

APRIL 2026
THEATLANTIC.COM

A

The Atlantic
EST. 1857



MY
YEAR AS A
DEGENERATE
GAMBLER

By McKay Coppins

V



REACH FOR THE CROWN





THE DAY-DATE



FOR AN OFFICIAL ROLEX JEWELER VISIT [ROLEX.COM](https://www.rolex.com)
ROLEX, OYSTER PERPETUAL AND DAY-DATE ARE © TRADEMARKS. NEW YORK

SPONSOR CONTENT

RANGE ROVER

This content is made possible by our sponsor and is independent of *The Atlantic's* editorial staff.



LINDSEY VONN

Champion Ski Racer

THE DRIVE TO LEAD

Clarity.

Discipline.

Perseverance.

Leadership isn't defined by a single win—it's built through resilience, clarity, and the courage to begin again. Lindsey Vonn embodies that sentiment. Raised in Minnesota, she learned from her father that integrity mattered as much as speed. At seven, she began racing; a decade later, she was among the best in the world. Every milestone since has been shaped by vision, discipline, and belief. Qualities that, like a finely tuned Range Rover, balance power with purpose.

Through triumphs and injuries, victories and comebacks, Vonn has redefined perseverance. "Perseverance is never giving up," she says. "It's showing up again and again; just never quitting." Her determination has motivated countless young athletes and fueled her work with the Lindsey Vonn Foundation, inspiring, and helping, girls chase their own dreams.

Now, after six years of retirement and a partial knee replacement, Vonn is writing her next chapter. It's a return that proves strength evolves and passion endures.

Curious, bold, and endlessly driven, Vonn continues to lead with perseverance; an ethos shared with Range Rover, where capability meets confidence, and every journey begins with vision.

Continue the drive with Lindsey Vonn.

Visit theatlantic.com/drivetolead
or scan here →





Soft botics

At Carnegie Mellon we are inventing sensory intelligence to enhance human experiences in real time. A bike rider receives heightened awareness of the space and traffic behind and surrounding the bike through camera images that are transferred into pulsations felt through the clothing. No cell phone or screen is required.

This enables the rider to make quicker, more informed decisions and navigate safely. Softbotic technology is expanding the human sensory experience today in innovative ways.

Bringing robotics into everyday life.



Carnegie Mellon University
College of Engineering

Learn more:





Features

20

The Unbearable Lightness of Signalgate

Nearly a year after a national-security scandal erupted on my iPhone, no one in the Trump administration has faced serious consequences.

By Jeffrey Goldberg

26

COVER STORY

Sucker

My year as a degenerate gambler

By McKay Coppins

42

Leaving the United States Behind

The Cruz family spent years building a life in New York. Then the risks of staying became too great.

By Caitlin Dickerson

52

Struck

What getting hit by lightning does to the body and mind

By Jacob Stern

70

Insatiable

Indoor rain, windows to nowhere, and reanimated nuclear reactors—how the race to power AI is remaking the physical world

By Matteo Wong



62

THE WOMEN OF AVENGER FIELD

By Ellen Cushing

*They bravely served as pilots in World War II.
Then America forgot them.*

Members of the Women Airforce Service Pilots program, wearing flight gear and parachutes

Front

8
The Commons
Discussion & Debate

Dispatches

11
OPENING ARGUMENT
The Cost of Not Having Health Insurance
My aunt couldn't afford to go to the hospital. She ended up there anyway.
By Jenisha Watts

14
TECHNOLOGY
My Self-Driving Car Crash
The Tesla was driving perfectly—until it wasn't.
By Raffi Krikorian

17
POLITICS
That 1930s Feeling
How dark fringes reached the center of the Republican Party
By Tom Nichols

Culture & Critics

78
OMNIVORE
Robyn Is Still Dancing On Her Own
The queen of popitism takes up motherhood and midlife desire.
By Spencer Kornhaber

82
BOOKS
The Last Days of Franco
Montserrat Roig's classic novel captures Barcelona on the cusp of unimaginable change.
By Colm Tóibín

86
BOOKS
Vigdis Hjorth's Family Secrets
The wildly popular Norwegian novelist returns again and again to a dark past.
By Honor Jones

89
BOOKS
The College-Educated Working Class
Can a generation of graduates frustrated by their economic prospects change American labor politics?
By George Packer

93
Misrule Music
A poem by Robert Pinsky

Back

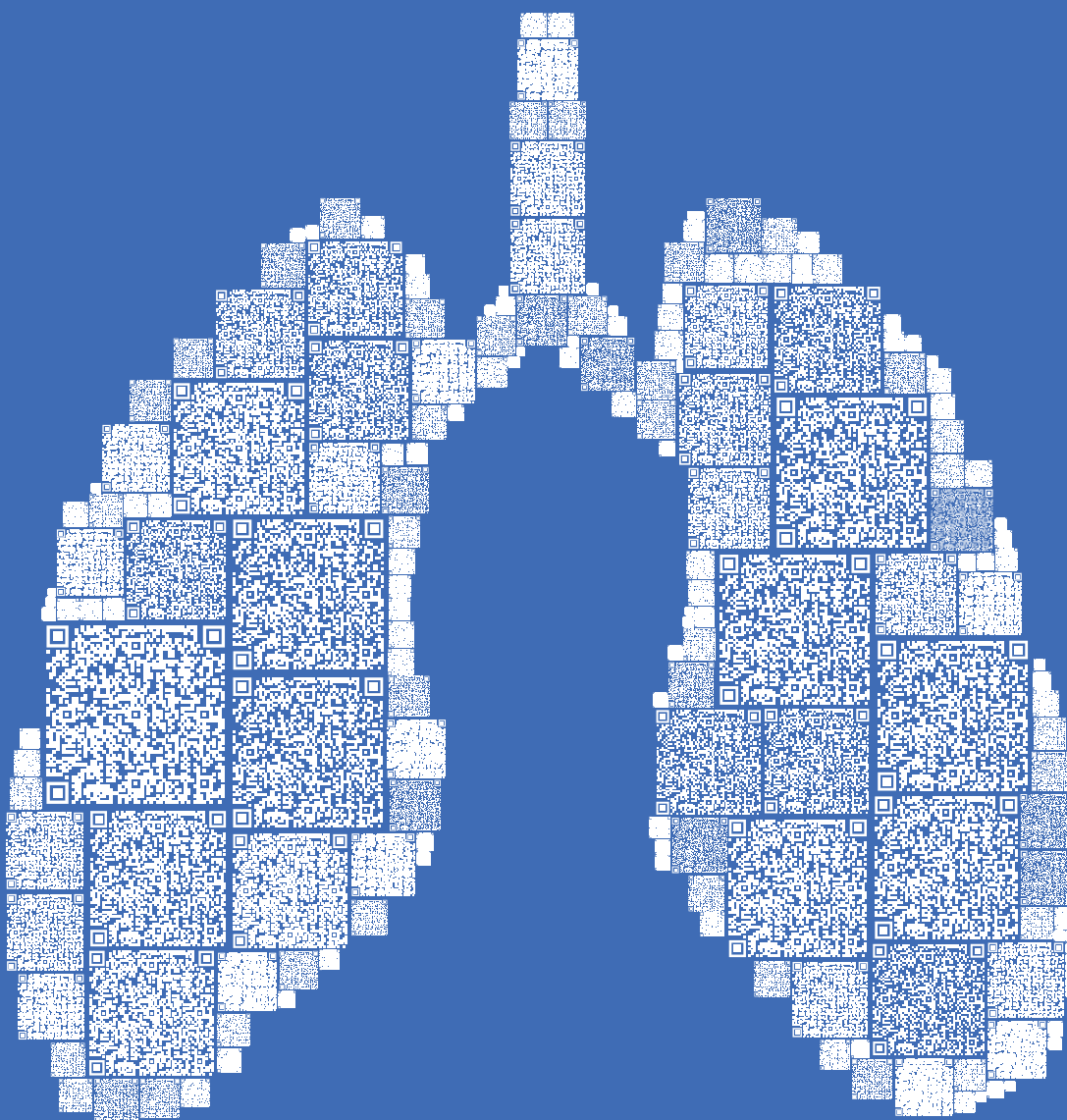
94
ESSAY
The City Where Coetzee Is God
Searching for the Nobel laureate in Cape Town, the city he left behind
By Gary Shteyngart

104
Caleb's Inferno
A crossword by Caleb Madison

On the Cover

ILLUSTRATION BY COLIN HUNTER

RENDERING BY DANIELLE DEL PLATO



If you used to smoke, scan these lungs to see
if you should scan yours.

SavedByTheScan.org



Behind the Cover: In this month's cover story, "Sucker" (p. 26), McKay Coppins writes about his foray into sports gambling. Coppins wagered on games throughout the 2025–26 NFL season. He describes how betting changed his relationship to football—and his family—and considers the social costs of having

casinos in our pockets, in the form of now-ubiquitous betting apps. For our cover image, we inverted the magazine's "A" logo to create an ace of spades, a symbol of a quainter era of gambling, when the vice was still largely confined to remote desert cities.

— Colin Hunter, *Art Director*

THE

The Most Powerful Man in Science

In the January issue, Michael Scherer considered why Robert F. Kennedy Jr. is so convinced he's right.

Letters



I am a pediatrician who witnessed the rise of vaccine and science skepticism during the coronavirus pandemic, and I'm terrified by Robert F. Kennedy Jr.'s decimation of the Department of Health and Human Services, the CDC, and the

National Institutes of Health. Michael Scherer's article resonated with me. I am open-minded; I believe in integrative practices, and I agree that the medical establishment can be arrogant and unduly influenced by the pharmaceutical industry, which now funds so much of medical research. But I fully understand Scherer's frustration with his interminable discussions with Kennedy about scientific articles. I, too, have read articles about the benefits of weird diets or the dangers of vaccines, and tried to reason with my patients' parents about them—parents who didn't understand the meaning of statistical significance, or any of the scientific jargon used in the articles they would bring me.

But after reading about RFK Jr.'s 14-year battle with

drug addiction, his daily Alcoholics Anonymous meetings, and his admitting that he has had to "completely commit" himself "to a way of life" in AA, I was struck by his final words to the author: "Good health does not just come in a syringe." Very bad things happened to him and those around him due to the contents of syringes. I understand if he has a deep-seated skepticism of anything delivered through a needle. But even if his skepticism is understandable, as the head of the largest and most important civilian agency in the federal government, he must rely on facts, not fear.

David Gottsegen, M.D.
Belchertown, Mass.

Francis Collins, a former director of the National Institutes of

Health, had advice for dealing with people like Robert F. Kennedy Jr.: Try to understand the backstory of someone you don't agree with, in order to convince them that you have given them a fair hearing without trying to change their mind. I admire that Michael Scherer appears to have followed his advice.

RFK Jr. has raised many questions about the way the government has handled the problems of public health, and those questions deserve answers. But he has stubbornly and falsely alleged that no one has contradicted his research or his supposed "evidence." At a certain point, he has no right to be taken seriously by anyone who truly cares about public health.

Kirk S. Ray
Little Rock, Ark.



I am a retired infectious-disease physician. In his interviews with Michael Scherer, Robert F. Kennedy Jr. seemed to demand absolute certainty that all risk has been removed from a given treatment before a doctor can recommend it. If this were the case, we would be unable to recommend treatment for any disease. Certainty is impossible in medicine—that's why physicians speak in terms of risks and benefits. Even good old penicillin has its risks.

As for Kennedy's investigation into whether vaccines cause autism: He is directing millions of dollars toward one line of inquiry while neglecting other possible factors. We do epidemiological studies to test hypotheses. If there isn't a "signal" suggesting a link between two things, then why keep searching for one? Resources aren't limitless.

RFK Jr. isn't trained to think like a scientist or a physician. Ultimately, this isn't a battle of viewpoints or ideologies. It's a question of data—and we have reams of them, interpreted by credentialed statisticians.

Barbara McGovern, M.D.
Needham, Mass.

Upon finishing Michael Scherer's profile of Robert F. Kennedy Jr., I realized that he and Donald Trump are not strange bedfellows after all, despite

their initial differences in political affiliation. Both searched for issues that could lead them to the pinnacle of national power, and both found the same target: America's highly educated, cosmopolitan elite, which had written them off as unserious. The rest of us are watching their revenge play out on a grand scale.

John Yochelson
Bethesda, Md.

In April 1980, as a radio reporter with one year of experience, I interviewed Robert F. Kennedy Jr. in North Carolina. He was in the state campaigning for his uncle Ted Kennedy, who was running in the Democratic presidential primary. I remember RFK Jr., then only 26, as irascible—especially after I asked how he thought his uncle would explain the events of Chappaquiddick and the death of Mary Jo Kopechne to voters. He yelled at me and the interview ended abruptly. It was through that lens that I read Scherer's profile.

Forty-five years later, it seems that RFK Jr. has not changed. He still can't reflect. He is still irascible in his responses. His fixed belief remains: He is absolutely right about vaccines causing autism. He shows little understanding of what one can and cannot conclude from scientific research. It was his

cousin Caroline who labeled him a predator. "I would not contest it that much," Kennedy said, when reminded of his cousin's comments by Scherer. "Addiction is kind of narcissistic." His narcissistic personality persists, even beyond his addiction, and it's causing him to prey on parents desperately seeking answers about autism and chronic disease.

Sue Ferrara
Hamilton, N.J.

My childhood friend Susan, stricken with polio, was in an iron lung in 1946 when I was finally permitted to visit her. We were both 13. I remember being terrified at the sight, though we had desperately wanted to see each other. I was allowed to visit because she was not expected to live. Another friend of mine, Jack, was carefully isolated at home during a whooping-cough epidemic the next summer because he had rheumatic fever. He still contracted that severe and highly contagious bacterial infection. Susan was released from the iron lung after three months and lived to adulthood, though with physical disabilities; Jack died of heart failure at 19.

I'm sorry that Robert F. Kennedy Jr., who was born in 1954,

the year I turned 21, cannot envision those days. Or imagine the excruciating fear that enveloped my family in 1939, when my older sister Jane had measles. She was kept in a room with the shades and curtains tightly drawn to shut out any ray of light; similar cases were leaving children sightless. Jane recovered and lived into her 70s without vision problems; she was a painter.

These diseases that shadowed my childhood were all but eradicated as vaccines were developed—and now the secretary of health and human services seems to want to bring them back. Because he lives in some alternate reality that refuses to acknowledge what science and history have so clearly proved, 13-year-olds today will suffer needless disability and early death. Why our own health and humanity should have to be sacrificed at the altar of RFK Jr.'s stubborn misconceptions is beyond comprehension.

Fran Moreland Johns
San Francisco, Calif.

To respond to *Atlantic* articles or submit author questions to The Commons, please email letters@theatlantic.com. Include your full name, city, and state.

Correction: "The Man Who Broke Physics" (March) stated that no other figure skater besides Ilia Malinin has landed more than three quadruple jumps in competition. In fact, no one besides Malinin has landed more than four.

PROMOTION

The Atlantic ACROSS AMERICA

A TOUR OF ALL 50 STATES

In 1857, *The Atlantic's* founders wrote that their magazine would make a sincere and honest effort to represent and champion what they called “the American idea.”

The Atlantic will visit all 50 states in a series of events where we will surface and engage with the most urgent, complex, and distinctly American questions of the moment in the places where they are unfolding.



Explore More
TheAtlantic.com/atlantic-across-america

DISPATCHES

OPENING ARGUMENT

THE COST OF BEING UNINSURED

*My aunt couldn't afford
to go to the hospital.
She ended up there anyway.*

BY JENISHA WATTS

The day after Thanksgiving, I got a voice-mail. A woman identified herself as a doctor at the University of Louisville hospital: “I believe I may have one of your family members here.”

The message was hard to understand. Most of my family lives in Kentucky, so I didn’t know whom the doctor was referring to. I called the hospital, but kept getting put on hold. Then I tried my aunt—if someone was in trouble, she’d be the one to know. But she didn’t answer.

A few hours later, her son got in touch with me. My aunt was the one in the hospital. She’d had an aneurysm on the right side of her brain, and it had burst. The drainage tube the doctors used to stop the bleeding kept slipping loose; after three tries, they finally got it to stick. Only then could they do surgery. My cousin FaceTimed

me afterward, from the ICU. “Are you ready?” he asked. He angled the camera down to my aunt’s face, and I started sobbing like a sudden rainstorm.

A few days later, I got on a plane from Washington, D.C., to Kentucky and went straight to join my family at the hospital. We had always called my aunt “The Glamourina.” She wore feathered hats with sparkly shirts and experimented with different hairstyles: a butterscotch-blond cropped cut, an afro, a bob streaked with highlights. She paid for my first real manicure, when I was in high school. We wore matching striped shirts to the salon, and used an eyeliner pencil to draw fake moles above our lips, like Marilyn Monroe.

She is 58 now, and raised two kids as a single mother. She always treated me like one of her children, and I grew up to look more like her than like my own mom. When I’d talked with her the week before she ended up in the hospital, she’d asked me to play our favorite song, “I’m So Proud of You,” by Julie Anne Vargas. Now the top half of her head was shaved and staples ran in a ladder across it. IVs were taped to each arm, and a machine next to her bed was helping her breathe. She couldn’t speak. When she opened her eyes, they rolled.

Her older son was especially alarmed by how quickly she’d declined. He wanted the doctors to come into her room so they could explain what had happened. But one of our older relatives stopped him, saying that we couldn’t afford to make demands, let alone trouble, because “she don’t have a lick of health insurance.”

We knew that the hospital couldn’t deny her care, but we understood the tightrope

you walk when you don’t have money. All she could afford to be was grateful.

WE DON’T KNOW what caused my aunt’s aneurysm, but she’d had persistent headaches for months, and she’d been worried. Once, when she was driving, the left side of her body turned numb and

WE COULDN’T
AFFORD TO
MAKE DEMANDS,
LET ALONE
TROUBLE,
BECAUSE “SHE
DON’T HAVE A
LICK OF HEALTH
INSURANCE.”

her toes curled up. She pulled over but didn’t go to the hospital; she couldn’t afford it.

My aunt worked as a hair stylist at a salon for years. Most recently, she was the overnight caregiver for an elderly woman, but she had opted out of her employer-sponsored health insurance because she couldn’t afford the premium. She’d occasionally had coverage in the past, but it never guaranteed that she’d actually be able to afford health care. She called me once, defeated, because she was trying to fill a prescription at Walgreens and the pharmacy had flagged an issue with her insurance. She would need to pay out of pocket, and she didn’t have the \$134.89. She was often frustrated by spending long spells on hold with insurance agents, and was overwhelmed by the complexity of the plans.

My aunt’s experience with the health-care system is familiar to many Americans. In a

2023 survey by the Kaiser Family Foundation, nearly a quarter of adults said signing up for a plan was simply too confusing. Even those who have coverage may decide to delay or skip treatment because they can’t afford the out-of-pocket costs, resulting in emergency-room visits and hospitalizations that could have been prevented.

Some years, my aunt made so little money that she might have qualified for Medicaid, but not recently—the income cutoff if you’re single in Kentucky is \$1,835 a month. Some years, she bought coverage through the Affordable Care Act’s exchanges, but eventually she decided it was too expensive.

Many more people are now making that same decision. In 2025, the Republican-controlled Congress voted to let Biden-era subsidies in the ACA, which had helped some 22 million people afford their coverage, expire. Within just two weeks of the cutoff, at the end of December, enrollment had dropped by 1 million people. According to one group’s estimate, families are paying \$200, \$300, or \$1,000 more a month; many have seen their premiums double.

In January, President Trump released his proposal for a “Great Healthcare Plan,” which suggests that savings from the former subsidies could be sent directly to “eligible” Americans. But who would be eligible? The proposal makes no mention of the many people who don’t have coverage. Then, in February, the Trump administration released a list of 43 prescription drugs that Americans can buy for reduced prices. But some of these were already available at those prices or in generic forms, and they make up a tiny fraction of the drugs Americans

need; the prescription my aunt couldn’t afford, for instance, is not listed.

Nothing about Trump’s pronouncements changes the fact that millions more Americans will soon be stuck where my aunt was: in the middle—sometimes insured, sometimes uninsured, but always too poor to get the care they need.

AS I STARED at my aunt in the ICU, I noticed that her eyebrows were freshly waxed, and her nails had bleach-white French tips. Only the week before, she’d texted me about getting her nails done. It was an indulgence she rarely allowed herself: “Woo this pedi feels good. I haven’t had one since last year.” When I rubbed Vaseline on her chapped feet, I discovered her ruby-red toenails.

She could not have known that the decision to finally splurge a little on herself would be a conversation starter with the nurses, who complimented her on her nails and eyebrows. Her grooming signaled to them that she was someone who took care of herself, someone who deserved their attention and respect.

I drove to her house later that week to meet her younger son. We’d planned to check on her bills—to see if we could find her bank PIN or account information to make sure that her finances stayed on track. I found notebooks coated with her handwriting, a list of numbers down each page that looked like an unsolved equation. These, I realized, were her monthly expenses, along with details such as the confirmation codes for bills she’d paid. Stuffed inside one notebook was a pawn-shop notice, announcing its full ownership over an item she’d traded in.

For years, not having enough money nibbled at my aunt's health. She texted me about having severe pain in her back and breasts. She wrote that she had a "knot" in one breast—"I'm thinking just polyps." She lost a lot of weight and said she was feeling depressed. I suggested reaching out to a psychiatrist to ask for antidepressants. She wrote back: "That cost. That's why I need insurance." She was tired of pretending to be okay. After paying for her mortgage, water bill, Wi-Fi, car insurance, and other necessities each month, she'd usually be out of money. She was always transparent with me about her struggles, and sent photos of bills with disconnect notices: a letter from the energy company; an available checking balance of -\$59.70; a past-due payment, with the amount owed in bold. *Shutoffs have resumed. Make a \$172.75 payment today to get your account back on track.* She had small wins, such as finally paying off her car. But she still went back and forth to the payday-loan store.

As I sat next to her in the hospital, I couldn't help but feel guilty. For years, I had been sending her money when she asked, but sometimes I didn't. I would listen to her struggles and then go on with my life. I was grateful to be financially stable, but frustrated by being the financial rescuer for family members. I wanted to create boundaries, and to escape from the transactional, lopsided part of these relationships.

But I had not thought enough about how much she gave me—in every way she could. She posted about my accomplishments on Facebook no matter how small I considered them. She filled voids

for me: self-esteem booster, cheerleader, second mother. In 2014, she used all the money she had to fly to New York to see me graduate from Columbia. She was the only member of my family there. When my name was called and I walked across the stage, she cried so much that someone had to hand her a tissue.

wow. This is awesome." That night, I sent the video to my aunt. She wrote back at 2 a.m.: "Up looking at videos over n over. He was so excited." She was always trying to give to others, even though she never had enough for herself.

As individuals, and as a country, we tend to pay attention only when it's too late.

worth in America? Unfortunately, that determination has been made.

My aunt hasn't sat up or spoken since the aneurysm, and no one knows if she will again. In January, she was transferred from the hospital to a nursing home. She's supposed to go home soon, to be cared for by the family, who can't possibly



A few months ago, my son turned 4, and my aunt was determined to send him a gift. A manila envelope arrived at my apartment: She had mailed him five individually wrapped Hot Wheels cars and a Spider-Man birthday card. I recorded a video as my son stuffed his hand inside the envelope, pulling out each toy, saying, "Oh,

Americans who want to cut health-care spending don't seem to understand that access to preventive care saves not just lives, but also money. Perhaps my aunt's hospital stay could have been avoided if she'd been able to call a doctor and make an appointment, an option that so many of us take for granted. What is a life like my aunt's

give her the round-the-clock care she needs. She's not capable of worrying about health insurance at this point, but if she were, she wouldn't have to: Now that she's completely disabled, she qualifies for Medicaid. *A*

Jenisha Watts is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

MY SELF-DRIVING CAR CRASH

The Tesla was driving perfectly—until it wasn't.

BY RAFFI KRIKORIAN

The smell was strange. Sharp. Chemical. Wrong. The concrete wall was too close. My glasses were gone.

One of my kids was standing on the sidewalk next to our car—not crying, just confused.

The seat belt had held. The crumple zone had crumpled. The airbag had fired. Everything designed to protect bodies had done its job. But the car, a Tesla Model X, was totaled.

One Sunday last fall, my kids and I were on a drive we'd done hundreds of times, winding through the residential streets of the Bay Area to drop my son off at his Boy Scouts meeting. The Tesla was in Full Self-Driving mode, driving perfectly—until it wasn't.

What happened next, I've had to piece together. My memory is hazy, and some of it comes from one of my sons, who watched the whole thing unfold from the back seat. The car was making a turn. Something felt off—the steering wheel jerked one way, then the other, and the car decelerated in a way I didn't expect. I turned the wheel to take over. I don't know exactly what the system was doing, or why. I only know that somewhere in those seconds, we ended up colliding with a wall.

You might think I'd have known what to do in this situation. I used to run the

self-driving-car division at Uber, trying to build a future in which technology protects us from accidents. I had thought about edge cases, failure modes, the brittleness hiding behind smooth performance. My team trained human drivers on when and how to intervene if a self-driving car made a mistake. In the two years I ran the division, we had no injuries in our early pilot programs.

With my own Tesla, I started out using Full Self-Driving as the default setting only on highways. That's where it makes sense: You have clear lane markers and predictable traffic patterns. Then, one day, I tried it on a local road, and it worked well enough to become a habit.

Despite the accident, we were lucky. I walked away with a stiff neck, a concussion, a few days of headaches, and some memories I can't shake. The kids climbed out unharmed. Still, you could say I was crushed in what the researcher Madeleine Clare Elish calls the moral crumple zone. Some parts of a car are specifically designed to absorb damage in a crash, to protect the people inside. But when complex automated systems fail, Elish argues, it's the human users who take the blame. My car's Full Self-Driving mode logged flawless miles for three years, but when the accident happened, it was my name on the insurance report.

And the car has evidence. While you're at the wheel, it logs your hand position, your reaction time, whether you're keeping your eyes on the road—thousands of data points, processed by the vehicle. After crashes, Tesla has used these data to shift blame onto drivers. Following a fatal collision in Mountain View, California, in 2018, the company released a statement in which it noted that “the vehicle logs show that no action was taken.” (Tesla did not respond to a request for comment.)

While Tesla can access these records, it's not so easy for drivers. They can request their data, but some say they've received only fragments—and have had to go to court to get more. When plaintiffs in a Florida wrongful-death case sought key evidence of how one of Tesla's driver-assistance systems had failed, the company said it didn't have the data. The plaintiffs had to hire a hacker, who recovered them from a computer chip in the crashed vehicle. Later, Tesla stated that the data had been sitting on its own servers for years, and that the company failed to locate them by mistake. (A judge did not find “sufficient evidence” to conclude that Tesla had sought to hide the data.)

For now, the legal principle is simple: You're responsible. Though Tesla originally called its technology “Full

Self-Driving Capability,” the system is officially classified as “Level 2” partial driver automation, which means the human must remain in control at all times. Last year, a judge in California found Tesla's original name “unambiguously false” and misleading to consumers; Tesla now uses “Full Self-Driving (Supervised).” When a Tesla using a version of the technology killed two people in California in 2019, the car's own logs were used to prosecute the driver for failing to prevent the crash—not the company that designed the system. The company was held accountable in a major verdict for the first time only last year, when a jury found Tesla partly liable in the Florida wrongful-death case and awarded \$243 million to the plaintiffs.

A similar pattern is emerging everywhere algorithms are asked to work alongside humans: in our inboxes, our search results, our medical charts. These systems are building toward full automation, but they're not there yet. Computers still regularly make mistakes that require human oversight to avoid or fix.

Full Self-Driving works almost all of the time—Tesla's fleet of cars with the technology logs millions of miles between serious incidents, by the company's count. And that's the problem: We are



asking humans to supervise systems designed to make supervision feel pointless. A machine that constantly fails keeps you sharp. A machine that works perfectly needs no oversight. But a machine that works almost perfectly? That's where the danger lies. After a few hours of flawless performance, research shows, drivers are prone to start over-trusting self-driving systems. After a month of using adaptive cruise control, drivers were more than six times as likely to look at their phone, according to one study from the Insurance Institute for Highway Safety.

Tesla's description of Full Self-Driving on its website warns, "Do not become complacent," and I didn't think I was. Before my accident, I had my hands on the wheel. But I was driving the way the system had conditioned me to: monitoring instead of steering, trusting the software to make the right call. The familiarity curve bends toward complacency, and the companies building these systems seem to know it. I certainly did. I got lulled anyway.

Psychologists call this the vigilance decrement. Monitoring a nearly perfect system is boring. Boredom leads to mind-wandering. The research is unforgiving: Drivers need five to eight seconds to mentally reengage after an automated driving system gives control back. But emergencies can unfold much faster than that. The driver's physical reaction might be instantaneous—grabbing the wheel, hitting the brake. But the mental part? Rebuilding context, recognizing what's wrong, deciding what to do? That takes time your brain doesn't have.

The driver in the 2018 Mountain View accident had six seconds before his car steered itself into a concrete median. He never touched the wheel. That same year in Tempe, Arizona, sensors in an Uber test vehicle detected a pedestrian nearby with 5.6 seconds of warning. The safety driver looked up and took the wheel with less than a second left. By then, it was just physics.

In my case, I did take action before my accident. But I was asked to snap from passenger back to pilot in a fraction of a second—to override months of conditioning in the time it takes to blink. The logs would show that I turned the wheel. They wouldn't show the impossible math.

I DON'T KNOW enough about what actually happened during my accident to say that Tesla's technology crashed the car. But the problem is bigger than one company's self-driving system. It's about how we're building every AI system, every algorithm, every tool that asks for our trust and trains us to give it. The pattern is everywhere: Condition people to rely on the system. Erode their vigilance. Then, when something breaks, point to the terms of service and blame them for not paying attention.

My car didn't warn me when it was confused. Chatbots don't, either; they deliver their results in the same confident voice, whether they're right or hallucinating. They perform expertise, even when the sources they cite are dubious or fabricated. They use technical language in an authoritative tone. And we believe them, because why wouldn't we? They've been right so many times before.

Cars train us mile by mile; AI trains us week by week. In week one, you read a chatbot's output carefully. By week three, you're copying and pasting without reading. The errors don't disappear, but your vigilance does. So does your judgment, until one day you realize that you can't remember which ideas in a memo were yours and which were generated by AI. What does it say about us that we've handed over our thinking so willingly?

When my car failed, it was immediate and palpable. With chatbots, the failure is silent and invisible. You find out about it later, if at all—after the email is sent, the decision made, the code shipped. By the time you catch the mistake, it's already out there with your name on it. When the system works, you look efficient. When it fails, your judgment is questioned, sometimes with catastrophic consequences. In 2023, a New York lawyer was sanctioned for citing six cases that didn't exist. ChatGPT had invented them, but he'd trusted it, and the court blamed him, not the tool. Because a chatbot never gets fired.

We're experiencing an uncanny valley of autonomy. Computer systems aren't just almost human; they are almost capable of working on their own. When they fail, someone has to absorb the cost. Right now, that someone is us. But when we pay for a self-driving car or an AI tool, we think we're buying a finished product, not signing up to test a work in progress.

This "almost" phase isn't a brief transition. It's the product—one that will be with us for years, maybe decades. So it's important to notice the patterns. When an AI system

never admits uncertainty, or when a car's marketing says "self-driving" but the fine print says "driver responsible," that's a warning sign. When you realize that you haven't really been paying attention for the past 10 miles, or the past 10 auto-composed emails, that's the trap.

Things don't have to be this way, but they won't change unless consumers see the situation clearly and refuse to accept it. We should reject the deal we've been handed—the one where the terms of service become a shield for companies and a sword against users. We should demand that companies share the risk they're enticing us into taking. If they design for complacency, they should get some of the blame when their product fails.

This isn't a utopian goal. In July 2025, the Chinese car-maker BYD announced that it would pay for the damage caused by crashes involving its self-parking feature, sparing the driver's insurance and record. It's only one company, and only one feature, but it proves that accountability is a choice. Other businesses can be persuaded to opt in, too.

My kids were in the back seat when I had my car accident. One day, they'll have their own cars and use AI in ways that I can't even imagine yet. The systems they inherit will be built either to elevate them or to lull them and blame them when things go wrong. I want them to notice when they're being trained. I want them to ask who absorbs the cost, and the damage. *A*

Raffi Krikorian is the chief technology officer of Mozilla.



THAT 1930s FEELING

How dark fringes reached the center of the Republican Party

BY TOM NICHOLS

Over the past few months, during his agency's chaotic crackdowns in Chicago and Minneapolis, the U.S. Border Patrol chief Greg Bovino has worn an unusual uniform: a wide-lapel greatcoat with brass buttons and stars along one sleeve. It looks like it was taken right off the shoulders of a Wehrmacht officer in the 1930s. Bovino's choice of garment is more than tough-guy cosplay (German media noted the aesthetic immediately). The coat symbolizes a trend: The Republicans, it seems, have a bit of a Nazi problem.

By this, I mean that some Republicans are deploying Nazi imagery and rhetoric, and espouse ideas associated with

the Nazi Party during its rise to power in the early 1930s. A few recent examples: An ICE lawyer linked to a white-supremacist social-media account that praised Hitler was apparently allowed to return to federal court. Members of the national Young Republicans organization were caught in a group chat laughing about their love for Hitler. Vice President J. D. Vance shrugged off that controversy, instead of condemning the growing influence of anti-Semites in his party. (In December, at Turning Point USA's conference, Vance said, "I didn't bring a list of conservatives to denounce or to deplatform.")

Even federal agencies are modeling Nazi phrasing. The Department of Homeland

Security used an anthem beloved by neo-Nazi groups, "By God We'll Have Our Home Again," in a recruitment ad. The Labor Department hung a giant banner of Donald Trump's face from its headquarters, as if Washington were Berlin in 1936, and posted expressions on social media such as "America is for Americans"—an obvious riff on the Nazi slogan "Germany for the Germans"—and "Americanism Will Prevail," in a font reminiscent of Third Reich documents.

Trump, of course, openly pines to be a dictator. In his first term, he reportedly told his chief of staff, General John Kelly, that he wished he had generals who were as loyal as Hitler's military leaders. (The

president was perhaps unaware of how often the führer's officers tried to kill him.) More recently, the White House's official X account supported Trump's pursuit of Greenland by posting a meme with the caption "Which way, Greenland man?" That is not merely a clunky turn of phrase; it's an echo of *Which Way Western Man?*, the title of a 1978 book by the American neo-Nazi William Gayley Simpson, a former Presbyterian minister who called for America to expel its Jewish citizens.

The people pushing such trash are offended by the accusation that they are pantomiming Nazis. "Calling everything you dislike 'Nazi propaganda' is tiresome," a DHS spokesperson told *Politico*. But when even Laura Loomer—conspiracy theorist and ardent Trump supporter—says on social media that "the GOP has a Nazi problem," *then perhaps the GOP has a Nazi problem*.

AS A FORMER Republican, I'm aware that the American conservative movement has spent generations fighting off intrusions from the far right, including the John Birchers and the Ku Klux Klan. But I am still surprised and aggrieved by how quickly 21st-century Nazism has found a home in the party of Lincoln. In 1991, President George H. W. Bush repudiated the former Klan leader David Duke, who was running as a Republican to be Louisiana's governor. Today, Trump and his party haven't bothered to even pretend to be appalled by the degenerates gathering under the GOP aegis.

The U.S. Border Patrol chief Greg Bovino in Minneapolis on January 15, 2026

So how did a major American political party become a safe space for such people?

When I first joined the GOP, in 1979, the party around me did not seem hospitable to Nazis. A liberal Black Republican, Edward Brooke, had just finished two terms as our junior senator from Massachusetts; the liberal Republicans Lowell Weicker and John Chafee represented Connecticut and Rhode Island, respectively. In college, I worked in the Massachusetts state House for our hometown representative, a young and principled working-class Democrat (my GOP membership was not a disqualifier; imagine that). I got to know Republican legislators on Beacon Hill because they were close friends with my Democratic boss. Party affiliations were about political disagreements among Americans, not markers of antithetical worldviews.

I was, like many people then, a resolute ticket-splitter, voting often for local Democrats but always for Republican presidents, because I believed the national GOP was a moderate institution. Ronald Reagan, for example, disappointed the far right and his evangelical base by reducing nuclear weapons, leaving abortion rights largely untouched, and granting mass amnesty to undocumented immigrants (something I objected to at the time).

I first encountered the fringe elements of the conservative base in 1990, when I went to work in the U.S. Senate for John Heinz of Pennsylvania. I remember fielding an angry phone call from a constituent who grilled me about whether the senator was part of a globalist one-world-government conspiracy.

The country and the GOP were in the hands of Bush, the ultimate moderate, but extremists were making inroads to power. The populist demagogue Pat Buchanan, crusading against modernity and multiculturalism, challenged Bush in 1992 and garnered 23 percent of the Republican-primary vote. Bush, in turn, gave him

WAS THIS
A RADICAL,
UNPREDICTABLE
METAMORPHOSIS,
OR WAS A FASCIST
TENDENCY
LATENT IN THE
DNA OF THE
PARTY?

the stage at the Republican National Convention in Houston. Buchanan's speech, which envisioned a "religious war" for the country, shocked many Americans.

A few years later, Representative Newt Gingrich of Georgia carried Buchanan's culture war into the House speakership. For Gingrich, politics was solely about winning; his scorched-earth approach treated opponents as enemies and compromise as treason. He wanted votes, and wasn't concerned about who was animated by his viciousness.

Gingrich was eventually driven from the speakership; Buchanan left the Republican Party to run under the

Reform Party, and then faded from public life. But an example had been set of welcoming extremism (extreme ideology, extreme tactics) for the sake of winning.

Later Republican presidential nominees—good men such as John McCain and Mitt Romney—represented the moderate coalition that had brought people like me into the party. As they stood in the center of the GOP tent, they began to see who was now lurking in the back. In 2008, the nation saw too, when McCain had to defend Barack Obama as a "decent family man" to a delusional town-hall participant who had obviously imbibed racist right-wing propaganda.

Soon after McCain's loss to Obama, the Tea Party movement barreled into American politics. I was among those appalled by the Tea Partiers' juvenile public behavior and anti-government nihilism; others believed they represented a new grassroots movement and the future of the party. In the end, their revolt against government bailouts soured into a giant yawp of anger at the first Black president. By the time Romney was running against Obama, in 2012, Trump had launched his political career by pushing the "birther" lie, which capitalized on racial animus toward the 44th president. Rather than try to push Trump out of the tent, Romney accepted his endorsement. McCain came to be viewed as a traitor by the Republican base; Trump made that permissible by mocking his war-hero status.

In his third run for office, Trump expanded his vote share despite embracing fascist themes of xenophobia, nationalism, and glorification

of violence. I didn't want to see what was happening to the Republican Party, until the durability of Donald Trump made it impossible to ignore.

WAS THIS A radical, unpredictable metamorphosis, or was a fascist tendency latent in the DNA of the party? To better understand the GOP in the years before I joined it, I arranged a Zoom call with Stuart Stevens, a native Mississippian and former Republican operative. Stevens, several years older than I am, joined the Republicans in his youth rather than the segregationist local Democrats, then bolted from the party because of Trump. I asked Stevens to tell me when and where the GOP went wrong, and whether the devolution into a haven for Nazis was inevitable.

For Stevens, racism is the original sin of the modern Republican Party. White voters were alienated by the passage of the Civil Rights Act in 1964 and the violence around the 1968 Democratic primaries. As Black voters deserted Republicans, the segregationist George Wallace proved with his '68 presidential run that white southerners were up for grabs. Richard Nixon made a cunning and cynical calculation to sweep up those disaffected white voters, using appeals to "law and order" to stoke racial anxiety. By the 1970s, the GOP was the de facto white party in the United States.

Nixon and Reagan held racist views, as did many men of their generation. (Nixon was also an anti-Semite.) But they did not govern as racists, and they certainly weren't Nazis; neither was Gingrich, Buchanan, or any national

Republican over the past half century. But years of racial pandering had created a too-big tent, enlarged in the name of electoral expediency, that offered dark corners for despicable ideologies.

Political realignment also made the GOP vulnerable to extremism. Democrats became appealing to wealthy suburbanites. Republicans, whose voters were now less educated and more working-class, gained among white voters in rural areas and the Rust Belt. Gerrymandering helped turn red districts redder and blue districts bluer. Democrats' more diverse constituencies were a built-in trip wire against politicians who cozied up to extremists, while Republican-primary candidates—influenced by the rise of talk radio, Fox News, and the Tea Party—were not subjected to serious moderate challengers. Unprincipled and bizarre candidates could now thread a path to victory in ruby-red districts.

Critics of the GOP have long argued that something like the Trump movement, and the emergence of a new American Nazism, was inevitable—that conservatism, as a belief system, inevitably decays into fascism. Stevens, when he left the party, wrote a book with a bitter title: *It Was All a Lie*. When I told him how often people quote his title to argue that conservatism itself was a lie, he rolled his eyes. “We conservatives were right about everything,” Stevens told me. “Especially about the importance of character.”

I asked the writer Geoffrey Kabaservice, who has chronicled the decline of Republican moderates, whether the fall of the GOP was preordained, and why conservatism, once a

moralizing movement, became so vulnerable to figures without moral character.

“I don’t happen to believe that conservatism is one of those doctrines that is flawed from the get-go,” Kabaservice told me, “and certainly not in the American context, in which conservatism is a variation on core liberal principles.” In that sense, he said, Reaganism, the strongest vehicle of 20th-century American conservatism, didn’t lead directly to Trumpism—not least because Trump’s vulgar populism is “a repudiation of conservatism.”

But Reagan’s dominance of the party may have indirectly set the stage for Trump. Kabaservice brought up the Prussian statesman Otto von Bismarck, who created a balance-of-power system that worked only because it relied on Bismarck’s personal influence and political genius; it collapsed without him. Likewise, Kabaservice argued, Reagan enjoined his party to leave room in the tent for moderates and to avoid ideological litmus tests, but the GOP needed Reagan’s “personal magnetism” to keep his followers from spiraling into hyper-partisanship, or even political fratricide.

Without Reagan, the Reaganite coalition began to dissolve in the face of Buchanan’s angry populism and Gingrich’s cold opportunism. The Republican Party, as an institution, weakened over time, until it could be hijacked by an aspiring dictator. Republican leaders who warned against Trump in 2016—senators such as Ted Cruz, Lindsey Graham, and Mike Lee—soon discarded conservative principles to protect their jobs. Their eager amorality has allowed extreme elements to use the GOP as a

vehicle for bigotry and rage. Racism and hate are now structural parts of the Republican Party, replacing consensus, compassion, and compromise. Trump started his second presidency by pardoning the insurrectionists who’d wanted to unlawfully extend his first. Little wonder that fascists and other miscreants feel welcome.

Conservatives will complain that Democratic Party leaders have often tolerated their own extremists. People on the right point to radical professors lionizing Angela Davis, a Communist Party figure who was once on the FBI’s most-wanted list, or a future president socializing with Bill Ayers, who co-founded a Marxist militant organization and participated in bombings of the U.S. Capitol and the New York Police Department headquarters. Ayers may have casually socialized with a 30-something Barack Obama, but he did not get an office in the West Wing 15 years later. And no one on the left has shown up to work dressed like a conquering Nazi general swanning through the streets of Smolensk, the way Bovino did in the Midwest.

Some Republicans lament these developments and still hold fast to conservative principles and policy ideas. But their party has laid out a welcome mat for an ideology that Americans once had to defeat in combat, at the cost of millions of lives. If wannabe Nazis now confidently roam the halls of power—and the streets of American cities—it is because Republican leaders have made them feel at home.

WHAT CAN AMERICANS do in the face of moral rot in a major political party? The only short-term answers are shaming,

shunning, and mockery—and punishment at the polls. Decent citizens must ostracize those among them who toy with Hitlerism. Americans—especially journalists—should resist becoming inured to fascist rhetoric. No one should rely on euphemisms about “extreme” comments or “fiery” speeches. Call it what it is: Nazi-like behavior.

When a Gen Z Republican focus group has 20-somethings talking about how Hitler “was a great leader,” even if “what he was going for was terrible,” something is amiss not only in the Republican Party but also in America’s homes, schools, and neighborhoods. Some of these trolls are merely pasting swastikas on their nihilism, but their ideological sincerity is irrelevant. As Kurt Vonnegut wrote in *Mother Night*, his 1961 novel about a man posing as a Nazi: “We are what we pretend to be, so we must be careful about what we pretend to be.”

Whatever their intentions, some Americans are expressing or abetting ancient hatreds, smirking at the mention of Hitler, and plastering public spaces with images that Allied soldiers once tore from the walls of destroyed German cities. Political leaders who encourage or tolerate such scoundrels should be driven from office.

The Republicans have a Nazi problem, yes. But this means that the United States also has a Nazi problem. The responsibility for defeating it in the 21st century falls, as it did in the 20th, to everyone—of any party or creed—who still believes in the American idea. *A*

Tom Nichols is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

Pete Hegseth
We are currently clean on
OPSEC. Godspeed to our
Warriors.

19m



Michael Waltz



30m



John Ratcliffe
A good start

2:36 PM



The Unbearable Lightness of Signalgate



MAR
Good Job Pete and your team!!

5:14 PM



S M
Great work all.
Powerful start.

5:18 PM



Susie Wiles
Kudos to all - most particularly
those in theater and CENTCOM!
Really great. God bless.

5:21 PM



TG
Great work and effects!

6:35 PM

Nearly a year after a national-security scandal erupted on my iPhone, no one in the Trump administration has faced serious consequences. **By Jeffrey Goldberg**



THE UNIFORM CODE of Military Justice serves as the criminal-justice framework for America's armed forces. It covers offenses recognized by civilian law as well as crimes and infractions unique to the military, from insubordination to cowardly conduct. The code contains 158 articles; the *Manual for Courts-Martial* itself runs nearly 1,000 pages. It is an obvious truth that discipline, morale, and order can be maintained in military formations only if everyone—from four-star generals to the youngest “boot” privates—is held equally accountable for their actions.

A cursory review of recent courts-martial suggests that the enforcers of military discipline don't miss much. In December, a Marine private first class was convicted of “contempt or disrespect towards a noncommissioned or petty officer, and disrespect towards a superior commissioned officer in command.” The private was held in confinement for five days and was reduced in rank. In September, an Air Force lieutenant was convicted of engaging in conduct “unbecoming an officer” after drinking on duty and cursing superior officers. He was sentenced to 30 days of confinement and received a presumably career-ending reprimand. In November, a senior airman, a medical specialist, was found guilty of failing to “safeguard protected health information from unauthorized disclosure.” She was sentenced to one month of confinement, and received a temporary pay reduction and a reprimand. Also in September, an Army specialist was convicted of disrespecting a superior by “interrupting her when she was speaking and then walking away,” among other charges. A military judge reduced the specialist's rank and prevented her from leaving her military facility for 14 days.

Many soldiers are punished for infractions related to the handling of their weapons—the unfortunate Louisiana National Guardsman who recently left his rifle in the bathroom of a hotel bar could face a court-martial. And members of the armed forces are also punished for mishandling information. The military is necessarily unforgiving of those who violate operational security—“loose lips sink ships,” in the age-old shorthand. That is why seemingly quotidian bits of information—the dates and times that units are moving from one base to another, for instance—are held so closely. According to the UCMJ's Article 92, the punishments for the release of unauthorized information vary, but could include two years' imprisonment. A unit commander, operations-security guidance states, must “protect from unauthorized disclosure any sensitive and/or critical information to which they have personal access.” In October of last year, a retired Army colonel, Kevin Charles Luke, who was at the time a civilian Department of Defense employee, was found guilty of sending a photo of a classified email to a woman he'd met online. The email contained information about

an upcoming military operation. In early February, Luke was sentenced to two years in prison for his crime.



IT HAS BEEN almost a year since the national-security scandal that came to be known, inevitably, as Signalgate erupted on my iPhone, and I've been thinking through its consequences. Michael Waltz, the official who invited me into a Signal chat group whose members included most of America's national-security leadership, was removed as the president's national security adviser. But he soon received (what is to my mind, at least) a promotion, and is now serving as U.S. ambassador to the United Nations. The Signal Foundation, the nonprofit organization that owns the messaging app, saw a dramatic increase in usage following the scandal. *The Atlantic* itself saw an unparalleled burst of subscription growth, and I personally managed to avoid prison and extract a brand-new iPhone from my employer. President Trump suffered no negative consequences from Signalgate. In fact, he found it professionally riveting, carefully studying the way in which *The Atlantic* temporarily dominated the news cycle. (He also suggested to me, in an Oval Office meeting that took place as the scandal was subsiding, that he should receive more credit for *The Atlantic*'s success than I have granted him.)

As for Pete Hegseth, the secretary of defense who shared what were quite obviously military secrets in a discussion, held on a privately run messaging app, that he didn't even know included a journalist—well, more on him later.

Allow me to recount, as efficiently as possible, the sequence of implausible events here. On March 11 of last year, I was invited to connect on Signal by a user purporting to be Waltz. Soon after, I was invited to a chat called the “Houthi PC small group.” *PC* refers to *principals committee*, which included people identified as Vice President J. D. Vance, Secretary of State Marco Rubio, Hegseth, CIA Director John Ratcliffe, and Tulsi Gabbard, the director of national intelligence.

I am suspicious by profession, and so I assumed that this was an entrapment scheme, or a foreign-intelligence-service operation, or a simulation beyond easy comprehension. But I know Waltz (please keep this fact in mind), and I have reported on national-security matters for decades, so the invitation wasn't entirely outlandish. (A reasonable guess is that my telephone number can be found—or could be found, before Signalgate—in the contact lists of seven or eight members of the 18-person “small group.”)

The chat itself was highly realistic, and fascinating. I watched as a substantive debate was held over whether the U.S. should immediately launch strikes against Houthi-terrorist targets in Yemen. The vice president, quasi-isolationist in outlook, argued against such strikes, noting that Europe—not his favorite continent—would benefit disproportionately. A little while later, the chat participant identified as Hegseth wrote, “Waiting a few

weeks or a month does not fundamentally change the calculus,” though he added, “We are prepared to execute, and if I had final go or no go vote, I believe we should.”

The colloquy came to a sudden end when the user “S M,” whom I took to be the Trump confidant Stephen Miller, wrote, “As I heard it, the president was clear: green light, but we soon make clear to Egypt and Europe what we expect in return.”

That was that. Hegseth wrote, “Agree,” and the dissident vice president said nothing. And then came the day of the Yemen strikes. At 11:44 a.m. on Saturday, March 15, I was at a supermarket—a Safeway in the Chevy Chase neighborhood of Washington, D.C.—when the following alert came in over Signal from Hegseth: “TEAM UPDATE.” What followed was information that, had it been seen by an enemy of the United States, could have been used to kill American military and intelligence personnel. Hegseth promised that Yemen would be attacked within two hours.

I’ve seen strange things in my career, but nothing quite like this. I stayed in my car in the Safeway parking lot and waited. I took screenshots of the chat and searched X and other platforms for news of U.S. military activity. Hegseth had said in the chat that the first detonations would be felt at 1:45 p.m. eastern time. At approximately 1:55 p.m., credible news reports started appearing about an attack.

In the chat, congratulations began to pour in. Waltz posted three emoji: a fist, an American flag, and fire. Steve Witkoff, Trump’s all-purpose, in-over-his-head global-conflict negotiator, responded with five emoji: two praying hands, a flexed bicep, and two American flags. Later, the Houthi-run Yemeni health ministry reported that at least 53 people had been killed in the attack (the number has not been confirmed independently). The Houthis are despicable terrorists, and in my opinion should be fought and defeated, but there was still something disturbing about the proliferation of emoji.

Proof that the chat was authentic forced me (and a growing number of advisers, sworn to secrecy) to make a choice. I was interested in exposing a security breach at the highest reaches of government; I was less interested in being accused of violating the Espionage Act. I would thus exit the chat later that same day. The Signal group would be alerted that I had left, so timing was important. That evening was the annual dinner of the Gridiron Club, at which Washington journalists host senior administration officials and members of Congress and make mainly mild fun of them from the stage. I heard that Waltz might be attending. I didn’t want the FBI raiding the dinner to seize my phone, so I waited until the end of the dinner to leave the chat. I spent the next hours awaiting recognition by the federal government that I was an apostate member of the “Houthi PC small group.”

But, nothing.

As a reporter, I was relieved; as a citizen, I was appalled by the violation of the first commandment of digital hygiene: Thou Shalt Know Who Is in Thy Group Chat.

The next week rushed by as we prepared the story for publication. I decided not to include some of the key operational details shared by Hegseth, Waltz, and Ratcliffe, the CIA director. I wanted to expose their incompetence without releasing information that

could hurt American troops. Early on Monday, March 24, I wrote to Waltz and Hegseth on Signal (of course) and then others by email, asking for confirmation and comment. I would learn that my requests set off a scramble in the White House. The National Security Council called an emergency meeting in the Situation Room, where the mood, as participants later described it to me, was one of incredulosity and anger. According to people who participated in the meeting, Alex Wong, who was then the principal deputy national security adviser, briefed officials, but he didn’t have much information. The White House counsel, David Warrington, asked, slowly and repeatedly, “How. Did. This. Happen?”

To their credit, White House officials quickly responded to me and confirmed the authenticity of the chat, and we published our story. These officials publicly argued that nothing secret or sensitive had been disclosed in the chat, which was nonsense, though their argument was helped by my decision to keep actual operational details out of the story. It was my word against theirs.

There were two main worries in the White House that morning. The first: Who would tell the president? It is my understanding that Susie Wiles, the White House chief of staff, instructed Waltz to tell Trump. (Wiles, we would later learn, disliked Waltz, who treated her poorly.) The second worry was that Hegseth, who was then flying to Hawaii aboard the Pentagon’s “Doomsday” plane, would be unable to muster a mature reaction to the story. Over the course of the day, officials spoke with him and texted him repeatedly while he was in the air, pleading with him to respond to questions by saying only that no classified information had been disclosed.

Temperament is destiny, and Hegseth responded frantically and defensively. “You’re talking about a deceitful and highly discredited so-called journalist who’s made a profession of peddling hoaxes time and time again,” he told reporters when he landed. He was referring to my reporting, in 2020 and in 2024, that Trump had made various contemptible comments about American troops, including that soldiers who fell in war were “suckers” and “losers,” and that Trump had also said, “I need the kind of generals that Hitler had.” (Multiple sources confirmed that Trump had made these comments, including John Kelly, a former White House chief of staff and a retired Marine general.)

Waltz also responded in a juvenile manner, telling Fox News the next day that I am “the bottom scum of journalists. And I



Former National Security Adviser Michael Waltz stands next to Jeffrey Goldberg at the French embassy in Washington, D.C., in 2021.

OPENING PAGES: MANDEL NGAN / AFP / GETTY; TOM WILLIAMS / CQ ROLL CALL / GETTY; ANDREW HARNIK / AFP / GETTY; KATELA BARTKOWSKA / GETTY; ERIC LEE / BLOOMBERG / GETTY; JALIN BOTSFORD / THE WASHINGTON POST / GETTY; KEVIN DIETSCH / GETTY. THIS PAGE: X / BERNARD HENRI LEVY.



Signalgate became fodder for memes and late-night comedy. The Trump administration had violated the first commandment of digital hygiene: Thou Shalt Know Who Is in Thy Group Chat.

know him in the sense that he hates the president, but I don't text him. He wasn't on my phone, and we're going to figure out how this happened." Waltz went on to say, "Of course I didn't see this loser in the group." (I believe this is what is known as "projection.") And he made a comment that provided material for a week's worth of late-night comedy. In explaining how I may have been added to the chat, he said, "Well, if you have somebody else's contact, then somehow it ... gets sucked in. It gets sucked in." (I recently learned that Wiles ordered Waltz to turn his phone over to Elon Musk—at the time a kind of one-man Genius Bar for White House officials—who reported back to Wiles that my phone number did not get "sucked in" to Waltz's phone.) Waltz also denied ever having met me, which is not true.

The ad hominem campaign by Waltz, Hegseth, Gabbard, the CIA, and White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt, combined with the assertion that no classified information had been included in the chat, presented me with a dilemma. I knew, of course, that the information I'd seen on my phone would ordinarily be judged top secret by the military, and I knew that the White House lies were meant to undercut the credibility of this magazine. I simply could not understand why the administration was goading me into releasing the full message chain, which would show that I was correct in stating that the information was highly secret.

We devised a plan: My colleague Shane Harris, who covers the intelligence community, and I would speak with leaders of the relevant government agencies and ask them if they objected to the publication of the rest of the messages. This written statement, from Leavitt, illustrates the sophistication of the administration's response: "As we have repeatedly stated, there was no classified information transmitted in the group chat," she wrote. "However, as the CIA Director and National Security Advisor have both expressed today, that does not mean we encourage the release of the conversation. This was intended to be an *[sic]* internal and private deliberation amongst high-level senior staff and sensitive information was discussed. So for those reason *[sic]*—yes, we object to the release."

We published a follow-up story and included the operational messages from Hegseth and Waltz. Here is the key text from

Hegseth: "TIME NOW (1144et): Weather is FAVORABLE. Just CONFIRMED w/CENTCOM we are a GO for mission launch." Centcom, or Central Command, is the military's combatant command for the Middle East. He continued:

"1215et: F-18s LAUNCH (1st strike package)"

"1345: 'Trigger Based' F-18 1st Strike Window Starts (Target Terrorist is @ his Known Location so SHOULD BE ON TIME)—also, Strike Drones Launch (MQ-9s)"

"1410: More F-18s LAUNCH (2nd strike package)"

"1415: Strike Drones on Target (THIS IS WHEN THE FIRST BOMBS WILL DEFINITELY DROP, pending earlier 'Trigger Based' targets)"

"1536: F-18 2nd Strike Starts—also, first sea-based Tomahawks launched."

"MORE TO FOLLOW (per timeline)"

"We are currently clean on OPSEC."

"Godspeed to our Warriors."

It would have been more accurate to have written, "We are currently clean on OPSEC, except that I'm sending this information to the editor of *The Atlantic*." To honestly believe that this information was not secret would require Hegseth to achieve Olympian levels of self-deception.

As all of this was happening, I was receiving messages from various military officials expressing disdain and anger that Hegseth refused to take responsibility. None of them went public with their outrage, however.

Other people did, including a modest number of Republicans. Senator Roger Wicker, the chair of the Senate Armed Services Committee, told reporters, "The information as published recently appears to me to be of such a sensitive nature that, based on my knowledge, I would have wanted it classified." Wicker and his Democratic counterpart, Senator Jack Reed, asked for a Pentagon investigation. I doubted that this would occur, because the administration was dismantling the inspector-general system across the federal government. But an investigation was soon said to be under way.

Only two administration figures did not seem especially alarmed or defensive during the controversy. The first was the vice president, who, we would later learn, made one final joking addition to the "Houthi PC small group" chain late on the night after my first story appeared: "This chat's kind of dead," he wrote. "Anything going on?"

The other was the president himself.

I was worried that the Signal story would complicate already complicated efforts by my colleagues Ashley Parker and Michael Scherer to get an interview with Trump. But instead—and this was



Rubble in Saada, Yemen, after a U.S. air strike. According to the Houthi-run Yemeni health ministry, the attacks discussed in the “Houthi PC small group” are believed to have left at least 53 people dead.

somewhat predictable to those of us who have paid close attention to Trump over the years—he not only granted them an interview, but invited me to participate. He could not resist the temptation to troll us along the way, however. Three hours before our scheduled visit to the Oval Office, he posted the following message on Truth Social:

Later today I will be meeting with, of all people, Jeffrey Goldberg, the Editor of The Atlantic, and the person responsible for many fictional stories about me, including the made-up HOAX on “Suckers and Losers” and, SignalGate, something he was somewhat more “successful” with. Jeffrey is bringing with him Michael Scherer and Ashley Parker, not exactly pro-Trump writers, either, to put it mildly! The story they are writing, they have told my representatives, will be entitled, “The Most Consequential President of this Century.” I am doing this interview out of curiosity, and as a competition with myself, just to see if it’s possible for The Atlantic to be “truthful.” Are they capable of writing a fair story on “TRUMP”? The way I look at it, what can be so bad—I WON!

When we entered the Oval Office, Trump said, “This will be very, very interesting. You think Biden would do this? I don’t think so.” (He was correct.)

“Thanks for announcing the interview on Truth Social,” I said.

“I wanted to put a little extra pressure on you,” he said. “But at the same time, you’ll sell about five times more magazines.”

I asked him, in the course of the interview, what he meant by “I will be meeting with, of all people, Jeffrey Goldberg.”

“Oh, you like that? I had to do that,” he said. “I had to explain to people. That’s my way of explaining to people that you’re up here, because most people would say, ‘Why are you doing that?’ I’m doing that because there is a certain respect.”

“Are you saying that Signalgate was real?” I asked.

“Yeah, it was real. And I was gonna put in something else, but I didn’t have enough time.” This led me to ask, out of sheer curiosity, “How long does it take you to write these?”

“Not long,” he answered. “I go quickly as hell. You’d be amazed. You’d be impressed. And I like doing them myself. Sometimes I dictate them out, but I like doing them myself. What I’m saying is that it became a big story. You were successful, and it became a big story.”

Me: “But you’re not saying that it was successful in the sense that it exposed an operations-security problem that you have to fix?”

Trump: “No. What I’m saying is, it was successful in that you got it out very much to the public. You were able to get something out. It became a very big story.”

I then asked him directly if there were any other possible lessons to be learned from the Signal breach.

The president answered, “I think we learned: Maybe don’t use Signal, okay?”



MONTHS WENT BY. We heard, again and again, that the Defense Department’s inspector general would investigate, but nothing came of it. Finally, in December, the report was released. It found what had seemed obvious from the outset: that Hegseth’s use of Signal to discuss bombing Yemen could have exposed U.S. tactics and endangered troops.

“The Secretary sent information identifying the quantity and strike times of manned U.S. aircraft over hostile territory over an unapproved, unsecure network approximately 2 to 4 hours before the execution of those strikes,” the report reads. “If this information had fallen into the hands of U.S. adversaries, Houthi forces might have been able to counter U.S. forces or reposition personnel and assets to avoid planned U.S. strikes. Even though these events did not ultimately occur, the Secretary’s actions created a risk to operational security that could have resulted in failed U.S. mission objectives and potential harm to U.S. pilots.”

The report concluded, however, that because the secretary of defense possesses “original classification authority”—meaning he has the power to declassify secrets at will—he wasn’t technically in violation of any rules governing secrecy, only rules banning the use of private messaging apps for official Pentagon business.

Hegseth claimed that the report cleared him of all wrongdoing. “No classified information,” he posted on social media. “Total exoneration. Case closed. Houthis bombed into submission. Thank you for your attention to this IG report.”

He had not always been so forgiving when it came to matters of operational security. In 2016, at the height of the furor concerning Hillary Clinton’s email server, Hegseth, then a Fox News host, said, “How damaging is it to your ability to recruit or build allies with others when they are worried that our leaders may be exposing them because of their gross negligence or their recklessness in handling information?”

The Department of Defense employs nearly 3 million people, uniformed and civilian. All are subject to rules and regulations governing many aspects of their behavior. Any one of them would have faced serious consequences for announcing, on an insecure messaging app, that the U.S. was about to send its pilots over enemy territory.

All except one. *A*

Jeffrey Goldberg is the editor in chief of The Atlantic.

IT'S TIME FOR YOUR NEW FAMILY TRADITION

**START A TRADITION YOUR CHILDREN
WILL BE PROUD TO CONTINUE.**

Your family's gift through Heifer International will provide a family in need with the tools and education to lift themselves out of poverty while letting you live out your values.



Your gift of a goat means Khushi can drink nutritious milk every morning.

INDIA



Thanks to your gift of a sheep, Cheikh will be able to pursue an education.

SENEGAL



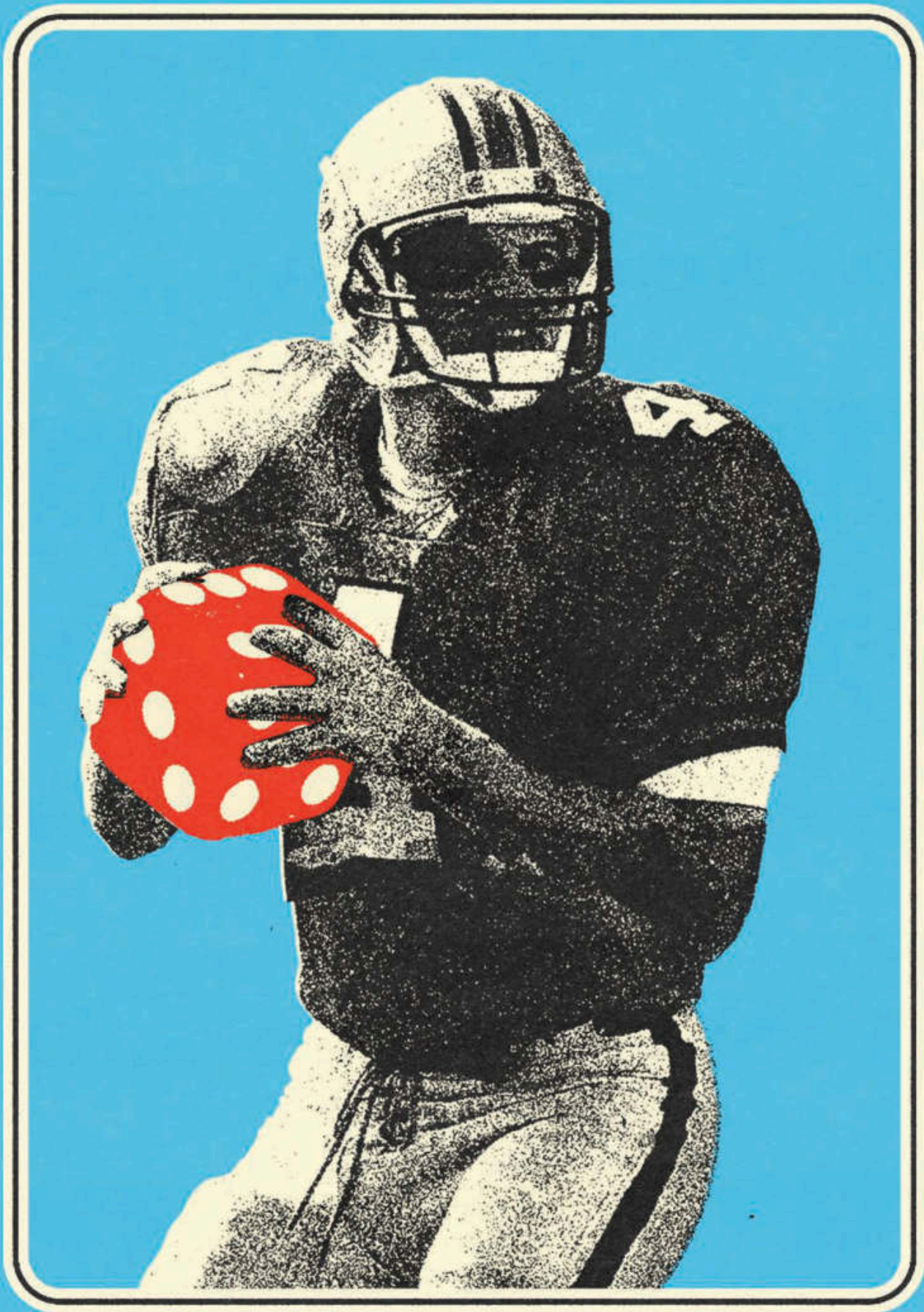
With your gift of garden seeds, Esli's parents can expand their cacao business.

HONDURAS




HEIFER[®]
INTERNATIONAL

START YOUR TRADITION AT [HEIFER.ORG/ATLANTIC](https://www.heifer.org/atlantic)

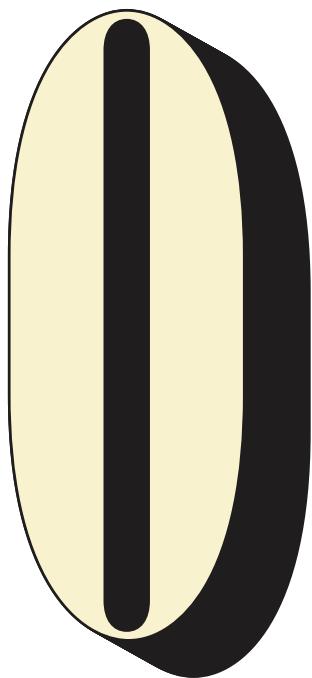


SUCKER

MY YEAR AS A
DEGENERATE GAMBLER

By McKay Coppins

Illustrations by Tyler Comrie



n a Thursday evening in September, I excused myself from the family dinner table and slipped into my bedroom. I didn't want my kids to see what I was about to do.

With the door locked behind me, I pulled out my phone and downloaded the DraftKings betting app. I felt a certain thrill as I typed in my debit-card information and deposited \$500. The first game of the NFL season was a few minutes away. Anything seemed possible.

I am not, by temperament, a gambling man. As a suburban dad with four kids, a mortgage, and a minivan, I'm more likely to be found

wrestling a toddler into a car seat than scouring moneylines or consulting betting touts. And as a practicing Mormon, I am prohibited from indulging in games of chance. Besides, I had always thought of gambling as a waste of time. This makes me an outlier among my generational peers: Since 2018, Americans have wagered more than half a trillion dollars on sports, and roughly half of men ages 18 to 49 have an active account with an online sportsbook.

When I set out to report on the sports-betting industry—its explosive growth, its sudden cultural ubiquity, and what it's doing to America—my editors thought I should experience the phenomenon firsthand. Mindful of my religious constraints, they proposed a work-around: *The Atlantic* would stake me \$10,000 to gamble with over the course of the upcoming NFL season. The magazine would cover any losses, and—to ensure my ongoing emotional investment—split any winnings with me, 50–50. Surely God would approve of such an arrangement, my editors reasoned, because I wouldn't be risking my own hard-earned money.

This spiritual loophole intrigued me. But for the sake of my soul, I decided I'd better consult a higher ecclesiastical authority than *The Atlantic's* masthead.

A few days later, I sat across from my bishop, explaining the experiment and watching a look of pastoral concern come over his face. After some consideration, he said (a bit tentatively, if I'm being honest), "I don't think you're doing anything wrong." He grasped the difference between gambling with my own money and using my employer's for research purposes. But he had also seen too many lives wrecked by vice to let me leave without a warning. He told me stories he'd heard about upstanding family men who had let an initially modest gambling habit ruin them, and a cautionary tale about a churchgoing lawyer who developed an unhealthy curiosity about sex work after handling a prostitution case and wound up devastating his family.

I promised the bishop that I would steer clear of slippery slopes. "This will really just be a journalistic exercise," I assured him.

Fifteen minutes before kickoff, I scrolled through the available wagers on DraftKings in wide-eyed bewilderment. Struggling to make sense of the terminology—*Profit boosts? Alternative spreads?*—I punched in bets almost at random. I bet that the Eagles would beat the Cowboys by at least nine points, based on the sophisticated premise that the Eagles had won the previous Super Bowl and the Cowboys had not. I placed a bet that Eagles quarterback Jalen Hurts would throw for more than 200 yards, and wagered on something called a "same-game parlay" that would pay out if both Hurts and running back Saquon Barkley scored touchdowns.

Then, after tucking in my kids for the night, I turned on the TV in our bedroom and settled in next to my wife, Annie.

Watching the game was unexpectedly stressful. Toggling among my five different bets—monitoring their progress, weighing live "cash out" options—left me feeling harried and sweaty. Four seconds into the game, I got a taste of the capriciousness of the enterprise when the Eagles' best defender inexplicably spit on the Cowboys' quarterback and got himself ejected. Had the Eagles' chances of beating the spread, and my chances at winning \$75, just been expectorated away?

But the experience was also strangely mesmerizing. For 200 bucks, I had purchased an artificial rooting interest in a game I had no reason to care about. I kept watching even after a weather delay pushed it late into the night, scrolling frenetically next to my sleeping wife in search of angles to exploit with late-game bets. Most of my bets ended up losing, but the long-shot Hurts-Barkley parlay hit, and when the game ended, I calculated that I was up \$20.

The next morning, I proudly shared the news with Annie, who high-fived me and immediately began to fantasize about how we would spend my winnings for the season. Could we replace our dying KitchenAid mixer? Remodel the kitchen pantry? Like so many wives before her, she had looked upon my foray into sports gambling with a bemused air of exasperation; now she was seeing a potential upside.

**EVER SINCE THE ADVENT
OF SPORTS, HUMANS
HAVE FOUND WAYS
TO LOSE MONEY
GAMBLING ON THEM.**

I laughed at her sudden enthusiasm—but I was starting to get ideas myself. I had made \$20 on my very first night of gambling. Scale up the wager sizes, multiply across all 272 games in the NFL season, throw in some NBA and college football, and I stood to make—what, \$10,000? \$20,000? More?

I knew, of course, that I wouldn't win every bet. But I didn't see the harm in dreaming. As Annie and I traded home-improvement fantasies, I tried my best not to dwell on the last thing the bishop had said to me: "Be careful."

EVER SINCE THE ADVENT of sports, humans have found ways to lose money gambling on them. Ancient Greeks wagered on the (occasionally rigged) early Olympic Games; Romans bet on chariot races and gladiatorial contests (also sometimes rigged). When 17th-century settlers arrived in North America, they encountered Native tribes placing high-stakes bets on "little brother of war," a precursor to lacrosse.

Throughout most of America's history, gambling was heavily regulated and generally discouraged. In 1631, Puritans banned games of chance in Plymouth Colony "under pain of punishment." In 1794, a Pennsylvania law prohibited "cockfighting, cards, dice, billiards, bowling, shuffleboard, horse racing, or any other type of gambling."

Laws varied by state and century, but the practice always came with a healthy social stigma, one rooted in millennia of accumulated wisdom. To humanity's great thinkers and leaders, gambling was an impediment to an ethical life (Aristotle), an invention of the devil (Saint Augustine), and a tax on the ignorant (Warren Buffett). It fostered selfishness and a something-for-nothing ethos that was poisonous to the soul. George Washington went so far as to warn that "every possible evil" could be tied to gambling: "It is the child of avarice, the brother of inequity, and the father of mischief." As a result, gambling was largely contained to certain disreputable corners of society, such as riverboats, red-light districts, and Nevada. For a time, it was the near-exclusive province of leg-breaking bookies and pin-striped criminals. Later, Native American reservations and offshore bookmakers got in on the action.

But professional sports leagues remained determined to keep gambling at a distance. High-profile scandals—the White Sox World Series fix in 1919, the Mafia-instigated point-shaving scheme at Boston College in 1978—had convinced commissioners that betting posed an existential threat to organized sports. In June 1990, officials from the major U.S. leagues testified before the Senate. Paul Tagliabue, then the NFL commissioner, captured their shared assessment: "Nothing has done more to despoil the games Americans play and watch than widespread gambling on them."

Two years later, Congress passed the Professional and Amateur Sports Protection Act, which effectively banned most sports betting outside Nevada. It remained the law of the land for decades.

Then, in 2012, New Jersey Governor Chris Christie, hoping to boost Atlantic City's flagging economy, signed a bill expanding sports betting to licensed locations in his state. The leagues sued New Jersey, and the case began winding its way through the federal courts. When I spoke with him recently, Christie recalled the thundering indignation that his bill provoked at the time. He

was once cornered at an event by Bill Bradley, the former Knicks player turned senator, and NBA Commissioner David Stern, who both shouted at him so loudly that other attendees started to gawk. "I'm not an animal to be bet on, like a horse," Bradley scolded Christie. "We're going to come after you with everything we've got," Stern warned.

"You know what, David?" Christie recalled telling Stern. "After I win this thing—and I'm going to win it—you're going to thank me."

G. K. Chesterton once wrote about two people who encounter a fence erected across a road. One of them demands that it be torn down; the wiser of the two responds that they should find out why it was put there in the first place before deciding on a course of action.

By 2018, Christie's case had landed before the Supreme Court, which overturned the federal ban on sports betting. Justice Samuel Alito, writing for the majority, made no effort to consider the public-policy rationale that had led Congress to make the law, or the cascading consequences of overturning it. He simply ruled that the Constitution empowers states, not the federal government, to regulate gambling, and scrapped the entire legal framework that had been in place for the past quarter century. No one involved—not Alito; nor the five justices who joined him; nor the legislators in 36 states who would legalize sports betting for their constituents; nor the league commissioners, who would rush into partnerships with online sportsbooks—seemed acquainted with Chesterton's fence.

Practically overnight, we took an ancient vice—long regarded as soul-rotting and civilizationally ruinous—put it on everyone's phone, and made it as normal and frictionless as checking the weather. What could possibly go wrong?

WEEK TWO

TOTAL GAMBLER: \$376.00
DOWN \$58.15

If I was going to do this, I decided, I would need a gambling guru—someone to talk me through the basics of sound sports betting (if such a thing existed) and teach me best practices.

The obvious choice was Nate Silver, America's most famous statistics nerd. Silver first made a name for himself as the founder of 538, an election-forecasting website that accurately predicted the winner of all 50 states in the 2012 presidential campaign. A few years ago, Silver, citing a midlife crisis and political fatigue, discarded the pundit suits, threw on a baseball cap, and started writing more about gambling. He launched a newsletter full of sophisticated sports-betting models and wrote a book about the psychology of successful gamblers. He estimates that he has netted in the "mid-six figures" over the course of his gambling life. If anyone could turn me into a respectable bettor, I figured, it was him.

Before our first call, I sheepishly sent Silver my week-one bet slips. After that first triumphant game, things had gone downhill.

Scrolling through DraftKings' offerings, I had turned into a little kid at a carnival, emptying my parents' wallet into any ring toss or high striker that caught my eye. I'd taken fliers on games without doing any research, and placed live bets on whatever ESPN happened to be showing when I turned on the TV. On Saturday afternoon, while casually watching a random college-football game with my brother, I bet \$10 that the point total wouldn't go over 52.5, lost, tried to make my money back with a new bet that it wouldn't go over 61.5, and lost that one too. Of the 14 wagers I'd placed in my first week, I'd won three.

Silver pulled up my slips when we got on the phone, and began to audibly react as he scrolled:

"Okay ..."

"Oh."

"Oh no." He started laughing.

Is it possible to be emasculated by Nate Silver? Apparently, yes.

Perhaps sensing my humiliation, he tried to soften his assessment. "Look, the nice way to put it is that you're betting like a recreational bettor." I took this as a withering insult.

Silver laid out some basic realities of the sports-betting economy. The books effectively charge you about 4.5 percent for every bet you place, he explained, which means it isn't enough to win 50.1 percent of the time; you have to win 52.5 percent of your bets just to break even, and that's before taxes. My most obvious mistake, he said, was that I was using only DraftKings. To find edges, I would need to shop for lines across at least three or four books every week.

He gave me other tips, too: Avoid "prop bets" on individual players (Josh Allen to rush for more than 50 yards) and multi-leg parlays, which pay out only if every outcome hits (the Chiefs cover the spread, the Ravens win, and the Chargers score more than 24 points). Props and parlays are how sportsbooks generate most of their profits. "They're suckers' bets," Silver said, which made sense, given that I had already placed several of them.

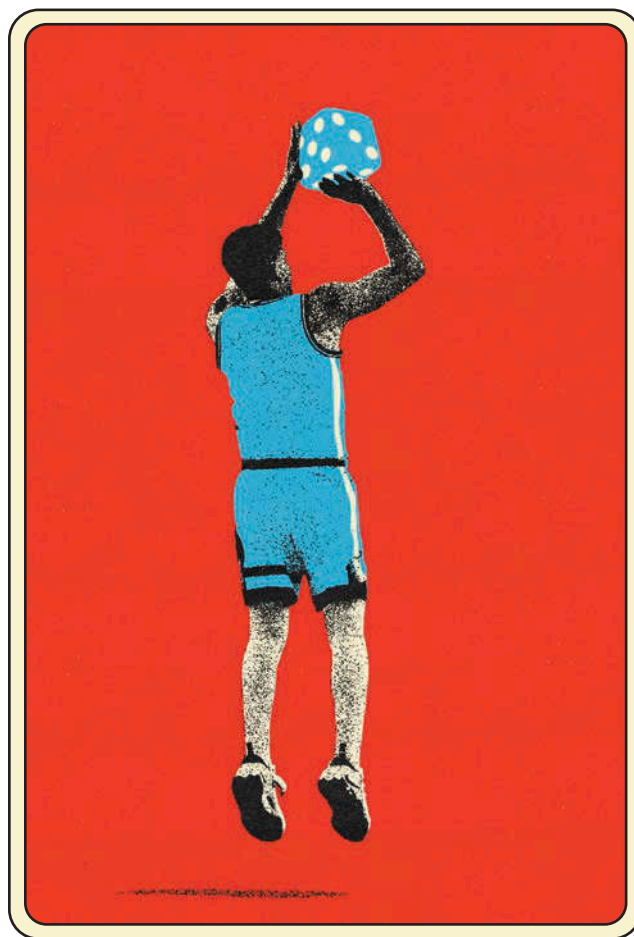
Live betting—placing wagers in the middle of games—was also a bad idea, he told me, because it leads to gambling based on emotion more than logic. Also, televised games are broadcast on a delay, which means the sportsbooks can adjust lines before you even see what has happened on the field. You are, in effect, betting against people who live 20 seconds in the future.

To guard against emotional betting, Silver suggested a Tuesday-morning ritual: I should sit in a quiet place, study the lines for that week's games, gather information on injury reports and weather forecasts, and then place \$100 bets on the six or seven games I liked best.

Before we hung up, I asked Silver what kind of profit would make it a successful season for me.

He seemed confused by the question. "If you make one penny, that would be better than 98 percent of people over an entire season," Silver answered, as if this were obvious.

I was taken aback. Hadn't Silver himself made hundreds of thousands of dollars gambling? Yes, he said, but that was mostly from poker tournaments. Sports betting was a game of razor-thin margins and microscopic edges. NFL football was among the hardest sports to win money on—the lines were too sharp,



the teams too evenly matched. Silver told me that, even with his quantish models and prognosticatory brilliance, he would consider it cause to celebrate if he broke even on the season.

Intellectually, I understood what he was saying. But some part of me didn't believe him. Somehow, I was still convinced that I could beat the odds.

THERE IS SOMETHING UNSETTLING about the suddenness with which gambling became omnipresent in American sports.

Turn on any game, on any channel, at any time of day, and you are likely to be bombarded with neon-soaked, star-studded ads for sports-betting apps: Jamie Foxx stalking a Bellagio suite, phoning Wayne Gretzky, Kevin Garnett, and Barry Sanders for betting tips. Shaquille O'Neal and Kevin Hart hyping new-customer bonuses for DraftKings. Hall of Famers who would have been selling sneakers and Wheaties a generation ago are now getting paid millions of dollars to lure 21-year-olds into online casinos.

Virtually every sports-media outlet in America, from CBS Sports to your favorite niche football podcaster, takes sponsorship money from gambling companies. ESPN now recaps the day's games by covering which teams beat the spread; gambling talk pervades pregame studio panels. Every major TV network now seems to employ a data whiz with glasses and rolled-up sleeves who can break down the betting angles for viewers at home.

The leagues, initially so opposed to legalized sports betting, embraced it to help reverse sliding TV ratings and lure back the younger fans who were drifting away. Before long, they found themselves beholden to the industry they'd helped create. Now the NFL, the NBA, and MLB all have large equity stakes in the data companies that power the sportsbooks. They license broadcast rights directly to sportsbook-operated streaming services, and hurry to defend their partners whenever a game-fixing scandal breaks. "Gambling touches everything," the former ESPN reporter Joon Lee recently wrote in a *New York Times* op-ed. "The betting apps are in charge now, and everyone knows it. The leagues are hostage to the forces they unleashed."

In 2017, Americans legally bet \$4.9 billion on sports. Last year, that number rose to at least \$160 billion—and once you're hooked, the list of sporting events you can gamble on is seemingly endless. Unsatisfied with wagering only on Sunday football games? Not to worry: How would you like to bet on an Indian cricket match, or Lithuanian Ping-Pong, or a Polish soccer game in a league whose name you can't pronounce? In 2023, an off-shore book called BetOnline briefly allowed people to gamble on the Special Olympics. The plan ran aground when athletes were apparently awarded identical medals in the same event—the Special Olympics is not, strictly speaking, about winners and losers—and bettors revolted after their payouts were delayed. A spokesperson for BetOnline acknowledged to the *New York Post* that grading the Special Olympics had been "more challenging than we expected."

Now, with the rise of "prediction markets" like Kalshi and Polymarket, gambling options are no longer limited to sports. Live-betting odds have been featured on the Golden Globes telecast and CNN's election coverage. In 2026, you can gamble on how warm it will get in Los Angeles tomorrow, and the winner of the Grammy for Best Rap Album, and how much money *Avatar: Fire and Ash* will gross, and the date of Taylor Swift's wedding, and *Time* magazine's Person of the Year, and the possibility of extraterrestrial life being discovered, and how many people will be deported from the United States, and the prospect of Iranian regime change, and the chances that Donald Trump declares martial law before his term ends, and whether Jesus Christ will return to Earth this year.

In remarkably short order, gambling has permeated every nook and cranny of American life. (If this strikes you as apocalyptic, the odds for the Second Coming currently stand at 23 to 1.)

WEEK THREE

TOTAL GAMBLED: \$1,011.00
DOWN \$185.40

In late September, my family piled into our Honda Odyssey and drove to Greenville, North Carolina, for the Brigham Young–East Carolina football game. Like any good father, I had made a project in recent years of indoctrinating my young kids in the sports fandom of my alma mater. We rolled up to the BYU tailgate

party—fancy bespoke sodas instead of beer; a canned-food drive in place of keg stands—and spent the hours before the game eating barbecue and taking pictures with Cosmo, the beloved Cougar mascot.

I had decided in advance not to bet on the game—I didn't need any action in order to be invested in its outcome, and the stress might sour the family experience. But at the tailgate, I met a BYU administrator who told me about how prepared the team was and how the defense would be "locked in." This was hardly insider information, but it was enough to compel me—an hour before kickoff—to put \$100 on BYU to win. When I mentioned this to my 12-year-old daughter, she rolled her eyes. "That's not very Mormon of you," she said.

The game was a blast. BYU fans had traveled from all along the East Coast to fill a large section of the stadium. Our defense was indeed locked in, forcing two turnovers and propelling the team to an early lead. By the middle of the third quarter, East Carolina fans were leaving in droves while my kids and I belted the Cougar fight song until we were hoarse: *Rise and shout, the Cougars are out!*

It was one of those ecstatic family moments—a core memory in the making. And yet, as we sang, I couldn't quite ward off an intrusive thought: *I should have bet BYU to cover the spread. Much better juice.*

WEEK FIVE

TOTAL GAMBLED: \$2,206.00
DOWN \$220.13

By October, I had settled into a rhythm with my betting. Following Silver's advice, I had downloaded several more sportsbook apps (FanDuel, ESPN Bet) and spent time early each week searching for the most enticing games on the NFL schedule. I kept tabs on roster updates and checked various prediction models.

One of my most valuable resources was a website that aggregated the lines across all sportsbooks and tracked the micro-movements in real time. The differences were minimal, but Silver had told me that exploiting even the tiniest advantage was crucial. If I liked the Seahawks to beat the Buccaneers, one book might have them as four-point favorites, while another would have them at 3.5; one might require me to bet \$110 to win an additional \$100, while another needed only \$106. The books are constantly adjusting their lines to keep users evenly balanced on each side of a given bet, in order to limit the risk of lopsided payouts, which would cut into their profits.

I took a certain perverse pride in my mastery of the lingo and the basic betting math. Scouring the sportsbooks each week for the best lines made me feel like a sharp. But the process could be time-consuming. One rainy evening, I found myself parked outside a big-box store in Northern Virginia where my wife had sent me on an errand, obsessively scavenging for lines on my phone and jotting down favorites in my Notes app. When I looked up, 45 minutes had passed. I would be late for dinner.

Doing all of this homework heightened my investment in the games—but it also conjured something disconcerting and primal in me.

I first noticed it during the fourth quarter of the Cardinals-Titans game that Sunday. The Cardinals had been heavy favorites, and I'd bet on them to win by a touchdown. Early in the fourth quarter, it looked like a win was in the bag. The Cardinals were already up 21–6 when running back Emari Demercado ran for what looked like a game-sealing 72-yard touchdown. But when the referees reviewed the play, they found that Demercado, who had dropped the ball after scoring, had actually let it go half a step before reaching the end zone. The touchdown was reversed, the play was ruled a fumble, and the Titans proceeded to pull off an improbable 16-point comeback to win the game. My money vaporized.

Rewatching clips of Demercado's fumble, I was filled with an irrational hatred for this person I had never met. I hated the way he sauntered so cavalierly into the end zone. I hated the way he tossed the ball to the ground like a used dish towel in what I'm sure he thought was a cool flex. I hated the way he shrugged off reporters' questions in the locker room afterward by repeating the same meaningless quote ("Just gotta be smarter").

The intensity of the feeling, fleeting as it was, unnerved me.

CAROLINE GARCIA DOESN'T REMEMBER the first abusive message she received from an angry gambler who lost a bet on her, but she knows she was still a teenager.

Garcia, a French tennis player who at her peak was ranked fourth in the world, told me she got so many deranged messages over the years—so many slurs and death threats, so many *fuck yous* and *kill yourselfs*—that they started to feel like background noise. She recalled the dissonance of receiving the most unhinged message

imaginable and then looking at the sender's wholesome Instagram: "His profile picture is with his kid of 1 year old, and you're like, *I don't understand—what is the problem with you?*" I felt a twinge of shame as I realized I could empathize with that gambler's brief spell of insanity more than I'd like to admit.

Garcia, who retired last year, was speaking with me via Zoom from Dubai, where she now lives with her husband. She told me she likes how safe the city feels. More than a decade of death threats from deranged bettors can make you appreciate high-tech security systems and heavily policed streets.

Athletes are no strangers to wrathful comments, of course. But the rise of legal, normalized betting has coincided with an increase in harassment. More than a third of men's Division I college-basketball players say they've received abusive messages from gamblers, and 21 percent of gamblers themselves cop to lashing out at athletes in person or online. The trend makes sense: When a player underperforms, he's not just letting down his teammates and fans. He's costing gamblers money. In the adrenaline spike of a tough beat, a bettor loses perspective; the athlete becomes a subhuman extra in the gambler's personal drama.

Tennis is among the most gambled-on sports in the world. And because it's primarily an individual game, the frustration of losing bettors lands directly on the players themselves rather than on coaches or whole teams. Garcia, who hosts a podcast called *Tennis Insider Club*, said players trade tips on how to deal with the abuse. They call law enforcement and hire private security; some of them rely on AI-powered software called Threat Matrix, which monitors and assesses the credibility of menacing messages across platforms.

A few have taken to mocking the misdirected rage. After Gaël Monfils lost in the first round of the Stuttgart Open last year, he posted a "special message" on Instagram for the gamblers who were filling his DMs with racist insults. "Really? You're still betting on me?" deadpanned Monfils, who at 38 was one of the oldest players on the tour. "You write in that I'm shit. I know I'm shit! We both know I'm shit!"

But even the most easygoing athletes realize that the desperation of a losing bettor can lead to scary places. In 2024, during a fourth-round women's match at the U.S. Open, in New York City, the official X account for the U.S. Tennis Association received a DM: "I'm inside Louis Armstrong with a bomb that will go off at 1 pm est." As experts worked to determine the credibility of the threat and the NYPD quietly swept the arena for explosive devices, tournament officials considered evacuating the stadium. Eventually, the message was traced to Strasburg, Pennsylvania, where a 20-year-old man had wagered a large sum on the match. When his player fell behind, he tried to disrupt the match and void his bet with a bomb threat. He now faces up to five years in prison.

Before Garcia retired, she told me, she often found herself wondering if a losing gambler's digital threat would escalate to physical violence. She told herself it was unlikely, but the possibility was always in the back of her mind. "You just hope that he will always stay in messages, and he will never go the next step," she said. Her eyes drifted to some unseen point off camera. "You never know."

HAVING GIVEN UP ON THE
PROSPECT OF A BIG
PAYDAY, MY WIFE WAS
NOW FOCUSED ON THE
MORE IMMEDIATELY
VISIBLE CONSEQUENCES
OF MY GAMBLING—LIKE
THE FACT THAT OUR
7-YEAR-OLD DAUGHTER
KNEW THE DIFFERENCE
BETWEEN A POINT SPREAD
AND A MONEYLINE.

WEEK SEVEN

TOTAL GAMOLED: \$3,551.00
DOWN \$567.23

I was surprised at how quickly and extensively the experiment was bleeding into the rest of my life. I was listening to gambling podcasts in the shower and spending my Sunday afternoons watching five football games at a time—one on my phone and four on the TV's split screen.

I routinely stayed up past midnight scrolling through the apps, my face illuminated in the dark of our bedroom by brightly colored ads for “NO SWEAT BETS” and “SAME GAME PARLAYS.” I impatiently swiped away FanDuel's “Reality Check” pop-ups, which notified me, in what I took to be a passive-aggressive tone of disapproval, that I was spending quite a lot of time on the platform.

It was now common for my family to catch me furtively tapping in wagers. On one occasion, my 10-year-old son discovered me on my phone in the kitchen pantry, where I'd gone to get snacks for the kids, and announced, “Dad is hiding again!” On another, Annie happened to glance down the pew at church just as I was sneaking a peek at DraftKings. “You're addicted,” she stage-whispered.

My wife was no longer having fun with this stunt of mine. Having given up on the prospect of a big payday, she was now focused on the more immediately visible consequences of my gambling—like the fact that our 7-year-old daughter knew the difference between a point spread and a moneyline, and that our 10-year-old's first question whenever I turned on a game was “Who are we betting on?”

Once, Annie overheard me enthusiastically explaining to our kids that if the third leg of my parlay hit, I would win enough money to erase all of my losses for the season. “But gambling is bad,” she shouted from the other room, “and people who do it eventually lose all their money, right?” Her tone of voice suggested that I was bound by marital covenant to endorse this position, which I promptly did.

“I can't wait for your gambling experiment to be over,” Annie muttered one night as we drove home from a long weekend at my parents' house. I had been up late the night before, sweating a Texans-Seahawks game that didn't end until about 1 a.m., and I'd slept in longer than intended, leaving Annie to wrangle the kids by herself all morning. This had become, she noted, a regular occurrence in recent weeks.

“I'm fine with you sleeping in when you're up late working, but ...” Annie began.

“This *is* for work,” I insisted.

She scoffed. “You don't have to watch every game you bet on,” she said. “You have no control over the outcome.”

The irrefutability of her point reduced me to indignant sputtering.

In truth, I was beginning to wonder about what Annie had said to me at church. I had always told people that I didn't have an addictive personality, believing that to be so. Now I had to consider a different possibility: Maybe I had simply constructed a life with strong enough guardrails that I'd never had to test the premise.

What would happen to me, I wondered, if those guardrails were removed?

I MET CRAIG CARTON at his Midtown Manhattan studio—faux brick, wood floors, klieg lights—near Madison Square Garden, about an hour before he went on air. Carton was a quintessential sports-media success story, having leveraged his bombastic New York morning show, *Boomer and Carton*, into a national following, as well as a book deal and a lucrative TV gig.

Now he spends a lot of his time talking to gambling addicts.

Carton hosts a weekly call-in show on WFAN called *Hello, My Name Is Craig*, in which he interviews recovering gambling addicts. The guests' stories are invariably bleak. The Wall Street trader who maxed out 15 credit cards and started stealing jewelry from his parents to cover his losses. The father of two whose wife left him when she found out he hadn't paid the mortgage for two years. The Little League umpire who got so deep in the hole that he decided he would try to win it all back in one trip to Atlantic City or else kill himself.

Carton, a bald, wiry guy with a raspy New York accent, toggles between empathy and razzing his guests—routinely interrupting a confession to bark, “Heard that one before!”

He's hard on them because he's been there. “I'm not a therapist,” he told me. “But I can talk to a gambler the way a non-gambler can't. You can't bullshit me—anything you've done in the gambling world, I've done times a hundred.”

The story of Carton's own descent into ruinous gambling addiction is typical: He started out playing low-stakes blackjack and placing modest bets on sporting events. But little by little, the habit consumed him. He began gambling so much that casinos would fly him out to Vegas on private jets and comp his meals and hotel rooms. As his bets got bigger, the losses became harder to conceal. He borrowed, refinanced, moved money around, and lied about it all, until federal agents showed up early one morning in 2017 outside his Tribeca apartment and arrested him for securities and wire fraud. Prosecutors accused him of siphoning millions from a ticket-resale business, and misleading investors, in order to pay off gambling debts. What Carton remembers most vividly from the morning agents handcuffed him to a bench outside his building was the look on his wife's face when she saw him.

Carton went to rehab in Arizona, spent a year in prison, and, when he got out, started counseling compulsive bettors and speaking at schools about the dangers of gambling addiction. He is overbooked. Since 2018, when the sports-betting ban was overturned, internet searches for phrases like *Am I addicted to gambling?* have spiked by 25 percent, and calls to gambling helplines from young men have surged. Gamblers Anonymous has reported young men showing up in droves across the country, and one survey found that nearly one-third of 11-year-old boys

had gambled in the past year. (The CEO of FanDuel's parent company, Flutter Entertainment, has spoken enthusiastically about the growth potential provided by the massive, exploitable market of Americans soon to come of age.)

Experts estimate that only about 2 to 5 percent of gamblers will develop compulsive behaviors. But as Carton likes to point out, that small percentage becomes a very large number when tens of millions of Americans suddenly have casinos in their pockets.

Gambling addiction is similar to other addictive disorders, but there are key differences. It's easier to hide, at least at first—the addict doesn't have glazed eyes or slurred speech, and no one can smell it on him. Plus, the compounding financial pressure of the habit can quickly turn a private vice into a full-blown crisis. One in five compulsive gamblers will attempt suicide in their life, a higher rate than for any other category of addict.

Executives at the major online sportsbooks are quick to trumpet their commitment to "responsible gaming." But that purported commitment runs up against an economic reality: As much as 90 percent of the sportsbooks' revenue comes from less than 10 percent of their users. Their apps seem clearly designed, much like TikTok and Candy Crush, to keep users scrolling and tapping in a hypnotic stupor. If your account is nearing empty, DraftKings will offer a "reload bonus" of gambling credits to entice you to deposit more money; if you've gone a couple of days without making a wager, you might get a push alert from FanDuel offering a "no sweat bet," promising to refund a loss with site credits to be used for more gambling.

When I asked Christian Genetski, the president of FanDuel, about accusations that online sportsbooks prey on problem gamblers, he dismissed the idea as "a bit of a trope." He said his company goes out of its way to identify and slow down users who exhibit reckless or addictive behaviors. Bettors who start spending more time or money than usual on the app will receive a notification alerting them to the anomaly—hence the Reality Check alerts I had impatiently dismissed. If they disregard too many of these notifications, FanDuel will impose limits on their gambling, and may even shut down their accounts. (An executive at DraftKings told me it has a similar policy.) "We don't want any revenue from someone that has a gambling problem," Genetski told me, noting that the platform's biggest spenders are not necessarily the ones with unhealthy habits. Genetski said that it's in FanDuel's long-term interest to keep users gambling at a sustainable rate. "If people are burning out because they are spending beyond their means, they're not going to be customers for very long." ("Loss smoothing" is the industry's term of art for this tactic; gamblers call it "the slow bleed.")

When Carton sits down with a gambling addict, his first suggestion is to fill out a "self-exclusion" form. Most states that have legalized gambling allow you to submit a document to the government that prohibits online sportsbooks from taking your action for a defined period—the gambling equivalent of Odysseus binding himself to the mast so he can withstand the temptation of the Sirens. (The strategy isn't fail-safe: After Carton filled out his own self-exclusion form in New Jersey, he received a letter from a brick-and-mortar casino in Atlantic City. "It said something

to the effect of 'We see that you've self-excluded from online gaming. Feel free to come in anytime. We'd love to have you.'")

Many of the young men Carton works with started out betting on football games with their dads. The dad, craving a Sunday-afternoon bonding experience, would open the account, make picks with his son, and then split the winnings—while covering the losses himself. "You're creating these little mini-monsters in gambling who have no idea that there are times you lose, and the money is real," Carton told me.

Listening to him talk, I became aware of the troubling parallels to my arrangement with *The Atlantic*. When I mentioned this to him, he chuckled ruefully. "You're in harm's way, that's for sure," he said.

I asked him, hypothetically, what warning signs a new gambler should watch for, and he rattled off a list of questions. Are you going to sleep and waking up thinking about your bets? Are you staying up late to watch West Coast games with teams whose rosters you know nothing about? Are you "chasing"—making reckless new bets to win back the money you lost? Are you placing bets on your phone in the bathroom so your family doesn't see you gambling?

I shifted uncomfortably in my seat.

WEEK EIGHT

TOTAL GAMBLED: \$5,321.00
DOWN \$132.40

On October 23, the FBI announced the arrests of more than 30 people in a pair of interlocking gambling schemes. The indictments alleged a yearslong mob operation that drew on insider information to manipulate NBA games and win bets. Terry Rozier, while playing for the Charlotte Hornets, was said to have tipped off associates that he would leave a game early with a foot injury, enabling bettors to place more than \$200,000 on "under" prop bets for his points, rebounds, and assists. The implicated included NBA players and a retired Hall of Fame point guard turned head coach. (They have pleaded not guilty.)

As I watched the FBI press conference on CNN, my phone pinged with messages from friends and sources who knew about my sports-betting experiment, including one from the governor of Utah: "Really relieved your name didn't come out in that gambling ring."

That evening, I had made plans to check out a real-life sportsbook in Washington, D.C. I invited along two friends, Steve and Ryan, who had been following my gambling *rumspringa* with deep amusement, and were eager to see me in action.

Neither their wives nor mine expressed interest in joining us. This had become something of a pattern since my experiment began—whenever I started talking about gambling with a couple, the woman would almost invariably tune out or recoil, while her husband leaned in attentively, eager to hear more. Neuroscientists have sought to explain this phenomenon. Men are, on average,

less psychologically affected by financial loss than women, and more prone to optimism (rational or otherwise) about their financial future; this combination naturally leads to more risk-taking. There are complicated brain-chemistry factors involved that have to do with testosterone, and dopaminergic systems, and kappa-opioid receptors, all of which seem to add up to a Jim Gaffigan joke about how men are morons compared with their wives. Whatever the reason, the gender split is undeniable: Men make up about 70 percent of sports bettors in America and, according to one study, 98 percent of online sports bettors who qualify as “problem gamblers.”

Our plan was to watch the Chargers play the Vikings, along with a couple of NBA games, at the Caesars inside Capital One Arena. But the place was smaller than anticipated and depressingly empty, redolent with the smell of cleaning chemicals, secondhand smoke, and dissatisfaction with life choices. “This feels like the DMV,” Ryan said. We decided to take our business across the Anacostia River to the MGM National Harbor casino, in Maryland.

I approached the counter, eager to show off my newfound gambling prowess to my friends, and confidently told the bored-looking woman in a blazer that I wanted to “put \$100 on the Thunder minus 7.5.” I whipped out my debit card, feeling particularly proud of this bit of lingo I’d picked up. “Cash only,” the woman responded, without making eye contact. Chastened, I shuffled over to an ATM that charged me a \$9.75 withdrawal fee.

We settled into recliners facing a wall of massive TV screens. I had expected the sportsbook lounge to be more glamorous, more fun, than the apps I’d been using—a classic sports bar on steroids. But the communal experience I craved was curiously absent. Everyone seemed to be paying attention to different games, or rooting for different sub-outcomes within the games. I tried to bond with some guys nearby who, like me, had money on the Chargers. But they were preoccupied with a prop bet, and barely noticed when Justin Herbert completed a perfect 27-yard touchdown pass to Ladd McConkey with 45 seconds left in the first half.

Gambling had made us all care much more about the games, but it had also atomized us—taking the last and purest expression of American monoculture and turning it into a hyper-individualized, every-man-for-himself portfolio of micro-bets.

The Chargers game was a blowout, but the Oklahoma City Thunder went into double overtime against the Indiana Pacers, and I stayed late with Steve to watch the end. My 7.5-point cover looked out of reach until the final seconds of the game, when the Pacers, down six, tried to foul Thunder center Chet Holmgren. Two free throws would have won me the bet, but the referees ignored the foul, and the game ended. Shouts of indignation rang out from disparate quarters of the lounge. I buried my head in my hands while Steve cackled at my misfortune.

“Tough beat, buddy,” he said.

Seeking company in my misery, I pulled up X, where I found a stream of outraged gamblers accusing the referees of fixing the game, perhaps with the aid of the NBA commissioner.

“Clearly they had money on Indiana,” one wrote.

“Disgusted.”

“Adam Silver must resign.”

I am not usually prone to paranoid thinking. But to my surprise, I found myself wondering if these venting gamblers were right. The morning’s indictment lingered in my mind. Had the refs rigged the game? Were league officials involved? What about players? *How deep did this thing go?*

THE NBA GAMBLING RING exposed in October was only the beginning. In November, two MLB players pleaded not guilty after being indicted for manipulating pitches to help bettors. In January, federal prosecutors accused 39 college-basketball players across 17 Division I teams of taking bribes from gamblers to underperform. (The indictment alleges that the scheme began with rigging Chinese professional-basketball games, then spread to the NCAA.) That same month, the Ultimate Fighting Championship canceled a bout after reports of suspicious betting activity.

Taken together, the proliferating scandals have posed the most significant threat to the credibility of organized sports in the U.S. since Shoeless Joe Jackson got paid to help fix the 1919 World Series. One recent poll found that 65 percent of Americans now believe that professional athletes sometimes change their performance to influence gambling outcomes; in another poll, 70 percent of respondents agreed that sports betting “lessens the integrity of the game.”

Gambling apologists argue that the recent revelations are proof that new laws are working—offshore sportsbooks and black-market bookies never coordinated with law enforcement to flag suspicious bets the way FanDuel and DraftKings do now. The cheating isn’t new, this argument goes; it’s just getting discovered and prosecuted more frequently.

Even if that’s true—and some researchers are skeptical—fans’ teetering confidence could become an existential problem. It’s easy to start questioning the legitimacy of what you’re watching on the field or the court, especially when the leagues and the gambling-subsidized sports media both have such clear conflicts of interest. (In October, while ESPN was covering the gambling-ring indictments, producers scrubbed the screen of references to its own online sportsbook.) If trust in the integrity of the game disappears, then interest is likely to follow. Every sport risks becoming professional wrestling—an entertaining spectacle that everyone knows is bogus.

Sports leagues, of course, are not the first American institutions to suffer a crisis of authority in the 21st century. (See also: Wall Street, Congress, the military, the police, the press, etc.) But the recent decline of trust in sports is, to an extraordinary degree, self-inflicted and avoidable. By embracing gambling so completely—normalizing it, celebrating it, reaping massive profits from it—the leagues have all but ensured that many fans will see it as baked into the game itself. Even if point-shaving is rare, each new revelation reinforces the notion that the system is rigged. To watch sports in 2026 is to become, almost inevitably, a kind of conspiracy theorist.

After a late penalty in a December game between the Broncos and the Raiders turned a meaningless field goal into a bad

beat for anyone who had Denver minus 8.5, the Barstool Sports founder, Dave Portnoy, filmed himself melting down on camera. “This is the most rigged game I have ever seen in my entire life,” Portnoy ranted, pacing around his living room alone, looking like a paranoid QAnon adherent. He demanded that the referees be investigated; he demanded that the Raiders’ coach, Pete Carroll, be investigated. Then he called for more decisive punishments. “Prison for Pete Carroll!” he bellowed. “Murder Pete Carroll! I want Pete Carroll murdered!”

Portnoy apologized the next day, clarifying that he’d only been calling for a “metaphorical murder.” But he didn’t back off his accusation. He had lost a quarter of a million dollars on “one of the wildest sequences” of the season, he told his audience. Somebody needed to get to the bottom of it.

WEEK THIRTEEN

TOTAL GAMBLLED: \$10,941.00
UP \$156.16

A couple of days before Thanksgiving, I called Nate Silver, who was preparing to leave for a poker tournament in the Bahamas. He asked me for a gambling status report, and I informed him that I’d been following his advice—diligently shopping for lines, mostly sticking to point spreads. Three months in, I had wagered about \$11,000 on 117 bets and was right about even. I didn’t think this sounded like something to brag about, but Silver set me straight. If I could sustain that kind of performance over the long term, he said, it would place me in the top 5 percent of sports bettors.

“So, a moral victory?” I joked.

“I’m serious,” he insisted. This NFL season had been a particularly “weird” one, he said—injuries galore, untested quarterbacks, and no dominant favorites steamrolling the rest of the league, among other anomalies. I had noticed that the FanDuel-sponsored sports podcasters I listened to most often—Bill Simmons, Cousin Sal, Joe House, and the rest of the *Ringer* crew—were all under .500 with their recommended picks for the year.

Silver didn’t want to reveal how much money he’d personally wagered on NFL games, but he said if it were 100 “units,” he was down about two-tenths of one unit. “You’re beating the lines,” he told me. He sounded almost impressed.

My family and I spent Thanksgiving in Florida, where my parents and siblings teased me relentlessly about my new gambling vocabulary. I laughed along with them, acknowledging the strangeness of the reporting project I’d embarked upon. I also shared their revulsion when we saw a dystopian FanDuel ad depicting a family gathered around a Thanksgiving table, each member staring at their phone, accompanied by the tagline “Bet together like never before.”

What I didn’t tell my family was that I was experiencing my first bout of gambling withdrawal. Upon arriving in Orlando, I had discovered that none of my regular apps worked. Florida allows online sports betting only through an app called Hard

Rock Bet, whose servers are on Native land—the result of a 2021 compromise between gambling lobbyists and the Seminole Tribe.

When my brother put on the Chiefs-Cowboys game, a barn burner that came down to the final minutes, I noted with some alarm that I could barely muster any interest. The dopamine system in my brain had been hijacked; I needed money on the game to care about it.

When we got back to Virginia, I reflexively reached for my phone and opened DraftKings as soon as I woke up in the morning, a junkie reaching for his fix. Silver’s encouragement had filled me with irrational confidence. Could it be that I was actually good at gambling? *Exceptional*, even? A sports-betting savant who had discovered his talent only in middle age? This was not exactly what Silver had said, but I could read between the lines.

That night, the Patriots, my favorite team, were playing the Giants on *Monday Night Football*, and I spent all day putting together what I thought was the perfect play. The Pats had been on a good run, and the Giants were only 2–10. But New England was dealing with multiple injuries, and I thought the 7.5-point spread was a little rich. I decided to violate one of Silver’s key guidelines and bet \$350 on a parlay: the Patriots to win outright, and the game’s point total to be under 50.5. I figured, given my performance, that I’d earned the right to break some rules.

Before the game, I showed the parlay to my 10-year-old son, explaining my logic as if I were a physicist explaining a particle accelerator. The temperature in Foxborough was forecast to be 29 degrees at kickoff, I told him, and teams always score less in the cold.

“You’re, like, a betting genius now,” he said. I felt, briefly, the swelling pride of a father who has impressed his son.

PAUL TONKO does not cut an especially imposing figure. He has white tufts of hair that flare over his ears, and a rumpled, curmudgeonly affect that calls to mind a disapproving grandfather. But the 76-year-old congressman from New York is one of Washington’s few prominent crusaders against the sports-betting industry. It’s a lonely job.

Tonko came to the cause four years ago, when he saw that the social-media feeds of his younger aides were filled with ads for sports-betting apps. The marketing, he thought, bore a striking resemblance to the cigarette campaigns from a generation earlier—glossy, predatory, and calibrated to hook the young. As a co-chair of the Addiction, Treatment, and Recovery Caucus, Tonko says he recognized immediately that the industry needed more regulation. “They’re delivering a known addictive product,” he told me, sitting in his office overlooking the U.S. Capitol.

When he began working on a bill that would ban certain kinds of advertising for sportsbooks, he was surprised by the energy around the issue. He was urged on forcefully by parents whose sons had gambled away their tuition money, and by politicians and experts in the United Kingdom and Australia who wished that they’d cracked down on the industry earlier. Key players in the fight against Big Tobacco told him that online gambling was the next major public-health crisis, and volunteered their help.

**DESPITE ALL OF MY
RESEARCH—MY MONASTIC
STUDY OF THE LINES, MY
CAREFUL HUNT FOR SMALL
EDGES—I HAD BEEN BURNED
BY A BAD CALL FROM A
RANDOM REFEREE. I
BECAME DETERMINED TO
WIN IT ALL BACK.**

The only place Tonko struggled to find support was in Congress. When he brought up the bill with colleagues, they would listen politely and then waffle when asked to sign on. They seemed to regard sports betting as an insignificant problem—a nice pet issue for Tonko, maybe, but not something worth spending time or political capital on.

Maybe the hurdle was generational: The average House member is about 60 years old, well outside the DraftKings target demographic. But Tonko suspects that at least some of the resistance has to do with money. In the years since the Supreme Court paved the way for state-by-state legalization, sports-betting companies have mounted a lobbying blitzkrieg in statehouses across the country.

In Kansas, industry representatives plied lawmakers with steak dinners, premium whiskey, and cigars in a private club as they pushed favorable tax legislation. In Mississippi, DraftKings courted the House speaker, bringing him and his wife to New Orleans for the Super Bowl, where they mingled with celebrities in a luxury suite over drinks and gourmet Creole food.

The lobbyists' pitch to politicians is easy enough to understand: Tax revenue from online gambling can help fund schools and roads. In 2024, online sportsbooks generated at least \$2.9 billion in taxes for state and local governments, a figure that is growing rapidly. Mindful of this, Tonko has been careful to frame his proposals in terms of basic harm reduction. "We're not out to outlaw sports gambling," he told me. He has proposed a new bill that would restrict how online sportsbooks can target and track customers, as well as cap certain kinds of losses, ban prop bets on college and amateur athletes, and create a national self-exclusion list so that people who want to bar themselves from betting don't have to fill out a new form every time they cross a state line.

When I asked Tonko how confident he was of the bill's passage, he seemed to slump into his sofa. "It's an uphill battle," he admitted. "The industry's got megabucks. So I don't kid myself."

But he noted that his colleagues do seem to be growing more interested in the issue. As the hazards of ubiquitous gambling become harder to ignore, Tonko expects political support to grow. "Give it time," he said; three years from now, things might be so bad that Americans will be clamoring for regulation.

This, it seemed, was his best-case scenario.

WEEK FOURTEEN

TOTAL GAMBLER: \$11,841.00

DOWN \$74.60

The tailspin began on a Thursday night, with a Lions-Cowboys game. I had bet on the Cowboys, who were 3.5-point underdogs, to cover the spread—and in the fourth quarter, a win looked within reach for me. Quarterback Dak Prescott was driving toward the end zone in pursuit of a touchdown that would have pulled the Cowboys within three. But with less than four minutes left and the Cowboys on the 11-yard line, a controversial offensive-pass-interference call ended the drive and my hopes for a backdoor cover. "That call is gonna be talked about," the announcer boomed.

It was almost midnight—the Christmas tree was glowing nearby, my father-in-law was dozing on the couch, and I had just lost \$500. I noticed that I was grinding my teeth.

I had endured plenty of tough beats up to that point, but the fluky nature of this particular loss made something inside me snap. Despite all of my research—my monastic study of the lines, my careful hunt for small edges, my righteous avoidance of the high-risk suckers' bets that the apps were constantly pushing on me—I had been burned by a bad call from a random referee. I became determined to win it all back.

My first move was to bump up the size of my wagers. When I'd started out, I put no more than \$100 on most games; now I was betting up to \$500—impatiently swiping to deposit more money when DraftKings or FanDuel told me I was out of funds. Months of diligent recordkeeping were abandoned as the flurry of action caused me to lose track completely of how much I had bet, and on what. Uncertain of what remained of my \$10,000 stake from *The Atlantic*, I routinely woke in the middle of the night, panicked that I was inadvertently dipping into my own savings.

On tilt—this was one of the terms I hadn't known before my foray into betting. It describes the emotional distress that causes a gambler to make unwise decisions. Over several frenzied days in December, I disregarded every rule Silver had taught me—throwing money at random prop bets and constructing multi-leg parlays like I was a mad scientist mixing volatile compounds in a lab.

Point spreads and moneylines ran constantly through my head, mingling with the omnipresent Christmas carols to create a strange backbeat to the holiday season. Every festive family outing became an opportunity for me to gamble. While my wife and kids ice-skated, I sat in the minivan, our toddler napping in his car seat, as I put together a six-game parlay (lost \$80). While my

daughter practiced for a Christmas choir performance, I stayed outside the church, chewing my fingernails as I watched a Chiefs-Chargers game on my phone (lost \$400).

One Sunday evening, we hosted a small Christmas party, where Steve and Ryan asked me how my gambling was going. I tried to adopt the same wry, self-aware tone that had so amused them when I began the experiment. But I was too keyed up to stay in character. Instead, as I rattled off betting lines in rapid succession, explaining my strategy to get back in the black with ever larger bets, I saw them exchange looks of concern.

"So you're chasing," Steve said.

I laughed, too loudly, and then slipped into the pantry to check the Seahawks-Colts score on my phone.

I had put a lot of money on the Seahawks to cover a two-touchdown spread. But while our guests filtered out in a blur of hugs and *Merry Christmases*, I watched miserably as Seattle eked out a measly two-point win with a field goal in the dwindling moments, losing me \$450.

When the house was empty, I collapsed onto the couch and started doing the math in my head. The flames were low in the fireplace; Bing Crosby was playing over the speakers. I had lost more than \$2,500 in 13 days.

WEEK EIGHTEEN

TOTAL GAMBLER: \$20,511.00

DOWN \$3,605.77

Four months of burying myself in gambling apps had apparently made me twitchy in ways that were perceptible to my colleagues. The editor in chief, concerned for my mental health, suggested that I log off for a bit and touch felt.

I landed in Las Vegas on a Sunday in early January and headed to the Bellagio, where I met Tom Nichols, the colleague that my editors had selected as my chaperone. Tom, a professor emeritus at the U.S. Naval War College and a blackjack obsessive (who knew?), came to Vegas several times a year, and was eager to teach me his ways.

He led me across the casino floor as I scampered behind him taking notes—the sage professor, goateed and clad in a black oxford shirt, explaining slot machines and table games to his earnest pupil. In my notebook, I wrote down, "Always tip the dealer" and "Forget roulette, that's a Eurotrash game."

Tom's main piece of advice was to never gamble on the Strip. The corporate casinos had gotten too greedy, he explained: The odds were bad, the table minimums too high. Besides, the *real* Vegas wasn't in places like the Bellagio.

He took me downtown to Fremont Street, where showgirls wandered past buskers beneath a canopy of LED screens. We passed a bar with a sign that read DRINK BEER THROW AXES, and a restaurant, the Heart Attack Grill, that offered free meals to anyone over 350 pounds and displayed customers' weight in

giant neon numbers. Tom let out a contented sigh. "America is already great," he said.

Tom loves Las Vegas—the kitsch, the unsavory history—and seems almost protective of it. Too many people think of casinos as depressing, predatory places, he said, filled with dead-eyed senior citizens sucking on oxygen tanks as they pump their Social Security checks into slot machines. But what he loves about casinos is not so much the gambling per se as the sense of community it generates.

Tom's favored casinos (the Golden Gate, El Cortez, the Plaza) were decidedly grimmer than the Bellagio—the synthetic air-freshener-and-cologne scent replaced by the stench of beer-soaked carpet and secondhand smoke. But they were also surprisingly friendly places. At one blackjack table, we met two chain-smoking blond women in their 60s from Green Bay, one of whom ribbed me for refusing to hit on 16 while the other proudly recounted her second wedding, where the guests wore Packers jerseys. At another table, a young Black guy with facial tattoos was playing \$100 hands and had developed a rollicking alliance with the white-haired geriatric at the other end of the table. "I see you!" he shouted in celebration whenever the old man got a blackjack. Tom, meanwhile, developed a running bit with the dealer about their "dysfunctional marriage."

There was something quaintly American about the scene: strangers from different parts of the country, of different races and generations, chatting, drinking, joking, commiserating. Yes, everyone was slowly getting ripped off, but at least they were getting ripped off together. Compared with the solitary swiping of the sports-betting apps, the blackjack table was almost Rockwellian.

But as I followed Tom around town for three days, I began to appreciate Vegas for another reason: As a venue for vice, it is inherently self-limiting, a kind of containment zone for sordid behavior. Even for someone who didn't partake in booze or strip clubs, it was an exhausting place to spend time in. The sensory overload wore me down after a while—the smells, the noise, the permanent neon twilight, the intentional assault on my circadian rhythm. I was never quite sure what time it was, only that I had probably stayed too long.

Las Vegas struck me as a monument to a truth that America once knew and had somehow chosen to forget: If gambling had to be legal, it should be contained to remote cities in the desert that make you feel a little bad about yourself.

BEFORE LEAVING LAS VEGAS, I was determined to meet with Sean Perry, a professional sports bettor with nearly half a million followers on Instagram. Perry belongs to a new, influencer-age breed of "handicappers"—people who sell picks to recreational gamblers, claiming inside information or proprietary analytics models.

I had come across Perry's Instagram profile months earlier, when my algorithm began to identify me as a degenerate gambler. Scrolling through his posts, I didn't find much sports analysis—but I did find the fruits of his purported success: the private-jet selfies and Lamborghinis in his driveway, the yacht off the Amalfi Coast, the 21 Hermès handbags he presented to his girlfriend for their six-month anniversary. "Sports betting," Perry likes to tell his followers, "is the highest-paying job in the world."



I was fascinated by the fantasy that Perry was selling—and, if I’m being honest, a part of me was intrigued to learn his secrets. But interviewing him turned out to be trickier than anticipated. Perry was a moving target, constantly bouncing around the Strip from one sportsbook to another.

The first time we met was on Sunday afternoon at the Bellagio. He arrived with an entourage: his mom, his girlfriend, a leashed English bulldog named Ripple, and a muscly bodyguard named Ron. Perry was surprisingly quiet, even awkward, in person, mumbling as he introduced himself and generally avoiding eye contact. “I’m gonna record a little intro if you want to watch,” he muttered as he handed Ron his phone.

But once the camera blinked on, Perry’s face lit up. He pulled \$100,000 in cash out of his Goyard backpack. “If you’ve got a house, sell the house!” he exhorted his followers. “If you’ve got a car, sell the car! I’ve got a guaranteed winner for you.” He marched up to the counter—his bodyguard still recording—and plunked down the wad of cash on the Ravens to beat the Steelers in that night’s game.

I was so mesmerized by the performance that I got in line behind him and put down \$300 on the Ravens myself. (*I’d* never bought my wife 21 Hermès bags.)

Before I could ask him any questions, Perry—displeased with the size of the TV that was showing that afternoon’s Las Vegas Raiders game—decided to change his plans. He and his squad were headed to Allegiant Stadium, the Raiders’ home field, to watch the game in person. He promised to text me a meetup spot later, but I never heard from him. And when the Ravens ended up losing that night with a missed 44-yard field goal, I was glad that I hadn’t sold my house.

For three days, I chased Perry up and down the Strip. He would text me plans to be at one casino or another, and then flake at the last minute. One afternoon, he DMed me on Instagram: “I’ve got a major play lined up, ready to move when you are. How much do you usually bet on something big?” I didn’t see the message until it was too late—and good thing, because it turned out to be another loser when the Montana State Bobcats failed to cover the spread against the Illinois State Redbirds in the Football Championship Subdivision title game.

One reason to doubt the betting prowess of handicappers like Perry, who claims to make tens of millions a year gambling, is that the professional sportsbooks are carefully designed to prevent such success stories. When a gambler starts to win too consistently, the books will place limits on how much he can bet. A true sharp will be effectively banned by every sportsbook in the country before too long.

Once that happens, a game of cat and mouse ensues: The sharp might hire someone else to place bets on his behalf—on any given day, the Las Vegas Strip is teeming with “runners” who carry backpacks stuffed with \$100 bills—but this strategy has its own risks. Betting in another person’s name violates the terms of most sportsbooks, and depending on how the transaction is executed, it could be considered fraud. To avoid detection, some sharps will “prime” their accounts—placing scattershot bets to make themselves look like reckless gambling addicts and prompt the sportsbooks to increase their limits—before moving in for the kill. Although the tactics are always evolving, one element of the sportsbook business model remains constant: to take as many bets as possible from bad gamblers, and as few as possible from good ones.

On my last day in Vegas, I finally caught up with Perry at Circa, whose sportsbook features a 1,000-seat theater, a 78-million-pixel Jumbotron, and half a dozen rooftop swimming pools from which gamblers can watch games and place bets. Circa, widely considered the largest sportsbook in the world, is the closest thing that sports betting has to Mecca.

Perry walked in alone—it was a weekday afternoon, and the place was mostly empty—but he was clearly dressed for another Instagram stunt. He wore wide-leg, diamond-studded jeans; a \$350,000 Rolex; and two massive, bejeweled chains that read SPW (“Sean Perry Wins”). As soon as he saw me, he thrust a phone into my hand and asked me to get ready to film.

I followed him to the counter, where he placed a \$100,000 bet on an NBA game. The ticket writer typed something into his computer, and then informed him that the book could take only \$3,000 from him.

Perry, elated, told me to press record. “I just got limited by the biggest sportsbook in Vegas!” he declared. He was feigning outrage, but in fact, this was a badge of honor for a handicapper like him—proof that the sportsbooks were scared of his gambling facility. I pointed out that the man at the counter had cited a player injury as the reason bets on the game were limited, but Perry waved me off. “If you walk to that window right now and try to bet the 100K, they would 100 percent have accepted it.”

When he was done preening for the camera, we retreated to a quiet row of empty seats. I asked him how closely he resembled

his social-media persona. “What do you think?” he scoffed. In real life, he told me, he didn’t wear bling or gaudy watches. “I put on a character when I’m on the internet,” he explained. “You have to—that’s how you get views. That’s how I make money.”

Did he ever worry that his followers might take him literally when he tells them to sell their house for a bet?

“They know I’m trolling,” Perry insisted.

I pressed him. “Sometimes people are degenerate,” he conceded. “They’ll go all in on a single play and lose money. The truth is, that’s not my fault.” Perry said that he employs a team of data analysts who pore over statistical models. One of his clients, he claimed, had made \$8 million following his picks; another had made \$13 million in four months.

No single bet is guaranteed, he told me. But if you stick with him over time, “it’s impossible to lose money.”

WEEK NINETEEN

TOTAL GAMBLLED: \$22,386.00

DOWN \$4,257.67

Upon my return from Vegas, the editor in chief asked for an update on my losses. I admitted that I was down about \$4,000 but assured him, like an underwater debtor talking to his loan shark, that I was going to win it all back—the NFL playoffs were coming up. He reminded me that this was the magazine’s money I was playing with. “The future of *The Atlantic* depends on you,” he said. “Pick wisely.”

What I didn’t mention to him was that I was no longer gambling just on sports. I was now experimenting with prediction markets.

I had been aware of platforms like Polymarket and Kalshi, which allow users to “invest” in predictive outcomes and trade their “positions.” I also knew that the platforms, which are available in all 50 states, were competing for market share in sports betting with FanDuel, DraftKings, and other incumbents.

But my curiosity wasn’t piqued until U.S. forces stormed Venezuela in January. Days before the operation, an anonymous user had created a Polymarket account and started wagering tens of thousands of dollars that President Nicolás Maduro would be in U.S. custody by the end of the month. When Maduro was captured, the account holder walked away with more than \$400,000 in profit.

I assumed at first that the story was an example of obscene abuse—insider trading on a deadly military raid. But once I started playing around with the markets, it became clear that insider trading was a feature, not a bug. The platforms’ founders say they’re providing a social utility, moving the entire digital public square from social-media sites, where AI slop and rage bait reign, to prediction markets, where you are incentivized to invest based on what you genuinely know or believe. “People don’t lie when money’s involved,” Tarek Mansour, a Kalshi co-founder and its CEO, told *The New York Times*. And although the platforms technically prohibit manipulation—and, in Kalshi’s case anyway, insider trading—proponents have acknowledged

that insiders making bets based on what they know only heightens the markets’ predictive value.

But scrolling through the available bets on Kalshi, I struggled to locate the civic spirit. Would anyone truly benefit because I could wager on which words Trump would use next week (5-to-1 payout on *Somalian*), or which nicknames he’d deploy for his political enemies (3-to-1 for *Newscum*)? Was the quality of the discourse improved by our ability to gamble on drug-boat bombings in the Caribbean or whether Gaza would experience a famine? “The long-term vision is to financialize everything and create a tradable asset out of any difference in opinion,” Mansour has said.

It is perhaps not a coincidence that the casinofication of America is taking place while the Oval Office is occupied by a former casino operator. Under the Biden administration, the Justice Department and the Commodity Futures Trading Commission opened investigations into whether Kalshi and Polymarket were flouting federal regulations. But the government scrutiny ended when Trump returned to office. Polymarket hired a former Trump adviser as its first Washington lobbyist and added the president’s son Don Jr. to its board; Kalshi also brought on Don Jr., as a “strategic adviser.” The investigations were quietly closed, and the companies began to scale up rapidly.

But the great gambling experiment that we’ve embarked on is bigger than the current president. The prediction markets represent the logical end point of the sports-betting explosion: Everything in American life—politics and culture, art and war—becomes a Las Vegas table game, tantalizing in its promise of profit, rigged against regular people, destined to demoralize and crush those who play.

In 1907, a Unitarian minister, writing in *The Atlantic*, warned against “speculation.” “The long and costly experience of mankind bears uniform testimony against gambling,” Charles F. Dole wrote. “It is a dangerous or unsocial form of excitement; it hurts character, demoralizes industry, breeds quarrels, tempts men to self-destruction.”

Not every consensus of the past is worth clinging to, of course. But as a society, we are making an enormously risky bet: that we can

AS A SOCIETY, WE ARE
MAKING AN ENORMOUSLY
RISKY BET: THAT WE CAN
REAP THE REWARDS OF A
RUNAWAY GAMBLING
INDUSTRY WITHOUT PAYING
ANY PRICE; THAT, UNLIKE
EVERY CIVILIZATION THAT
CAME BEFORE US, WE CAN
BEAT THE HOUSE.

reap the rewards of a runaway gambling industry without paying any price; that the litany of social ills long associated with this vice—addiction and impoverishment, isolation and abuse, cheating and chasing and corrosive idleness—can, this time, be kept in check; that, unlike every civilization that came before us, we can beat the house.

What are the odds that we're right?

THE SUPER BOWL

TOTAL GAMBLLED: \$28,206.00

DOWN \$4,787.70

Despite my assurances to the editor in chief, the playoffs did not go well. For complicated reasons involving point spreads and, possibly, divine punishment, I somehow managed to correctly pick the winner in 10 out of 12 games through the first three rounds while still losing money.

As the losses piled up, I took solace in my beloved Patriots' improbable postseason run. I had grown up in Massachusetts at the dawn of the Brady-Belichick dynasty; now I was sharing in the joy of New England fandom with my son, who perched next to me for every game. When quarterback Drake Maye scrambled through a blizzard for a game-clinching first down in the AFC championship—my son and I jumping up from the couch in a frenzy of high fives and enraptured whoops—it felt a little like destiny.

It also felt like an opportunity: When the line opened that night for Super Bowl LX, the Patriots were 2-to-1 underdogs against the Seattle Seahawks. I had what I thought were sound analytical reasons to believe the sportsbooks were underestimating the Patriots. But I was also seduced by the allure of a big, go-for-broke win, the chance to dig out of the hole I'd dug myself into.

If I put everything I had left on the Patriots moneyline and they won, I would end the season up about \$5,000. Not life-changing money, but enough to put that new KitchenAid mixer in play.

Nate Silver did not endorse this plan. My fanatical faith in the Patriots didn't factor into his model, and he calmly walked me through the many reasons it favored the Seahawks. "You're gambling, McKay," he said disapprovingly.

I spent some time perusing the Cheesecake Factory-size menu of available Super Bowl bets. It turned out you could gamble on essentially every second of the event, from the length of the national anthem (the smart money was on less than 116.5 seconds for the whole song but more than 3.5 seconds for how long the singer would hold the last note on *brave*) to the coin toss (it had been tails eight out of the past 12 games) to the color of the Gatorade poured on the winning coach's head (the chalk bet was yellow/lime, but red would pay out 15 to 1).

In the end, I put \$4,735 on the Patriots to win the game, and spent about \$700 on a smattering of long-shot parlays and prop bets that ranged from plausible to preposterous.

The Super Bowl was a disaster. After the Patriots got shut out in the first half—which I spent shouting at the TV and anxiously shoving tortilla chips into my mouth—our guests decided they

needed to "get the kids to bed." By the time Maye threw a hope-killing fourth-quarter interception, I had retreated into my phone, watching despondently as the live odds for a Patriots comeback got longer and longer until finally the TV screen filled with confetti.

As I toggled between gambling apps, my son sullenly turned off the TV and announced that he was going to bed. He was suffering the first sports-fan heartbreak of his young life; I was checking on my prop bets. The rest of my family soon followed him, leaving me to wallow alone. Before going to bed, Annie forwarded me an email from our bank alerting us that a card had been declined. Apparently, in my last frantic flurry of pre-kickoff bets, I had unwittingly overdrawn the checking account I had set up for my gambling. "The end of an era," she wrote.

Was it? That had been the plan, of course. My adventure in sports betting was supposed to conclude with the Super Bowl, when I no longer had journalism as an excuse and my employer's money to gamble with. But was I really going to let my grand gambling experiment end like this?

I slept poorly that night—tormented by the loss, moral dissonance, and Walmart-brand ranch dip—and woke before the sun came up. Sitting at my desk, I made a final tally of my wagers. I'd had an astonishingly bad night, even worse than I'd realized. Of my 22 Super Bowl bets, I'd won exactly two: that Patriots receiver Mack Hollins would score a touchdown, and that Ricky Martin would perform with Bad Bunny in the halftime show.

The season was over. I had lost \$9,891.

Staring at that number, I thought about all the people who had placed their first-ever bets on the Super Bowl. Some 68 million Americans had been expected to gamble on the game, and 70 percent had picked the Seahawks. I knew how they were feeling this morning—the thrill of a win, the sudden appetite for more, the hubristic belief that they just might be savvy enough to make money at this.

But I also knew how easily that joyful naivete could curdle into delusion and compulsion. When I'd started this project, I had presented it to my bishop as journalism; at some point, it had veered into obsession. And as clearly as I could see that now, in the cold comedown from a brutal loss, I didn't know how long that clarity would last. As I scrolled through the apps, my eye was drawn to the March Madness promotions—some of the Final Four odds looked intriguing. On Kalshi, meanwhile, the Oscars futures were calling to me. The temptation to chase would never go away, it seemed. Those fences that I, and the country, had erected—the ones that had convinced me that I wasn't prone to addiction and America that it didn't need to worry about this particular vice after all—suddenly seemed more vital than ever.

My family was still asleep upstairs; the gray winter light seeped through the cracks in the blinds. I thought about the advice that every addiction counselor gives to a problem gambler, and I opened my laptop. In the Google search bar, I typed the words *Virginia self-exclusion form*. *A*

McKay Coppins is a staff writer at The Atlantic.



LEAVING THE UNITED STATES BEHIND

The Cruz family spent years building a life in New York. Then the risks of staying became too great.

Photographs by
Natalie Keyssar

BY CAITLIN
DICKERSON

THE CRUZ FAMILY WAS EXHAUSTED. It was two days before Christmas 2024, and Rachel was coughing from bronchitis, her body once again crashing into the holiday break as she finished her 17th year teaching public high school in New York City. Irvi, her husband, was sleeping after his day shift at an upscale bistro on the Upper West Side, which had followed an overnight shift at a Latin dance club farther uptown, in Inwood. Between the two jobs, he'd dropped their daughters—Sara, 12, and Ana, 10—at their schools for gifted students, then rushed home to the Bronx to cook and do laundry.

For years, Rachel and Irvi had been hustling to make this routine work, hoping that American immigration policy would evolve and allow Irvi, who had spent half his life in the United States, to become a citizen. Raising two children in New York City was expensive. Each day felt like a marathon they didn't think they could finish. But the girls were thriving, and Rachel and Irvi were beloved at work. Every few years, they met with lawyers who urged them to hang on, so they did.

I met the Cruz family in late 2016, when Donald Trump's election, and his contempt for immigrants, first made them think of moving to Irvi's hometown, in rural southern Mexico. But their daughters were just 2 and 4 then, and uprooting them was daunting. Four years later, Joe Biden's win made the Trump years seem like an aberration, and Rachel and Irvi thought, once again, that a solution to their problem was within reach. Then came 2024, when 77.3 million Americans voted for Trump. His campaign signs had called for MASS DEPORTATION NOW! To the Cruzes, the message was clear: Irvi should give up and go home.

The family had never been apart for long. The four of them linked arms or held hands when they walked down the street together, without seeming to notice they were doing it. Separation was not an option. So they would go, all of them.

"We no longer have the faith that things will always be better here in the United States," Rachel told me that night in December, sitting at their dining table, cupping a Zabar's mug full of tea.

Drained from work, Irvi shuffled down the stairs in sweatpants. He had dark bags under his eyes but greeted me with his squinty smile. He sat down and said he was excited to live freely for the first time in his adult life. He was also scared. The only story he'd known about his family—that they were proud New Yorkers—was about to end. Sara, who had been standing behind him, playing with his salt-and-pepper hair, ran into the kitchen to cry. Rachel hurried after her.

"What do you want?" Rachel asked softly. "Do you want to give Papá a hug?"

"No, I just want to go to my room," Sara said. "I don't want to talk about this. I don't want to be here."

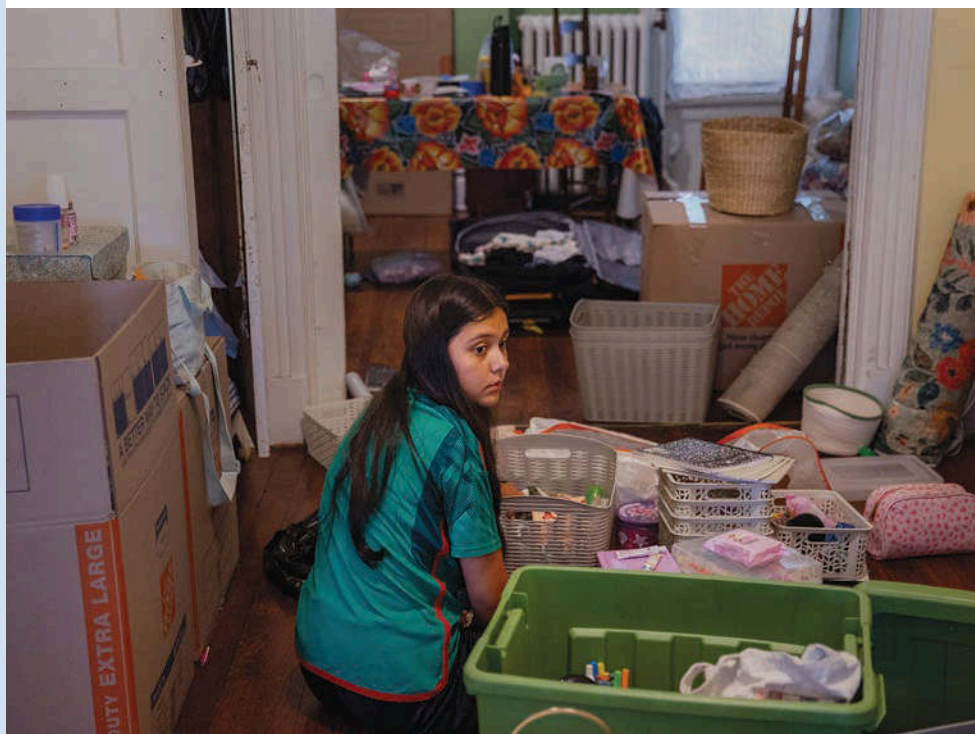
"Well, if we get it out now, maybe it'll make you feel better later," Rachel told her, unsure if that was true.

Their tentative plan was to sell the house and move in with Irvi's parents, 2,100 miles away. Irvi would go first, so he'd be out of the country before Trump took office. Rachel and the girls would join him seven months later, in August 2025, after finishing the school year and summer camp. They didn't know what they'd do for income in Mexico, or where the girls—who knew only a little Spanish—would go to school.

Friends thought they were overreacting. Some were upset. After all, New York was a sanctuary city and Irvi was married to an American citizen. Rachel and Irvi found these reactions maddening. They saw their American friends as stubbornly naive about the

system they had been battling for decades, and their undocumented friends as deluded for clinging to hope instead of reason.

Rachel's mother, Susan McCormick, had heaved and sobbed when she learned that the granddaughters she was helping to raise would be leaving New York. She and Rachel's father, Doug, were furious with the country for putting them in this situation. Their daughter was one of nearly 4.2 million American citizens and permanent residents in the United States with an undocumented spouse, and Sara and Ana



*Sara packs up
her New York life
in July 2025.*

were among 6.3 million children with an undocumented parent. How many were also choosing family over country? And what was the United States losing in the process?

By Christmas 2024, the McCormicks were trying to be stoic, to give Rachel and Irvi strength and to show the girls that everything was going to be okay. Doug had become a genealogy nerd in retirement and was reminding himself that their ancestors had made a move like this every few centuries: Irish farmers running from famine, Germans displaced by war, and Russian and Ukrainian Jews escaping pogroms. He even found ancestors aboard the Mayflower.

But all of these prior generations had found refuge here. “After 400 years in this country,” Doug told me, “suddenly America doesn’t want my children and grandchildren.”

Rachel, Irvi, and their daughters would be the first in their family to run from—rather than to—the United States.

ON SEPTEMBER 11, 2001, Irvi was 19 years old and had recently arrived in upstate New York. He was working on a construction crew, remodeling a Chinese restaurant, when the Spanish music on the radio was interrupted by grave English he didn’t understand. Terrorists had flown jets into the World Trade Center. George W. Bush’s administration would soon abandon negotiations to grant legal status to undocumented Mexicans and instead create the Department of Homeland Security, with a mission to deport them.

But on September 12, Irvi’s employer still wanted him to come to work as if nothing had happened. It was the kind of mixed message that would characterize his life in the United States. After a few more years of construction work, he felt homesick and returned to Mexico. But as soon as he touched down there, he felt he’d made a mistake. He had grown up in a one-room house without running water, dreaming of riding a motorcycle—a luxury that he could never afford if he stayed. He started making plans to go back to New York right away.

Irvi’s parents, Lulu and Martín, were leery of his decision. Both were the children of peasant farmers and had grown up in homes made of adobe and sticks. But they never thought of joining the more than 8 million Mexicans who’d moved north, starting with their parents’ generation and the U.S. government’s Bracero Program for temporary workers. American farmers got hooked on cheap labor and, after the program ended in 1964, continued to recruit Mexican workers, who now had to cross the border illegally.

Lulu, a street vendor, was afraid that discouraging Irvi would backfire. Martín, a bus driver on Mexico’s dusty rural highways, couldn’t hold back. “That country will eat you,” he said of the United States. “Of course, here it’s more work and less money, but you get used to it.”

When Irvi told them he was going back, his parents knew they might never see him again. Martín thought to himself: *I don’t have a son anymore.*

With his 16-year-old cousin, Irvi tried to sneak back across the border somewhere in Arizona. They got lost in the desert, and Border Patrol agents found them. Irvi’s cousin started crying, and one of the agents gave them water, peanuts, and cookies. “Don’t

“AFTER 400
YEARS IN
THIS COUNTRY,”
DOUG TOLD ME,
“SUDDENLY
AMERICA DOESN’T
WANT MY
CHILDREN AND
GRANDCHILDREN.”

worry; you’re safe now,” the agent said in Spanish. “Tomorrow you can try again, and maybe you’ll make it.” After a few attempts, they were successful.

Back in upstate New York, Irvi returned to working in construction. He was determined to learn English, so he immersed himself in American music and television, especially *Chappelle’s Show*.

Around that time, Rachel, who grew up in a wealthy suburb of Philadelphia, graduated from Vassar. She had studied abroad in Mexico and taken a class with the geographer Joseph Nevins, who gave lectures about the American government’s complicity in a system that exploits immigrants for their labor but denies them the dignity of legal residency.

She and Irvi met on a sunny afternoon in 2006 while they were watching an outdoor soccer game in Poughkeepsie. She was hobbling around on crutches because of a sprained ankle, and he jumped up to help her. Rachel was swept away by Irvi’s sweetness and exuberance. Irvi loved Rachel’s intelligence and empathy. They talked about everything—their different upbringings, their jobs, their roommate drama. Soon he was visiting her on the weekends in Philadelphia, where she had gotten a job. On one trip, a police officer stopped him, saw that he was undocumented, and let him off with a warning. To avoid the risk of driving for visits, Irvi moved in.



Around 2009, they went to see the first of many lawyers, who said that Irvi wasn't eligible to apply for legal status, even if he married Rachel, because he had gone back and forth across the border after living for more than a year in the United States. The only work-around was for him to spend 10 years in Mexico and then apply for a waiver. But a Democratic Congress, with Barack Obama in the White House, appeared to be on the precipice of passing immigration reform.

Eventually, Rachel got a teaching job in New York, and they found an apartment in Harlem. Irvi started busing tables at the bistro on the Upper West Side, while Rachel taught overcrowded classrooms of low-income students. Despite the pressure and burn-out, she felt like she was offering kids a chance at the American dream. *No matter where you come from, she believed, if you land in a public school, and if you get a teacher like me, you can make it.* On their third anniversary, Irvi proposed in a rowboat in Central Park.

Sara was born in 2012, Ana in 2014. Irvi was their full-time caretaker, toting them by subway to museums, the aquarium, the zoo, and story time at the public libraries. On weekends, he squeezed in five shifts as a busboy. He and Rachel made enough money to cover the essentials, and Rachel's parents helped with child care, but they went years without paying for a haircut or buying new clothes. They sometimes fought when they were tired and felt like they hadn't seen each other in weeks, or when Irvi's spontaneity clashed with Rachel's need for order. But they could never stare each other down for long without cracking a smile.

Irvi's unresolved immigration status trailed them, usually from a distance. ICE agents once entered their apartment building looking for a neighbor; Rachel stood guard at the peephole while Irvi hid in the bedroom. A few years later, Irvi borrowed his in-laws' car to take the girls to Coney Island. As they approached the park, he spotted a police checkpoint at the entrance. He pulled over and had a panic attack, then tried to play it off by telling the girls that the car was breaking down.

Rachel and Irvi talked about what to do if ICE ever tried to arrest him while she was at work. Irvi would have to persuade the officers to wait long enough for Susan and Doug to pick up the girls. "You have to fight to make sure that our kids are safe," Rachel told him.

For years, Congress debated changes to the immigration system, including ones that would have helped Irvi. When Sara was old enough, she joined Rachel at protests with a sign that said DON'T DEPORT MY DAD. As part of a campaign called Dream Across America, Rachel rode a bus to Washington, D.C., where members of Congress admitted to activists that they hadn't known that so many mixed-status families were in limbo.

Rachel was stunned by Trump's first election, but Irvi had expected it. Up to this point, Sara and Ana had only a vague understanding that their father was different from them, but they began to realize that he was in danger. Ana lost interest in playing with other children and asked her parents why the president hated her. She had nightmares and panic attacks, and had to see a therapist. Irvi distracted her and Sara with bedtime stories about Eddie Spaghetti, a caricature of himself, who fought battles against dragons and monsters inspired by rude customers at his restaurant.

As they did their best to block out national politics, their community embraced them. Rachel's students nominated her for a Big Apple Award, which recognizes the best teachers in the city, and she became the head of the department at her school that teaches English as a new language. Ana and Sara became fixtures in their school plays and joined a children's choir that rehearsed at Riverside Church. At the bistro, Irvi was promoted to server and then manager. He took night shifts at the club in Inwood, and began bringing home more money than Rachel—enough to buy the motorcycle he had dreamed of.

They borrowed against Rachel's retirement savings for a down payment on a bright-blue townhouse in the Bronx's Little Italy. The house was far from a subway stop but had a spacious front porch that looked out onto a maple tree. The plumbing didn't work and some rooms had no windows; Irvi paid his construction-worker friends to help him fix it up. The family turned hiding their home's flaws into a giant art project, creating a mural out of postcards to cover up cracked walls and ornamenting the crooked old stairs with starburst wallpaper. Their American dream may have been spackled together with glue and construction paper, but it held.

Rachel was standing in the front yard with a rake in her hand when their next-door neighbor Cookie ran out and announced that the 2020 election had been called for Joe Biden. Rachel felt something new: optimism. She and Irvi daydreamed about finishing the basement and redoing the kitchen. They started to believe they would grow old together there.

During the summer of 2024, Biden announced a program, Keeping Families Together, that would finally allow people like Irvi to become citizens through their American spouse. Rachel holed up in their home office one Sunday with the application, attaching hundreds of documents that illustrated the life they had built together. She paid the government's \$580 fee and clicked "Submit."

"It looks like Irvi might finally be getting legal protection," she texted me at the time.

The next day, a federal judge put the program on hold after 16 Republican-led states sued. A few months later, Trump was reelected and the court terminated the program. Because of the application that Rachel had filed for Irvi, the incoming administration knew exactly who, and where, he was.

IN JANUARY 2025, after the holiday break, Rachel stayed up late watching TV interviews with survivors of the Los Angeles wildfires. She found comfort in hearing people say that even though their home was gone, they still had their family, and that's all that mattered. The girls picked 10 family activities to do before Irvi left the United States. Sara wanted to go ice skating in Central Park. Ana requested a day at the American Dream mall in New Jersey, which has a ski slope and a water park. They found discount tickets for *Hairspray*, *Gypsy*, and *Annie*.

On Irvi's last day in New York, January 13, 2025, the whole family piled into the car for school drop-offs. Trump was planning to end a policy that made schools off-limits for immigration raids, so Rachel was carrying a trifold poster board explaining what to do in an encounter with ICE. Sara was finishing a homework assignment about the writers of the Declaration of Independence. "Let's say, all of a sudden, you're reading a story in English, and it's about a dad, and all of a sudden you're feeling really sad," Rachel asked. "Do you have an adult that you can talk to?"

"Yes," the girls said in unison.

Irvi bopped his head to La Mega, the Spanish-language radio station that he and the girls listened to each morning. For more than two decades, he had tried to be perfect—perfect at work, perfect in his marriage, perfect as a father and neighbor, as if playing a game that he could eventually win. He told me he had slipped, once, 22 years ago, when he was briefly charged with a misdemeanor for carrying a small amount of cocaine—a one-time mistake in his early 20s. Though the charge was dropped, and doesn't even come up in a background check, Irvi said he didn't want to hide anymore, in any respect. But honesty and character didn't seem to matter to the incoming president, who was conflating all unauthorized immigrants with the people he called "illegal monsters"—the small number who had committed heinous crimes.

"That's not what I've been working for," Irvi said. "That's not what I deserve."

Irvi made a final visit to a Bronx bodega that served as a hangout for Mexican immigrants. He would go there when he felt homesick, or when he was tired of speaking English. His friends tried again to talk him out of leaving. Save more money first, they said, or talk to a lawyer—as if Irvi hadn't been talking

to lawyers for years. He left angry but arrived home sad, knowing he might never see those friends again.

He tucked the girls in that night and waited for Doug, Rachel's father, to arrive. Around 3 a.m., the two men, along with Mango the cat, climbed into an SUV that Irvi had bought on Facebook Marketplace and then crammed with their belongings.

The three-day drive was smooth until they arrived at a gas station in South Texas that was swarming with Border Patrol agents. Irvi started panicking, and his face went gray. They stopped briefly at a family friend's house, where they had planned to stay the night, but Irvi's nervous system was telling him to get out of the country *now*. By Inauguration Day, he was in his hometown of San Lorenzo Cacaotepec. His parents had spent 20 years scraping together money to rebuild their house out of concrete and add a second structure—which meant there was now room for Irvi, his sister, and their families.

Irvi rose in the dark each morning and drove along a rocky dirt road to a small plot of land that his mother had inherited. There were no blaring car horns or subway trains



Above: Rachel, Ana, and Pinto the dog take a break from packing in July 2025. Opposite page: The Cruz family in 2018.

roaring underground. Just birdsong and rustling leaves. Irvi was enchanted and unnerved by Oaxaca's clear blue skies, unmarred by skyscrapers. He spent hours hunched over outside each day, digging in his family's land, pruning and picking, and breaking a sweat as soon as the sun came up. Along with relatives, he planted tomatoes, peppers, and onions, and sold them at outdoor markets. He barely broke even. His father had been right—in Mexico, you work more for less—and Irvi was struggling to adapt. He had been able to get anywhere in New York City without a map, but in Oaxaca he felt lost. "I have to start over again," he told me. "It's like I wasted all that time in New York now that I'm here. Everything I learned doesn't apply."

He could not stand to watch the videos, flooding his phone, of armed ICE agents smashing car windows and wrestling fathers to the ground while their crying children watched from the back seat. The plan that he and Rachel had formulated all those years ago—for him to connect the girls with their grandparents before ICE could detain him—would never have worked. He would have been overpowered and dragged away. He hadn't been in control then, he realized, and didn't feel in control now.

It didn't help that his relatives worried that Rachel and the girls might never join him. They couldn't believe that U.S. citizens would trade the privileges of their home country just to be with Irvi. A cousin told him: "You're going to have to find a new wife."

RACHEL NEVER THOUGHT of abandoning Irvi—not since the rowboat in Central Park. But she often felt guilty that he had to bear the psychological burden of their relationship. Now she thought it was her turn to sacrifice to keep the family together.

Without Irvi to pick the girls up from school with homemade sandwiches, Sara and Ana learned to ride the subway, texting him regular updates in the family's group chat. As their friends studied for entrance exams to the city's competitive middle and high schools, Sara refused to talk about her feelings and retreated into her phone. Ana's nightmares returned. She was valedictorian of her fifth-grade homeroom class and teared up during her speech when she mentioned Irvi, who was watching over FaceTime.

Once school let out for the summer—and as ICE agents stormed immigration courthouses downtown—Rachel and the girls took apart their New York lives. The postcards and pictures came down, revealing the cracked walls underneath. Rachel became engrossed in Facebook videos of other moms who were documenting their families' self-deportation process and describing their relief to be out of the United States.

Sara had a final sleepover with friends. Two of them took her phone into a closet to record a message for her to listen to in Mexico. "You're an amazing friend," they said. "We're gonna miss you so much."

Rachel bought a trailer for the last of their belongings. Her co-workers threw her a surprise party. The goodbyes "were more like *See you later's*," Rachel said. "They're not the same goodbyes as Irvi's." Her assistant principal told me that replacing a teacher of her skill level would take years.



Rachel found a private school in Oaxaca for the girls and secured a job for herself, at an annual salary of \$10,700—not nearly enough to live on, even in rural Mexico, and a pittance compared with her \$120,000 salary in New York. They had accepted an offer on their house in the spring, but the deal still hadn't closed by July. Rachel couldn't afford the bills without Irvi's income, and her debts were mounting. She told the girls they were leaving August 1, with or without the house money.

Rachel's father still couldn't believe it had come to this. "I'm heartbroken because I believe in this country in an almost religious way," Doug told me. But as a country, he said, "we fucked up."

Rachel and the girls—plus Coleslaw the cat and Pinto the dog—had planned to stop at tourist attractions to say goodbye to the United States. But Rachel was so frustrated and anxious by the time they left that they stopped only to sleep. She sped to the border, her adrenaline pumping.

Irvi flew to northern Mexico to finish the two-day drive with them. Rachel spent the first night at his parents' house



wide awake and in tears. She told Irvi she felt like she couldn't breathe. They reminded themselves that if Oaxaca didn't work out, they could try Mexico City. Or they could apply for visas to move to Spain or Canada.

As Doug had told them, "The whole world is open to you now, except for your home country."

Irvi harvests peppers in Oaxaca in November 2025.

ANA, NOW 11, put up a few Broadway posters in her new bedroom. Sara, now 13, hung birthday cards from friends in New York. They stuck their favorite *New Yorker* covers on the walls.

When I arrived to visit them in early November, three months into their reunion, Irvi was still going to the farm before sunrise, and Rachel and the girls would leave home at 6 a.m. for the bumpy ride to school, which involved driving through a creek to reach a paved road. Ana said the hardest part about the move was leaving her New York friends, because it had taken her many years to make

them. She made one friend at her new school whose family had moved from Canada that year; they sat together at lunch, talking about what it was like to start over somewhere new. Meanwhile, Sara sauntered across campus in a swarm of girls, who delighted in practicing their English skills on her. Though the school was technically bilingual, their teachers mostly spoke Spanish. In class, both girls' eyes glazed over. They looked lost.

Sara and Ana did their best to hide their discomfort in front of Irvi. "I try to say to myself that I'm not the only one and I should be calm about this," Ana told me, "because people have done it before and I'm pretty sure they've turned out fine." Plus, she said, "I will have a great college essay."

But sometimes their anguish spilled out. They were used to excelling in school, and now they felt like they weren't learning anything. One night, when Sara was struggling with homework, she lashed out at her parents, yelling exactly what Irvi had been afraid to hear: "I didn't choose to move here!" She ran up to her room. Irvi stayed on the living-room couch. They cried, separately.

Outside those emotional swells, the family was relieved to be together, and free of the dread that had hung over them in New York. They relished the meals that Irvi's mother, Lulu, prepared for them: rich and tangy beef, chicken-and-vegetable stew, fluffy corn cakes piled with salsa and beans. With all of their children and grandchildren at home, she and Martín now felt that they could live out their lives in peace.

Sara and Ana told me they felt safer in Mexico. Rachel agreed, but worried about the friends and family they'd left behind. She thought they were too close to see what the United States was becoming.

Rachel taught English at her new school, mostly through songs. She had free time for the first time in her adult life, but felt bored. When their house in the Bronx finally sold, she

bought a few luxuries to make their new home more comfortable: a refrigerator, an oven, and a washing machine, so they wouldn't have to scrub their clothes on the concrete washboard Irvi's mom used. They paid off their debts, and had surprisingly little money left over, even with Rachel tutoring children of wealthy Mexican families on weekends and after school.

They felt lucky to have had the freedom to immigrate to Mexico; no relatives in the United States relied on their care, and the sale of the Bronx townhouse funded the move. But it was still unclear how they would support themselves now that they were here. Rachel tried to be patient as Irvi figured out a plan. He had worked for so many years in the United States without a break, and he was clearly depressed. He knew he had to sell his motorcycle. He spent all day on the farm streaming Hot 97, an English-language radio station in New York. At night, he would scroll the social-media feed of the nightclub where he'd worked, telling Rachel which artists had performed and who had gotten into fights, until she snapped. "I don't care," she said, pleading with him to leave New York in the past.

They tried to distract themselves with excursions on the weekends, but every time they got in the car, Irvi would either go quiet or unravel, then beat himself up for days. Rachel was frustrated that he couldn't let them have a good time, until she realized that the only travel Irvi had ever done had been unpredictable and dangerous. He didn't know how to enjoy a trip with his family, because he'd never had the chance.

Irvi's father, Martín, places his hands on his son's shoulders at a family gathering in San Lorenzo Cacaotepec in November 2025.



NATALIE KEYSAR FOR THE ATLANTIC

“I’m trying to be positive,” Irvi told me, but he felt like a disappointment. He began to pull away from the girls. He seemed to miss the United States more as time went on, not less. In Oaxaca, another American family invited them over to celebrate their first Thanksgiving in Mexico. He took one bite of stuffing and burst into tears. But that same month, he saw on Instagram that ICE had raided his bodega hangout in the Bronx. One of his friends—a father who worked as a bike messenger for a Chinese restaurant—was taken away.

Irvi tried to reconnect with his relatives by attending birthday and anniversary parties. (“Half the town are his cousins,” Rachel told me.) He took me along to one party, in a small house with a concrete floor. Plastic tables, with bowls of taco fixings, were set up in a long row that stretched from the kitchen into the living room.

I sat with two of Irvi’s aunts, Chela Santiago and Blanca Méndez, who are in their late 60s and have spent their whole lives in San Lorenzo Cacaotepec. Their fathers traveled back and forth to the United States, first as Braceros, then as unauthorized farmhands. Since then, dozens of relatives have followed. Chela’s brother went to New York in the 1990s and slept 10 to a room.

“What they say about the United States isn’t true,” he said when he returned. “They treat you like animals.”

Without poor Mexicans, Blanca told me, the U.S. would not exist. “I would like for all the Mexicans in the United States to come here,” she said, “and then let’s see what the United States really is.”

Though Irvi was only a few seats away, she offered another blunt assessment of those who choose to leave home: “Sometimes they go because they want a life that isn’t theirs. Here, we live authentically.”

Irvi was quiet. The United States was where he’d become a man, a husband, a father, a homeowner, a model citizen in every respect except the one that mattered to the U.S. government. Now he had done what his aunt wanted—what President Trump wanted—and he was beginning to live with that choice. Surrounded by family, he looked like a man without a home.

P EOPLE WHO MIGRATE across borders leave pieces of themselves behind—pieces that don’t fit neatly back into place, even upon return. Irvi had known this since he was 19. A year after the family decided to leave the U.S., Rachel and the girls were discovering it, too. They went to New York to visit Rachel’s parents this past Christmas; right away, Sara bought frosted strawberry Pop-Tarts to bring back to her classmates in Oaxaca. She giggled on the phone at night with her new Mexican boyfriend. But Rachel had to pry her and Ana away from playdates with their New York friends. She changed the subject when they asked about visiting again for spring break in a few months.

They ate traditional Chinese food in one friend’s home, Russian in another, Dominican in another—the kind of New York experience that they were all realizing they missed. During one visit in Harlem, Rachel asked to speak with me alone, at a coffee shop nearby. When we sat together, she finally broke down. She felt guilty every time she heard her daughters say they were

PEOPLE WHO
MIGRATE ACROSS
BORDERS LEAVE
PIECES OF
THEMSELVES
BEHIND—PIECES
THAT DON’T
FIT NEATLY BACK
INTO PLACE, EVEN
UPON RETURN.

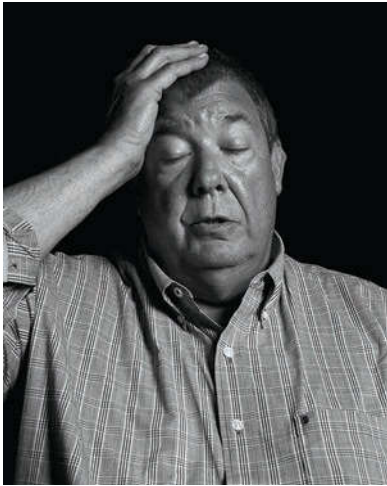
happy to be “home” for the holidays. She saw them falling behind their New York friends academically, so she bought an algebra book to teach them herself. Her old fear of ICE was coursing through her body, even though Irvi was safe in Mexico. And she had been stifling these emotions around her parents all week, because none of them wanted to be the first to cry.

“We tried so hard to make it work,” she told me. “I can’t think of anything else we could have done. And that’s the hardest thing about being here. We’re nice people. My kids are amazing. New York City would have been so lucky to have my kids.”

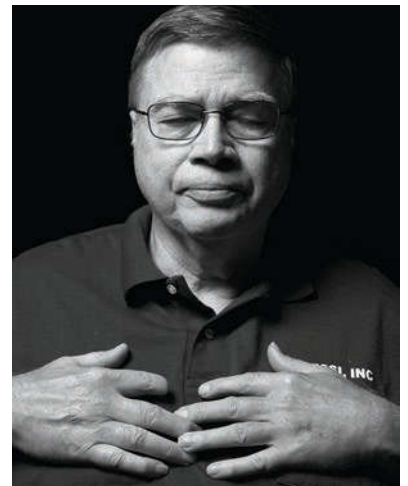
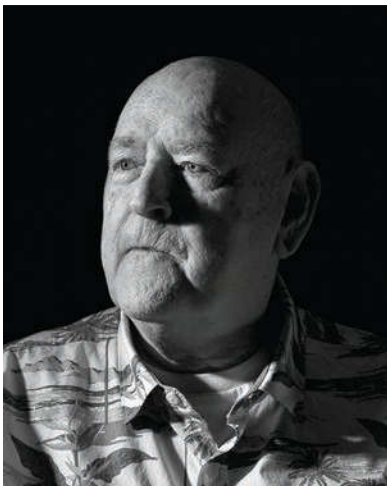
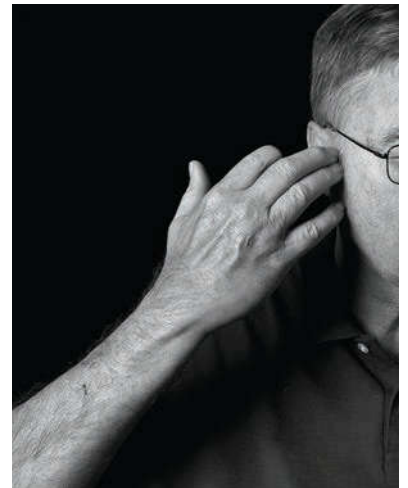
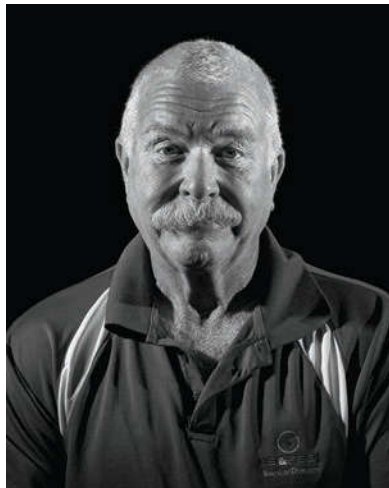
She told me that a few days earlier, she had gone to visit an uncle in her old neighborhood in the Bronx, but avoided driving past the bright-blue house. Cookie, their neighbor, had reported that another family moved in but left within weeks. The house was dark and empty. The gardens were a mess. An old couch was outside, rotting.

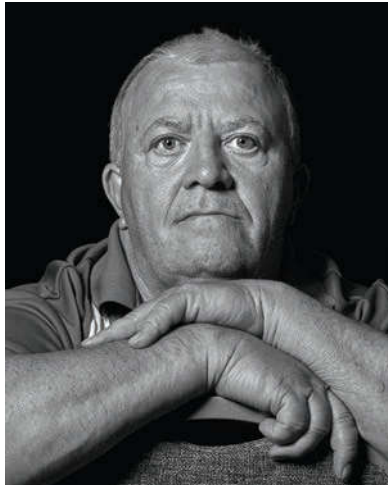
The Cruzes had poured themselves into that house. Now it looked like they had never lived there. Rachel couldn’t bear to see it. *A*

Caitlin Dickerson is a staff writer at The Atlantic. She received a Pulitzer Prize in 2023 for her immigration coverage.



S T R U C K





What getting hit by
lightning does to the
body and mind

By Jacob Stern

Photographs by
Stacy Kranitz



W

hat does it feel like to be struck by lightning?

There is no easy analogue. A defibrillator delivers up to 1,000 volts to a patient's heart; inmates executed by electric chair typically receive about 2,000. A typical lightning strike, by contrast, transmits *100 million* volts or more. But lightning races through the body in milliseconds, and therefore often spares it. Some people black out instantly upon being struck. Others recall the moment vividly, as if in slow motion: the flash of light whiting out all vision; the sound, which many survivors say is the loudest they've ever heard. The pain, for some, is excruciating, yet others feel no pain at all. "It felt like adrenaline, but stronger," one survivor reported. "I felt an incredible pulsing," another said, "a burning sensation from head to toe."

The severity of the resulting injury depends on, among countless other variables, how the electricity enters the body, and where, and the path the current takes through it. Direct strikes are the deadliest, but most strikes are indirect—a side flash coming off a tree, a current running through the ground, a streamer rising up from below—and most people survive these.

In some cases, the damage is immediately apparent. Lightning, in addition to being very bright and very loud, is very hot—the air around it can hit temperatures about five times hotter than the surface of the sun—and so it can singe or burn people. The shock wave from the strike can fling victims a great distance, breaking bones or causing concussions as they land. The current inscribes some victims' skin with mysterious scarlike

patterns called Lichtenberg figures, which resemble the limbs of a barren tree—or the branching structure of lightning itself.

Just as often, though, survivors manifest no burns, bruises, or scars. Even Lichtenberg figures generally vanish within a few days; no one knows exactly why. On the outside, survivors look normal. Which doesn't mean they feel that way.

Many of the body's essential systems—the heart, the brain, the nervous system—depend on electrical signals, and lightning can throw these thoroughly out of whack. Forgetfulness, sleep problems, sexual dysfunction, and headaches that manifest as intense pressure—like "my eyeballs are just popping out," one person told me—are common. Some people become hypersensitive to noise; others lose their hearing entirely. A few, almost miraculously, are freed of a prior ailment: a bad leg healed; vision, once impaired, restored. Pretty much all of them feel permanently off balance. Some have to relearn simple things, things they've done their whole life—how to read, how to sing, how to ride a bike.

Phantom sensations are prevalent. One woman told me she often feels as though water is running down her limbs. Another, in a Facebook group for survivors, said she feels "an indescribable itching" coming from inside the back of her head. Inexplicable odors can emerge; food can taste like cardboard or glue. The symptoms can last for decades. Yet standard neurological imaging, such as MRI scans, almost never detects abnormalities, and most physicians, who understand the symptoms' basis in only the most rudimentary sense, can offer little useful counsel. Faith in survivors'



Previous pages: Attendees of the 2025 conference of Lightning Strike and Electrical Shock Survivors International, in Pigeon Forge, Tennessee

Above: Steve Marshburn Sr., the founder of the group, seated at a conference luncheon. The conference always has a theme, and that year's was Hawaii.



stories—among friends, colleagues, even loved ones—can waver.

The most fundamental consequences of being struck by lightning are often metaphorical, and not easily communicable. How does falling victim to one of the most notoriously unlikely of all misfortunes reorient your sense of chance, of fate? How does it feel, when you're trying to describe the most transformative experience of your life, to be met, routinely, with disbelief?

LAST MAY, I ATTENDED a conference of Lightning Strike and Electrical Shock Survivors International. It was held, as it often is, in Pigeon Forge, Tennessee, a smallish town on the edge of the Great Smoky Mountains best known as the home of Dollywood, Dolly Parton's Appalachia-themed amusement park. The town's main drag resembles a sort of family-friendly version of the Las Vegas strip. Instead of casinos, there are dinner-show theaters, go-kart

tracks, and a sprawling Margaritaville megacomplex, its central fountain inhabited by giant animatronic *Brachiosaurus* that roar from time to time.

The conference was staged at a Staybridge Suites just off the strip. About 30 people were there, mostly men who looked to be over the age of 60, many of them conference regulars who'd been struck long ago, though there were some women and younger attendees too. Most had brought

their spouse and were making a weekend of it. They were there primarily to connect with other people who understood what they had been through.

Like senior prom, the conference always has a theme, and this year's was Hawaii. Survivors wore leis, and pineapples adorned with sunglasses sat on every table in the Staybridge's modest meeting room. A folding table converted into a makeshift tiki bar dispensed virgin piña coladas and hurricanes. Against this backdrop, specialists gave presentations on trauma therapies. Attendees compared notes on which treatments have worked for them and which haven't.

In one session, a man I'll call Matt, a young, redheaded survivor who for a year and a half after his strike could hardly feel pain, temperature, or most other sensations on much of his skin, said laser therapy had eventually restored his nerves. Having a massage therapist work on his vagus nerve had helped too. For a while, he'd slept inside a Faraday cage, to protect him from static electricity during storms. Today, to cope with intrusive thoughts about lightning, he dumps a packet of salt in his mouth because when you do that, he said, "that's all you can think about."

A woman I'll call Caroline, who'd been struck on the job two years earlier, used

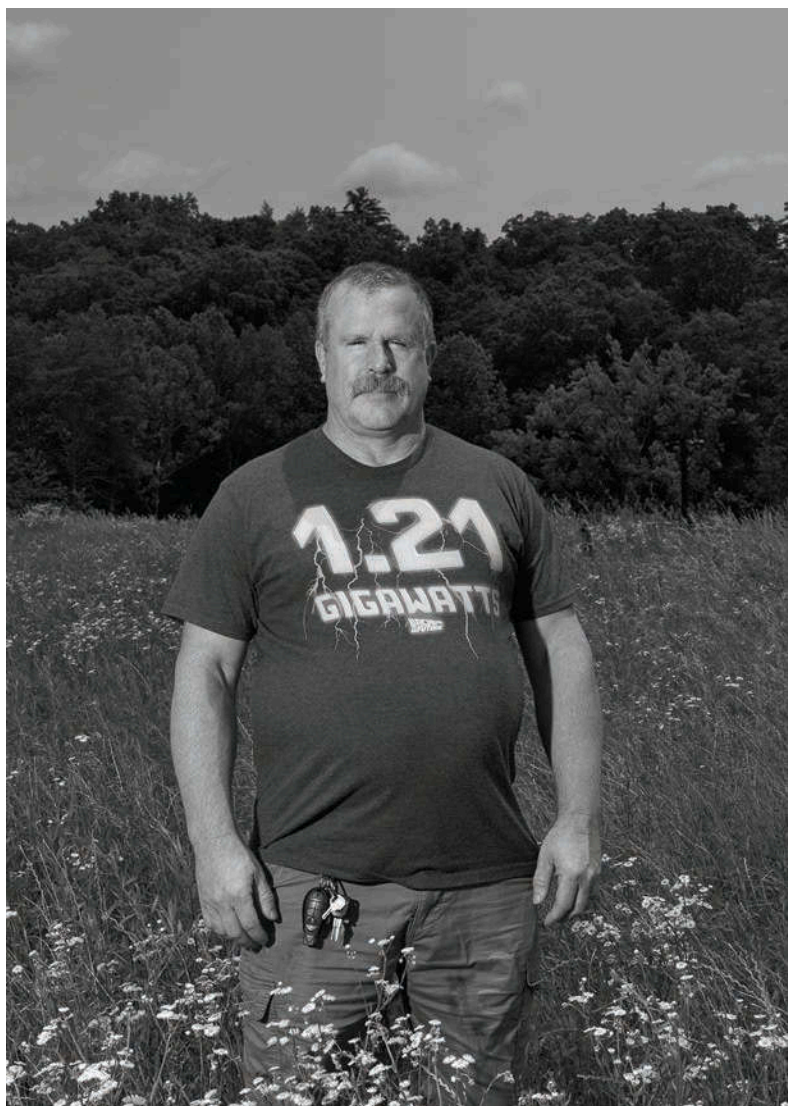
that same strategy, she said, only with Warheads candies instead of salt. One problem she had not solved was that no matter how hot she gets, no matter how hard she exerts herself, she can't sweat anymore. Matt said he'd had the same problem for a while. What fixed it for him was spending significant time in a sauna—up to 90 minutes three times a day.

If the discussion had a certain DIY quality to it, that reflects the paucity of medical literature on what lightning does to the body. Few systematic studies have been conducted, and most physicians have never treated a strike victim. Many survivors' experiences defy medical explanation, so doctors have little to say.

Given the limited counsel that the medical establishment can offer them, survivors tend to be open to alternative therapies, but they're also wary of being taken advantage of. At the conference, several attendees reminisced about the year when two "hippies" had shown up and started hawking New Age-type products. "They said they were linked in voodoo," one survivor recalled.

Much of the group conversation focused on Caroline, whose injury was the freshest. She used to cook her family elaborate meals, but "after the accident," she said, "I left the oven on so many times that I even ended up burning the element out." For a while she refused to get a new one, because she worried she'd burn the house down. She leaves sticky notes everywhere to remind her of what she needs to do, but even so, she rarely has the energy to do all of it. She has to ask for help, which makes her feel bossy. She worries that others think she's lazy.

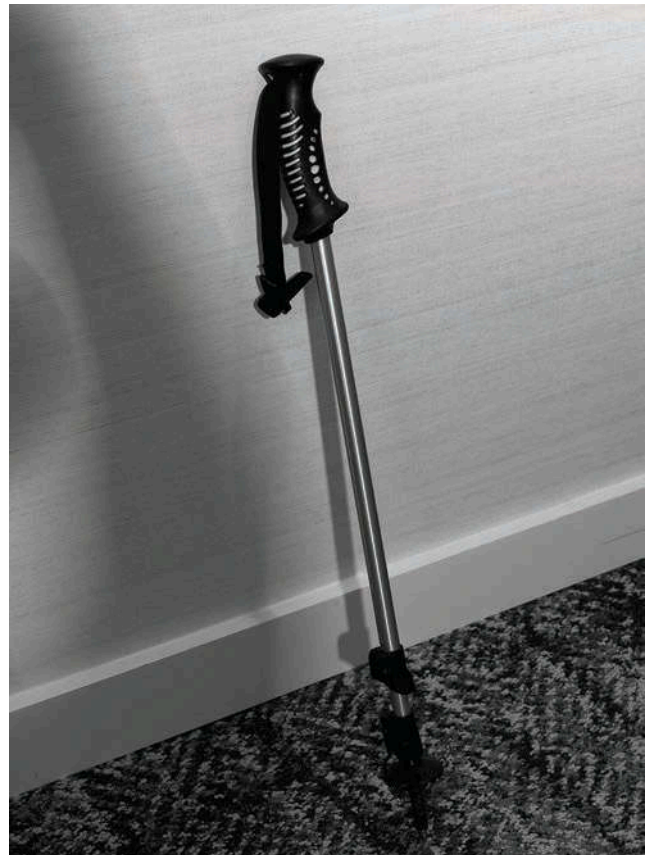
Gary Reynolds's experiences after he was struck in the summer of 2007 were similar. He was grabbing sodas from his family's extra fridge, he'd told me earlier, when lightning hit him through the open garage door. For months, he could barely get out of bed. His whole body hurt constantly. He had trouble concentrating, and simple tasks that had once been second nature now seemed complex. On warm afternoons, he watched the sky warily. A therapist diagnosed him with PTSD, which by some estimates afflicts more than



25 percent of lightning-strike survivors. In 2009, just a few months shy of their 20th anniversary, Reynolds and his wife divorced. Initially she'd been sympathetic, he said, but over time she lost patience. "You're not over this yet?" Reynolds recalled her saying. "It can't be that bad."

"I just keep thinking, *I want to wake up the next day and it's going to be normal*," Caroline said at one point during the session. But she wasn't even two years out from her strike. She had not yet come to the conclusion that the veteran survivors at the conference had reached long ago: that no matter what you do, no matter how many therapies you try, you still have to accept that you'll never be the person you were before. "You still look the same and everything else, but it's like a different person inside," Reynolds said. "It's a different soul."

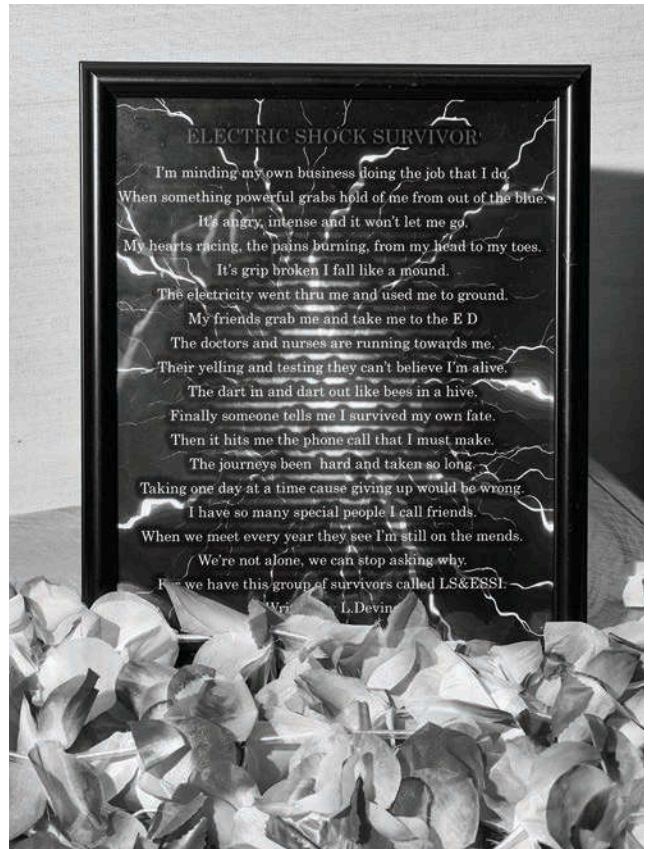
THE ODDS of being struck by lightning in the United States in a given year are roughly one in 1.2 million, according to a 2019 analysis by the National Weather



Opposite page:
Gary Reynolds, who
was first struck
in 2007

Above: A walking
stick used by one
attendee

Below: A poem
describing the
feeling of being
struck, and then
the aftermath,
by Lisa Devine,
who attended
the conference
with her husband,
Danny, a strike
survivor



Service—about the same as flipping a coin and landing on heads 20 times in a row. But this is only a generic estimate. The likelihood of being struck in San Francisco is not the same as the likelihood of being struck in Orlando, last year's urban lightning capital of America. The likelihood of being struck for lawyers is not the same as the likelihood of being struck for roofers.

The majority of people killed by lightning—about 20 each year in the U.S.—are struck while engaging in some sort of outdoor leisure or labor. But in truth, almost anyone can be struck almost anytime. People have been struck while talking on landlines, while using computers, even while sitting on the toilet, according to the National Weather Service, because current can travel through telephone wires, electrical connections, and metal pipes. When lightning survivors insist, as many do, on unplugging their appliances in preparation for a storm, this is not tinfoil-hat mania. And the old advice about not showering during a thunderstorm? Sensible.

Steve Marshburn Sr., who founded Lightning Strike and Electrical Shock Survivors International in 1989, told me that he was struck at age 25 on a seemingly clear November morning in 1969. He was working as a teller at First Citizens Bank in Swansboro, North Carolina, sitting at the drive-through window, and he thinks the bolt must have passed through an ungrounded speaker. For years, he struggled not only with debilitating headaches and back problems, but also with the sheer improbability of the event that had produced them. Many of the doctors he visited didn't believe his story. For a long time, even his parents wondered whether he was making the whole thing up.

And to some extent, Marshburn understands why. "It's so unbelievable that it's hard to talk about," he said. Eventually, a doctor introduced him to another patient who had survived an electrical injury, and that experience led Marshburn to start his survivors' group. Membership now numbers about 2,000, and in September the organization hosted its first-ever West Coast conference, in Scottsdale, Arizona. For years, most people found their way to the group via their local weather station, or

after seeing it featured in news outlets or on TV. Now more find it through Facebook.

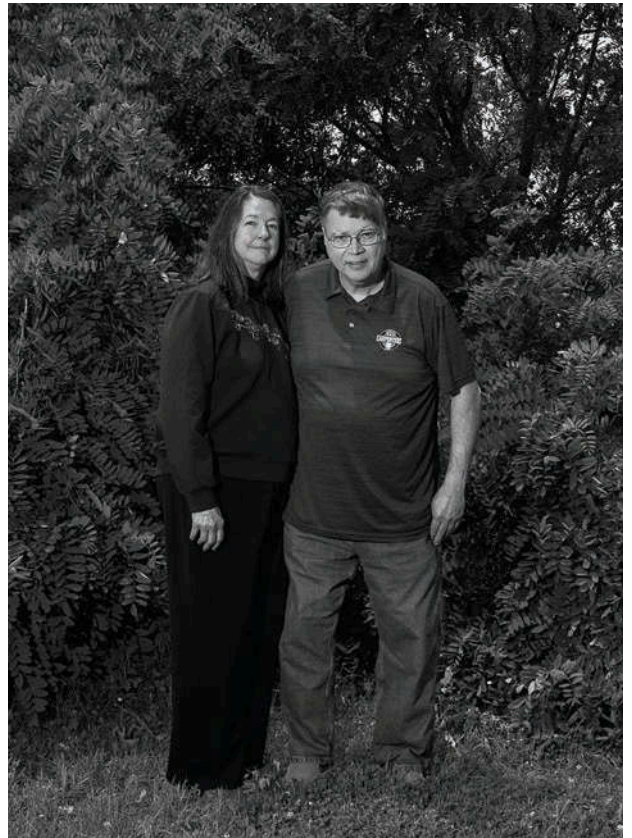
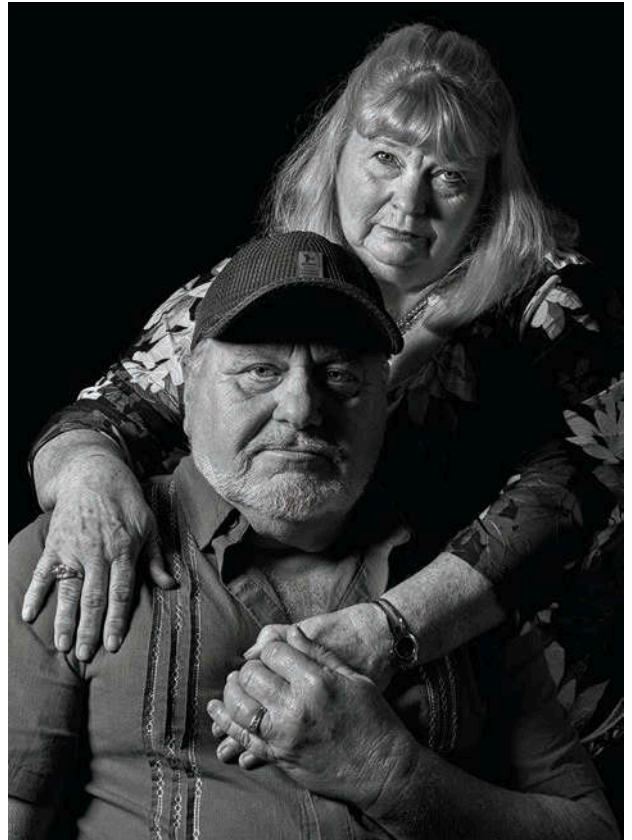
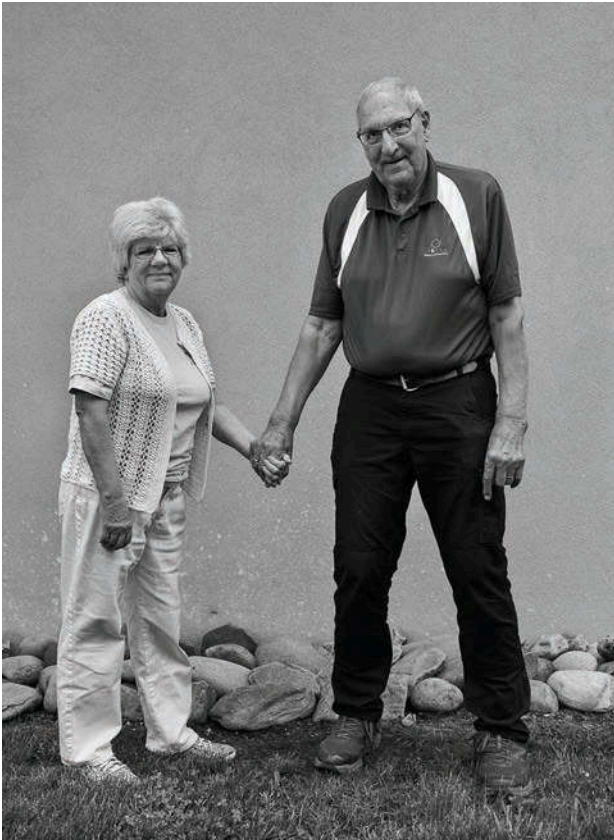
That's how Gary Reynolds did. His second wife, Lisa, discovered the group while searching online for other people who'd been struck, people who could understand him. Doctors never had. When he first went to the emergency room, they ran a battery of tests, but the results all came back normal. After he'd been at the hospital for about nine hours, a doctor said, "I'm not really sure what to tell you," and sent him home. Roughly the same thing happened when he visited his primary-care physician. Other doctors told him to his face that he was making the whole thing up.

Not until his first conference did he meet people who could truly empathize with him. He'd never spoken with a fellow lightning-strike survivor in person before, and he was nervous on the drive up, but when he arrived he felt almost like he was at a reunion. "You walk into that room and it's like we're family," he said. After he joined the group, he felt normal for the first time in years. "It was validating," he said. "Like, *Okay, I'm not crazy.*"

IN JUNE 2008, Reynolds told me, he was struck by lightning a second time. It was 11 months after his first strike, and he'd woken up at 2 a.m. with an awful headache. Ever since the initial incident, his head had throbbed in exactly the same spot when he sensed a storm coming. As he lay beside his open bedroom window, he felt a shock go through his hand. "*Not again,*" he thought. Half of his hand turned bright red, he said, but he hadn't yet paid off the previous year's hospital bills, and this strike seemed less serious than the last, so he decided not to seek care. In the following months, though, his lingering symptoms from the first strike all worsened. He was often dizzy, and he couldn't grip well. Reynolds ran a tree service at the time, one he'd started a few years after high school, and these were serious problems for someone whose vocation involved wielding a chainsaw. The divorce came about six months later.

In the years that followed, Reynolds pieced his life back together: He remarried, moved his family to western North Carolina, began working at a lumberyard,

Clockwise from top left: Electrical-shock survivor Rodney Burkholder and lightning-strike survivors Danny Devine, Danny "Joe" Jude, and Betsy Silby, in Pigeon Forge with their partners and caregivers



started attending survivors' conferences. Then, while standing in the kitchen of his mountainside home on a June afternoon in 2016, he was struck a third time. And six years after that, a fourth, he said, this time while sitting in a leather recliner watching TV with his grandchildren. Must've been a streamer, he told me. Came up through the floor and hit him square in the back.

If the likelihood of getting struck once in your lifetime is one in 15,300, as the National Weather Service estimated in 2019, then statistically, the number of people in the United States today whom you'd expect to have been struck multiple times is ... one. One single person. And yet the National Weather Service's collection of about 50 lightning-survivor stories on its website includes two from people who say they've been struck twice and another from someone who says she's been struck three times. Andy Upshaw, a North Carolina landscaper, says that he, too, has been hit three times. Charles Winlake, struck four times before the age of 30, added rubber

soles to all of his shoes and began to wear only plastic-rimmed glasses. Linda Cooper, a former South Carolina schoolteacher, says she's been struck six times, and so does Carl Mize, a former Oklahoma rodeo rider. One member of the Lightning Strike and Electric Shock Survivors Support Facebook group says she's been struck nine times, and another says she stopped counting after 13. Media reports document more multistrike cases. In all, my far-from-exhaustive search turned up more than two dozen.

All of this, to state the obvious, is incredibly improbable. Extrapolating from the National Weather Service estimates, the likelihood of being struck six times is roughly one in 13 septillion—that's a 13 followed by 24 zeros. If you multiplied the number of people who have ever existed on Earth by about 100 trillion, you'd expect one person among them to have been struck six times.

It can seem cruel to suggest that some lightning-strike survivors may be lying, especially when disbelief causes so much

Charles O'Connor Jr.,
a lightning-strike
survivor, attending
the conference for
the first time with
his wife, Chrissy



hardship for those who are not. But because relatively few lightning strikes are documented, the question often lingers. People lie for all kinds of reasons, and there can be financial incentives to claiming you've been struck: workers' compensation, disability benefits. Mary Ann Cooper was an emergency-medicine faculty member at the University of Louisville when she published the first systematic study of lightning injury in 1980—instantly becoming the leading authority on the subject in doing so. Cooper served for years as an expert witness in workers'-comp cases, brought in to assess whether the claimant really had been struck. She told me that she's encountered some frauds, identifiable because they reported inconsistent or physiologically impossible symptoms.

But the people trying to cheat their way into benefits, Cooper said, are largely not the ones attending survivors' conferences. She believes that the overwhelming majority of the people she has met at those conferences are telling the truth about being struck, and about all the calamities that followed, at least as they understand them. Which is not to say that every statement should be taken at face value.

Like several doctors and scientists I spoke with, Cooper thinks that most people who say they've been struck multiple times genuinely believe that, even if they haven't. Many survivors have flashbacks as a result of PTSD, just as combat veterans and wildfire survivors do. But when a combat veteran or a wildfire survivor resurfaces from a flashback, their surroundings verify to them that they are not, in fact, caught in the middle of a war zone or a fire. A lightning-strike flashback prompted by a storm involves no such assurance. A lightning bolt is there and gone in an instant.

What's more, because lightning leaves the nervous system damaged, it can make people feel bursts of pain—real, excruciating, and unconnected to any physical stimulus. Together, PTSD and nervous-system damage may explain many reports of second or third or fourth strikes.

Not so long ago, that explanation might have sounded far-fetched, just as some of the chronic symptoms of a lightning strike still do, to some. But the idea that trauma can alter the way people

perceive the world and interpret their experience is ubiquitous now. And the emergence of long COVID, along with increased awareness of other difficult-to-diagnose chronic conditions, has created a greater respect for individual testimony, and a greater appreciation for how much the medical profession does not know. In this sense, society is finally catching up to what lightning survivors and the people who study them have long understood.

The most grinding suspicions encountered by many survivors—about whether they were ever really struck at all—may in any case be mooted in the coming years. On a recent trip to France, Cooper met with a physician who told her he'd identified a biological marker for lightning injury, which may enable doctors to determine, with a simple urine test, whether someone really has been struck. Nothing has been published on it yet, Cooper said, and no such test seems imminent, so for the moment she isn't getting too excited. But she has an open mind to the possibility.

All of this, of course, is mostly to the good. Yet the lightning-survivor community has always defined itself by a sort of oppositional faith: *There, you are doubted; here, you are believed. There, you are strange; here, you are normal.* When I asked Reynolds what he made of the trauma-plus-nervous-system-damage theory of why there are so many multistrike survivors, I felt as though I was doing something almost sacrilegious, as though I was violating that ethos of mutual faith. I worried that he'd react with indignation. The notion that he might hang up on me and refuse to speak with me again did not seem unlikely. Instead, he said he thought the theory made a lot of sense.

Might then it explain his multiple strikes? I asked.

Well, he answered, not his.

WHAT DOES ONE MAKE of a life so fundamentally altered by an event as unlikely as a lightning strike? In Pigeon Forge, when I asked survivors whether on balance they felt lucky (for having survived a lightning strike) or unlucky (for having been struck in the first place), the question didn't register. "I don't think luck has anything to do with it," Susan Deatruck told

me. She doesn't like the word *providential* either, she said, "but at the same time, God is in control over everything down to the minutest detail."

This response, and others like it, initially surprised me. If lightning is a manifestation of the divine, I thought, how do people explain why it struck them? How do you make sense of a miracle that comes at your expense?

Jim Segneri, who moderated the conference's final and most intense group discussion, has a succinct answer, one more focused on his having been spared than his having been struck. "I firmly believe that whether you worship Allah or Buddha or God or Jesus or whoever put us here, the reason we're still here is so that we can help other people"—those who are doubted, those who are struggling.

Large numbers of survivors hold some version of this belief. Marshburn, the group's founder, often speaks of the number of survivors—more than 20—whom he has talked out of suicide, reciting in vivid detail the conversations he's had with people on the brink. Over her many years speaking with lightning-strike victims, Mary Ann Cooper said, "I can't tell you how many people have said to me, 'I should have been dead. God must have kept me alive for a reason.'"

And yet for those survivors who hold it, the belief in destiny can cut both ways. Reynolds says that after his third strike, he felt doomed. He'd left his career, gotten divorced, gotten remarried, started a new job, moved more than 600 miles away—and still the lightning had found him. "It's like it's looking for me," he told his therapist. "It's like it's a living, breathing creature."

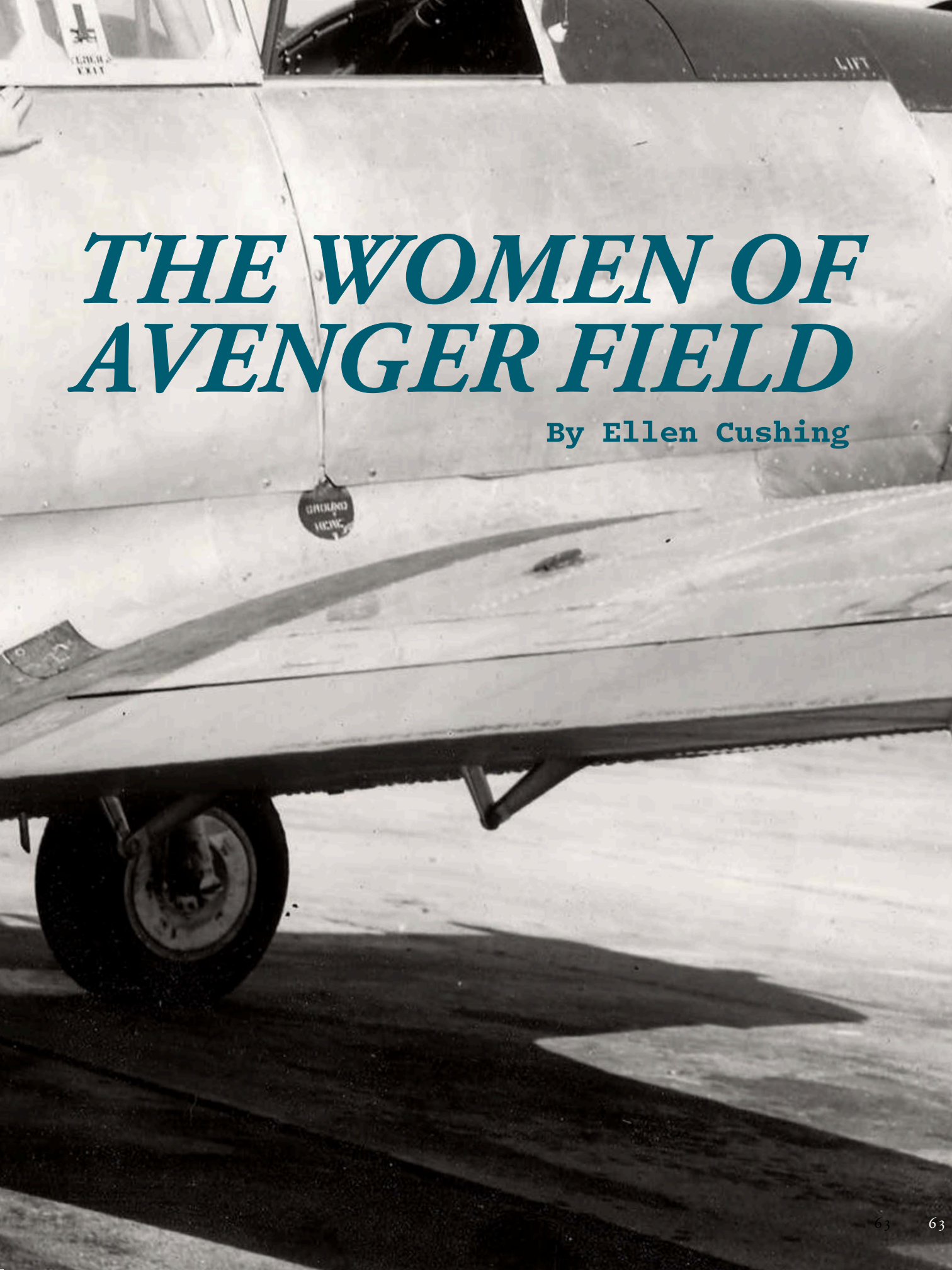
She assured him that it wasn't, and part of him knew she was right, but he couldn't stop thinking that he was fated to be struck again. She told him that she doesn't believe in destiny. That there is no providence, only circumstance. That sometimes you're just in the wrong place at the wrong time. He'd believed that once. But now he can't shake the feeling that she's wrong. *A*

Jacob Stern is a contributing writer at The Atlantic.

**THEY BRAVELY
SERVED AS PILOTS
IN WORLD WAR II.
THEN AMERICA
FORGOT THEM.**



The author's grandmother Patricia Perry joined the Women Airforce Service Pilots in 1943.



THE WOMEN OF AVENGER FIELD

By Ellen Cushing

Recently, I stood in an airfield in Sweetwater, Texas, and looked up. I was wondering what it would have been like to take off from there in a small plane, flying into the dust of West Texas and the chaos of World War II, as my grandmother had. The land around me had the palette of a well-used watercolor set and the topography of a paper towel: gray and brown, flat forever. It is dry all year round, except when it suddenly pours. The wide, featureless landscape makes for big, blustery winds and difficult orientation. Also, it is famous for its rattlesnakes.

During World War II, Sweetwater's Avenger Field was the primary home of a program that trained women to fly military planes. They were called Women Airforce Service Pilots—WASPs—and they were the solution to a high-stakes problem: The war needed pilots, and men were dying quickly. From 1942 to 1944, these women volunteers engaged in just about every aspect of military flight operations except combat—ferrying aircraft, testing planes, transporting cargo, training new pilots—so that the men would be free to fight in Europe and the Pacific. More than 25,000 women applied to the program, fewer than 2,000 were accepted, and 1,074 completed training.

By the time the program ended, the WASPs had risked—and in some cases given—their lives to save male pilots a cumulative 60 million miles of flying. But during the war, they were classified as civil servants, no different in the eyes of the government from the female federal employees who typed memos or cooked on bases. After the war, they were ineligible for veterans' benefits, and kept out of both the military and commercial cockpits. For decades, the WASPs lobbied to be recognized as service members. Today, they are still largely unknown. Soon, they will all be gone.



Patricia Perry, my Grandma Pat, was born in 1921, an only child. She grew up in Auburn, a small town in Northern

California's Sierra foothills. This was farm country—stone fruit and grapes—and when she was in high school, Pat learned to fly a friend's parents' crop duster. She was high-achieving, sheltered, patriotic, and eager to please—always, according to my mom, “trying to be the son her father never had as well as the daughter her mother insisted on.” In 1941, she moved two hours southwest to study political science at UC Berkeley. Instead of joining a sorority, she lived in the International House, where she was surrounded by students from all over the world, including many who had fled the war in Europe.

*THE WOMEN
PAID THEIR
OWN WAY TO
TEXAS. THEY
WERE TOLD
TO PACK
LIGHT, AND
TO BUY LIFE
INSURANCE.*

After graduation, she'd planned to attend law school at Berkeley, where she would have been one of just a few women, but deferred her admission to join the WASPs. She met the criteria: 5 foot 4 or taller, at least 21 years of age, high-school diploma, extensive flying experience. On July 5, 1943, when Pat was 21, she began her training in Sweetwater. She had never left California before.

With a few exceptions, the women at Avenger Field were white, but they came from a variety of backgrounds and professions—one was a Broadway actor—and from all over the country. Some were still essentially children; others were in their 30s, married with a family, or widowed by a husband who had already been killed in the war. The wealthier among

them had learned to fly for fun when aviation became an expensive diversion in the years between the world wars. Hundreds had gone through the Civilian Pilot Training Program, which had been founded a few years earlier to train men to fly and occasionally accepted women. Pat, like many of her fellow WASPs, had felt called to service. A large number just really loved to fly, and looked for any opportunity to do it.

Before she joined the program, Marion Schorr Brown was making \$90 a month as a schoolteacher and spending \$6 an hour for flight time. Nell Stevenson Bright took her first recreational flight at the age of 8, when her father paid a dollar for her to ride in a World War I biplane, and never stopped thinking about being in the air after that. Cornelia Fort was an airplane fanatic and a flight instructor who happened to have been flying with a student over Pearl Harbor on December 7, 1941, when she was 22. She saw the bombs exploding in the sky, and then she emergency-landed her plane as Japanese military aircraft rained bullets down on the tarmac. Ten months later, she became the second woman to sign up for what would become the WASP program.

The women paid their own way to Texas. They were told to pack light, and to buy life insurance. Once they got there, they were given men's flight suits; in photographs, they look like children playing dress-up, heavy fabric pooled at their feet. They covered lodging costs themselves, \$1.65 a day. The windows on their barracks were painted black, for modesty. They trained for four to seven months, learning physics, Morse code, and military law, and accumulating hundreds of flight hours: everything male pilots learned, except gunnery and formation flying. (They also learned how to examine their cockpits for rattlesnakes.) Every morning, they did calisthenics in bobby socks as military planes flew loud and low overhead. In the evenings, they wrote letters home, played Ping-Pong in the rec hall, and produced a newspaper, *The Avenger*.

In Sweetwater, locals received them with some suspicion, at least until program leaders encouraged them all to go to church, even the Jewish ones. In the country at large, to the extent that the public



WASPs at the Romulus Army Air Base, in Michigan. The women were typically outnumbered on base by hundreds or thousands of men.

was aware of the WASPs, the general attitude seems to have been one of amused gratitude. A cover story about the program in *Life* magazine—headline: “Girl Pilots”—called the women “very serious about their chance to fly for the Army at Avenger Field, even when it means giving up nail polish, beauty parlors, and dates for a regimented 22 ½ weeks.”

After training, the women received a pair of silver wings and a few days off. Then they scattered to their next assignment: Schorr Brown to Detroit, Stevenson Bright to El Paso, Fort and Pat to different parts of Southern California, the rest to airfields and Army bases around the country. There, they taught male cadets how to

fly; moved supplies between factories and bases; flew paperwork, planes, and pilots wherever they needed to go; and generally engaged in what the pilot Jacqueline Cochran, one of the program’s founders, was fond of calling “aerial dishwashing”—the tedious stuff, work no one else wanted.

Each WASP was typically one of only a handful of women among hundreds or thousands of men on base, and the historical record suggests that they were treated, at best, like zoo animals. An unspoken but widely understood part of the job description, Pat recalled, was to entertain their male counterparts: She packed a ball gown in her luggage along with her flight suit. The women were skipped over for certain flying assignments, evaluated more harshly than the men, and reportedly told by one base commander that both they and the planes could easily be replaced. For a while, many were grounded during their period. Rumors of sabotage by male pilots spread.

Cochran was said—but never confirmed—to have found traces of sugar in the engine of a plane that had crashed and killed a WASP.

Even under the best conditions, the flying itself was difficult and dangerous. The planes were tiny, many of the cockpits completely open to the air. (In Sweetwater, I saw four of them, dinky little tin-can-looking things, and I thought about how I require a glass of wine and a Xanax to get on a 737.) They had rudimentary instruments and no radar or GPS—often, the women would navigate by sticking their head out the window. Schorr Brown once accidentally got so close to the Statue of Liberty while flying from Montreal to Newark that it “scared the living daylights out of her.” Not at all infrequently, a WASP’s assignment was to test a plane for airworthiness, or to transport a damaged one to be repaired, or to tow a target over a practice area while not-fully-trained men on the ground did

their best to shoot at it with machine guns. Women were allowed to opt out of this last duty, but no one did.

On March 21, 1943, Cornelia Fort was ferrying a BT-13 from Long Beach to Dallas when one of the recently trained male pilots she was flying with accidentally clipped her wing. She nose-dived so hard that her plane's engine was later found buried two feet underground. Fort was the first woman pilot in American history to be killed while on active duty for her country. The military did not pay for her funeral.

Thirty-seven other WASPs died in service, either during training or on assignment. Each time, their remains were sent home at the expense of their families—the women at Avenger got used to passing around a hat, collecting donations. Their caskets were not permitted to be draped with the American flag, but sometimes their families did it anyway.

Even under the best conditions, flying was difficult and dangerous. The planes were tiny, and many of the cockpits were completely open to the air.

A

Almost the entire time, they were met with resistance from male pilots. In 1944, as an end to the war appeared to be in sight and the pilot shortage eased, the government ordered the cancellation of a flight-instruction program for men. A group of male teachers began petitioning elected officials and writing to the press: Why should women have these jobs when they couldn't?

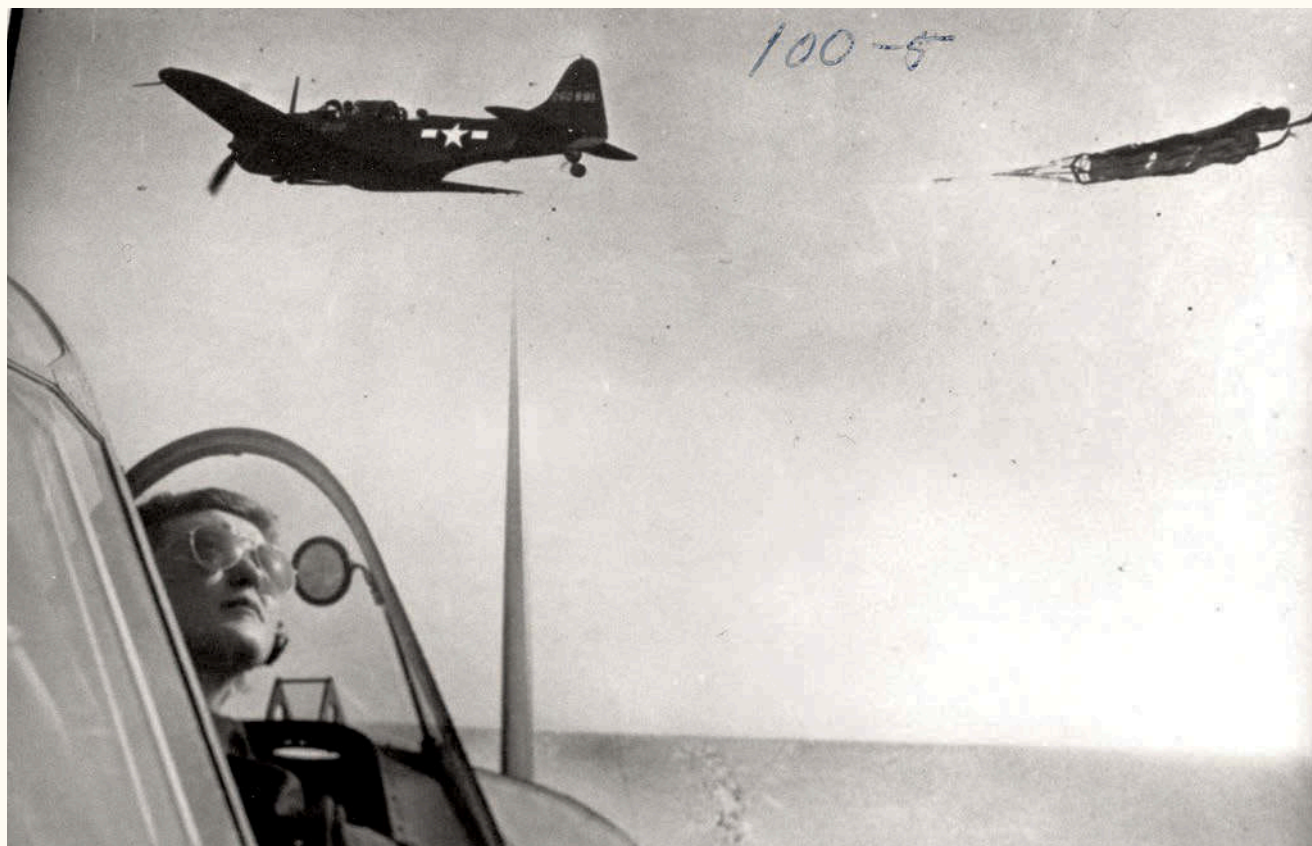
Soon enough, public sentiment toward the WASPs started to shift. "Women: Unnecessary and Undesirable?" a headline in *Time* magazine asked. A government report found the program to be expensive and wasteful, especially when so many male pilots were available. A bill that would have provided the WASPs with full military status was narrowly defeated in the House of Representatives. By October, it was all over: The program was to be disbanded by the end of the year.

Almost the entire time the WASP program existed, its leaders fought for it to be made an official part of the military, with all the attendant benefits.

On December 7, 1944, it graduated its final class. "The WASP have completed their mission," General Henry Arnold said at the ceremony. "If ever there was a doubt in anyone's mind that women can become skillful pilots, the WASP have dispelled that doubt." The pilots he was addressing would never get to put their skills to use. The ones currently on base were sent home.

And so the WASPs scattered back to their lives. They finished school, bred Pekingese dogs, won bowling competitions, sold encyclopedias, had babies, devoted themselves to their families. A number of them applied to be commercial pilots and were rejected, though occasionally an airline would suggest that they were perfectly qualified to become stewardesses.

Marion Schorr Brown married a civilian pilot and settled down in Columbus, Ohio, staying home to raise her children. Nell Stevenson Bright began a career in finance, and eventually became one of the first female stockbrokers in Phoenix. And Pat went back to Northern California, only to find that the law school she'd been





WASPs doing calisthenics at Avenger Field, in Sweetwater, Texas. Locals received the trainees with some suspicion, at least until program leaders encouraged them to go to church.

admitted to before volunteering had dramatically reduced operations, on account of the fact that there weren't enough men around to fill a class.

She instead enrolled at a different, less prestigious school. After graduation, despite having job offers in Los Angeles, she returned to Auburn at her parents' insistence and married a local war hero—my grandfather. She joined him in working at his family's law firm, which didn't allow Pat to bill clients or appear in court. On the ground as in the sky, it seemed she was expected to use her many talents in order to help the men around her, without being too bothersome or visible about it.

When she had my mom, in 1951, Pat left the firm for good. Twelve years later, she and my grandfather divorced. He quickly remarried, and she moved to Monterey with my mom and my uncle, then 6. She had graduated from an elite college, flown warplanes, and passed the bar, but as a divorcee in 1963, the best job she could find was working the reception desk at a hotel.

By then, the WASP program had been all but erased from public memory. Like so many who had served during the war, the WASPs themselves generally tried their

best to move on afterward. Margo Thurman, Nell Stevenson Bright's daughter, told me that she'd been unaware of her mom's service until she was in her 20s. Pat did tell her young children about it, but she didn't say much: She was proud of what she had done, but it was a close-mouthed kind of pride. At some point, she threw away her uniform.

Because they'd gone their separate ways after training, and the internet did not exist, and most of the women had changed their name, many of them lost touch. Most WASPs had little to no contact with the only people who had shared in, and could validate, their experience. Records of the program were classified, and the military didn't publicize it after it ended. What, after all, would be the point? "No one even knows about us," one WASP told her local paper in the 1970s. "They say I'm nuts when I mention it."



Starting in the early 1960s, WASPs organized various efforts to gain veteran status. They all failed. Then, in 1976, when the Air Force began accepting female recruits for combat, newspapers, working off military press releases, ran articles about the "first women pilots to fly military airplanes." By this point, the women's-rights movement had gained momentum,

and the nation, having just lost an ethically murky war, was inclined to glorify World War II and its veterans. Many of the WASPs, including Nell Stevenson Bright, began organizing anew, hoping that this time, the conditions were right for them to actually be heard.

Stevenson Bright turned 104 in June. In late fall, she spoke with me over Zoom from her assisted-living facility in Salt Lake City. She wore cherry-red lipstick and a cable-knit sweater; behind her sat a flower arrangement with a small American flag in it. She talked about the fight for recognition the same way she talked about flying an airplane: matter-of-factly, and with little interest in questions about how it felt. While living in Arizona, she had become friendly with Senator Barry Goldwater, she told me, and shortly after she and other WASPs pleaded their case to him, he "got to work" on a bill—simple. In 1977, the women were finally, formally recognized as veterans and made eligible for benefits.

The recognition effort helped many of the remaining WASPs get back in touch with one another. A few had gathered casually for years, but now they began to have larger, more formal reunions. "We'd just sit around and yak," Stevenson Bright recalled. They began making the rounds at air shows, setting up a booth and trying to talk with as many people as they could—for starters, they wanted everyone to understand that 1976 was not the first time women had flown military planes. They began considering what else they might want to do to make sure they wouldn't be forgotten.

In 1992, the WASPs established an archive at Texas Woman's University, in Denton, about 45 minutes north of Dallas. A few years later, one of the women and her daughter began advocating and raising money for a museum. It opened in 2005 at Avenger Field, 62 years to the day after the first WASP class graduated. As of this spring, 18 WASPs have had their ashes scattered there, with one another instead of their husbands, under the big gray sky. In 2009, after an extended lobbying effort, the women were awarded the Congressional Gold Medal for their service. A few years later, the family of a WASP named Elaine Danforth Harmon fought to bury her at Arlington National Cemetery, and won.

Pat died in 1995, when I was 7. My sense of her is arrested at the second-grade level: All I remember is that she loved golf, had bright-red hair, and gave me age-inappropriate books about the economy for Christmas, because she thought it was important for little girls to understand how money worked.

I wish I could ask her what she thought of it all—the archive, the medal, the long battle for recognition, the question of whether it’s even possible to win a fight you never should have had to wage in the first place. I know that she was interested in justice, on a philosophical and professional level as well as a personal one, but I also know that her feelings about being a WASP were complicated. When Pat’s children asked her about the war, mostly what she told them was how terrifying it was, how cold she was in the cockpit. She did not make enduring friendships in the program. It did not grant her greater opportunities later in life, or a sense that women could accomplish whatever they set out to do. She died angry at the U.S. military, and terrified of snakes. My mom believes that she did not want to think being a WASP was the most exciting thing she had ever done or would do. She also believes, as she told me recently, that Pat’s life was full of disappointments, often because of her gender, and that her experience as a WASP—during, but especially after, the war—“was the first, and the biggest.”

Recently, pop culture has developed

Nell Stevenson Bright would go on to become one of the first female stockbrokers in Phoenix, Arizona.

an interest in history-makers and hidden figures—in stories about spunky women who clopped around institutions that didn’t respect them in fabulous high heels, doing math or playing chess, glamorously but silently moving humanity forward. Part of the appeal of these narratives is that they flatter the present simply by virtue of its not being the past: You consume them and think, *Thank God we’re not like that anymore.* They are stories about discrimination and hardship that are designed to make their audience feel good, as though progress is always linear and justice is always served.

Many of the women I spoke with for this story have wondered why no one has made a big Hollywood movie about the WASPs. I have a theory. I think it’s because their story does not neatly represent the beginning of anything. A thousand American women were flying planes during the biggest and deadliest conflict the world had ever seen, and then they were back on Earth, wives

and mothers, their contribution forgotten before the war even ended. They did not integrate the military or significantly alter the general public’s understanding of what women were capable of—women weren’t allowed to fly military planes again for another generation. As of 2024, just 7.3 percent of this country’s licensed pilots were women; the government report I found this figure in is titled “U.S. Civil Airmen Statistics.” Meanwhile, Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth recently declared that the military “must be returned to the highest male standard only,” and ended a 74-year-old committee created to support women in service.

The WASPs hurtled into a hard wall and it didn’t break. If their story offers a lesson for the women of my generation or the girls of the next, it’s not a particularly uplifting one.



In November, my mom and I paid a visit to Texas Woman’s University. Twenty-first-century women crisscrossed campus in tiny shorts or enormous cargo pants, carrying fat textbooks on physics and Eastern philosophy. At an information desk inside the administrative building that houses special collections, a student worker stared at me blankly when I asked about the WASP archive. “Like ... wasp?” she said, moving her finger in the air like an insect.

We got there eventually. The archive shares space with the Texas First Ladies Historic Gown Collection, and one of the world’s largest collections of cookbooks—a news crew had recently been there to film a segment on the cookbooks, and the WASP memorabilia had been moved out of the way. We sat on soft chairs and talked with Corynthia Dorgan, the archive’s WASP expert.

In the months before I arrived in Texas, the Trump administration had embarked on a large-scale effort to purge government materials of references to women, people of color, and various other marginalized groups. (Two months after my trip, Texas A&M University would abruptly end its women’s- and gender-studies program.)



Simply acknowledging the existence of certain individuals, facts, and concepts had become a political act. The United States seemed to be in the middle of a mass experiment designed to test just how durable the reality of the past really is.

In some ways, the WASPs and their long, halting fight for status are a perfect example of Americans' perennial willingness to elide entire histories and people for the sake of convenience or ideology. And they have been subject to this great erasing themselves. Shortly after President Trump

Stevenson Bright, now 104, befriended Senator Barry Goldwater, who in 1977 sponsored a bill that granted WASPs veteran status and made them eligible for benefits.

started his second term, the *Air Force Times* reported that at least a dozen pages related to the WASPs and other female pilots had been removed from Air Force websites.

Recently, Dorgan told me, she and her colleagues had pulled as many PDFs of government webpages about the WASPs as they could, as a precaution. They have also subtly reframed the way they talk about the program publicly, emphasizing its role in Texas history more than women's history. "You do the little things," Dorgan said, in order to protect the truth. You do your best to tell the story you care about in a way that will make people want to listen, in the moment you are telling it.

This is something that the WASPs became good at. They started the archive where Dorgan now works, she told me,

because "they knew what they did was unique, and it was hidden, and they thought it shouldn't be." They created a museum because they felt that they should have a museum. It is still there for anyone who wants to visit; on a recent Wednesday, a group of teenagers was being led around on a tour. The WASPs spent their 80s traveling the country talking about their experiences because they thought those experiences mattered. They talked to anyone who would listen. History, they understood, isn't something that's ordained impartially or fixed in position—it's whatever people decide is worth repeating over and over. *A*

Ellen Cushing is a staff writer at The Atlantic.





Three Mile
Island's cooling
towers have until
recently served as
grave markers for
America's nuclear-
power industry.

INSATIABLE

BY
MATTEO
WONG

INSATIABLE

BY
MATTEO
WONG

INSATIABLE

BY
MATTEO
WONG

Indoor rain,
windows to
nowhere, and
reanimated
nuclear reactors—
how the race
to power AI is
remaking the
physical world

PHOTOGRAPHS BY
LANDON SPEERS

A

As we drove through southwest Memphis, KeShaun Pearson told me to keep my window down—our destination was best tasted, not viewed. Along the way, we passed an abandoned coal plant to our right, then an active power plant to our left, equipped with enormous natural-gas turbines.

Pearson, who directs the non-profit Memphis Community Against Pollution, was bringing me to his hometown's latest industrial megaproject.

Already, the air smelled of soot, gasoline, and asphalt. Then I felt a tickle sliding up my nostrils and down into my throat, like I was getting a cold. As we approached, I heard the rumble of cranes and trucks, and then from behind a patch of trees emerged a forest of electrical towers. Finally, I saw it—a white-walled hangar, bigger than a dozen football fields, where Elon Musk intends to build a god.

This is Colossus: a data center that Musk's artificial-intelligence company, xAI, is using as a training ground for Grok, one of the world's most advanced generative-AI models. Training these models takes a staggering amount of energy; if run at full strength for a year, Colossus would use as much electricity as 200,000 American homes. When fully operational, Musk has written on X, this facility and two other xAI data centers nearby will require nearly two gigawatts of power. Annually, those facilities could consume roughly twice as much electricity as the city of Seattle.

To get Colossus up and running fast, xAI built its own power plant, setting up as many as 35 natural-gas turbines—railcar-size engines that can be major sources of smog—according to imagery obtained by the Southern Environmental Law Center. Pearson coughed as we drove by the facility. The scratch in my throat worsened, and I rolled up my window.

xAI's rivals are all building similarly large data centers to develop their most powerful generative-AI models; a metropolis's worth of electricity will surge through facilities that occupy a few city blocks. These companies have primarily made their chatbots "smarter" not by writing niftier code but by making them bigger: ramming more data through more powerful computer chips that use more electricity. OpenAI has announced plans for facilities requiring more than 30 gigawatts of power in total—more than the largest recorded demand for all of New England. Since ChatGPT's launch, in November 2022, the capital expenditures of Amazon, Microsoft, Meta, and Google have exceeded \$600 billion, and much of that spending has gone toward data centers—more, even after adjusting for inflation, than the government spent to build the entire interstate-highway system. "These are the largest single points of consumption of electricity in history," Jesse Jenkins, a climate modeler at Princeton, told me.

Even conservative analyses forecast that the tech industry will drop the equivalent of roughly 40 Seattles onto America's grid within a decade; aggressive scenarios predict more than 60 in half that time. According to Siddharth Singh, an energy-investment analyst at the International Energy Agency, by 2030, U.S. data

centers will consume more electricity than all of the country's heavy industries—more than the cement, steel, chemical, car, and other industrial facilities put together. Roughly half of that demand will come from data centers equipped for the particular needs of generative AI—programs, such as ChatGPT, that can produce text and images, solve complex math problems, and perhaps one day inform scientific discoveries.

To power AI, energy and tech companies are turning to fossil fuels, which they regard as more reliable and readily available than wind, solar, or nuclear. Asked where the energy for data centers should come from, OpenAI CEO Sam Altman has repeatedly said, "Short-term: natural gas." (OpenAI and *The Atlantic* have a corporate partnership.) A Louisiana utility plans to build three natural-gas plants for a Meta data center that, upon completion, will be among the largest in this hemisphere. The lifespans of coal plants, too, are being extended to power new data centers. And the IEA estimates that data-center emissions could more than double by 2030—becoming one of the fastest-growing sources of greenhouse gases in the world.

The optimist's case is that, by then, advanced nuclear reactors will have obviated many of the new fossil-fuel plants, and AI tools will have invented technologies that can solve the climate crisis. That may well happen. But today, "the market has converged on *Add gas now, and then add nuclear later*," Jenkins said. In other words, if natural-gas turbines seem to offer the most expedient path to an AI-enhanced future, then clean air may have to wait.

A DATA CENTER is a planet of contradictions: heat without motion, shelter without bodies, light without sky. "The lifeblood of the internet is essentially flowing through these sites," Jon Lin, the chief business officer at Equinix, one of the world's largest data-center companies, told me in an Equinix facility in Loudoun County, Virginia. Behind Lin, someone in a green hoodie fiddled with computer chips shelved in a row of humming, refrigerator-size cabinets on the data-center floor. There were no windows,



LONDON SPEEDS FOR THE ATLANTIC



to keep the facility secure and to guard against the sun's heat. As we walked along a corridor of cabinets, motion-activated lights illuminated the way. Farther ahead, only faint blue lights and blinking computer equipment pierced the darkness.

Ever since the first data centers were built, in the mid-20th century, their purpose has remained constant: pack computer equipment close together to store and send information as efficiently as possible. But their scale has grown dramatically. The original data centers were simply large rooms housing mainframe computers. With the rise of the internet, in the 1990s, backroom computers gave way to entire buildings, such as the one Lin and I stood in—facilities that enable us to stream movies, trade stocks, store medical records, manage supply chains, and make military decisions. Now the AI race is requiring vastly greater computing power, which has led to even bigger data centers, ones filled with computer chips that are much hungrier and run much hotter.

Colossus, Elon Musk's data center in Memphis, can consume as much electricity over the course of a year as 200,000 American homes.

In a traditional data center, the cabinets are cooled by industrial fans—as we walked through the Equinix facility, I felt a constant breeze on my cheek—and rooftop cooling towers eventually expel the heat. The cabinets in a generative-AI data center use dozens of times more electricity. Lin showed me a row of AI-specialized cabinets used by Block, the firm that owns Square and Cash App, which radiated enough heat to make me break a sweat; to cool them, water runs into special metal plates that sit atop the chips inside the cabinets. AI data centers are filled with similar equipment, and cooling thousands of cabinets can require a lot of water. Public records from the Memphis water utility, for instance, show that the address for Colossus used more than 11 million gallons in September alone, as much

as 150 homes use in an entire year. When a data center's cooling equipment malfunctions, spiraling heat combined with humid air has yielded that rarest of meteorological events: indoor rain.

Placing servers in the same or neighboring buildings allows them to exchange information seamlessly and quickly, and Loudoun County has the highest concentration of data centers in the world, with 199 already operating and another 30 or so on the way. According to one report, 13 percent of global data-center capacity is squeezed into the county's 520 square miles. One particularly dense stretch is called "Data Center Alley."

Northern Virginia offers a glimpse into what the AI rush may bring to the rest of the nation. Loudoun is running out of space, but new data-center hubs are popping up in Phoenix, Atlanta, and Dallas. Amazon and Meta are building AI data centers in Indiana and Louisiana, respectively, that will each require more than two gigawatts of electricity, dozens of times more than standard facilities. OpenAI has proposed that the U.S. establish "AI Economic Zones": little Loudouns everywhere.

As I drove into Data Center Alley with Julie Bolthouse, the director of land use at the Piedmont Environmental Council, she explained how to distinguish data centers from warehouses: cooling towers on the roof, dozens of backup diesel generators to one side, no windows (or false ones, decorative glass panels backed by a wall of concrete). There didn't seem to be any warehouses, though, and I gave up counting data centers within minutes, unable to tell where one facility ended and the next one began. Bolthouse helps run a coalition aiming to slow data-center development throughout Virginia, but in Loudoun, it is too late. So many data centers are under construction just north of Dulles International Airport that hills of freshly dug dirt loom over roads and orange dust tints the air. Should Musk successfully colonize Mars, the early stages of terraforming might look like this.

The architect of this labyrinth is Buddy Rizer, Loudoun's longtime executive director of economic development. Rizer has courted data centers with regulatory and state tax incentives, and when we met in his office, he told me that since 2009, at least one has been under construction at any given time. Data centers are typically operated by only a few dozen staff members, but building them has produced a steady source of employment. They also provide nearly 40 percent of the county's budget, helping to pay for police, schools, and parks for a population that has grown steadily since 2010.

Within a 1.5-mile radius of us, Rizer said, were 12 substations: small jungles of metal poles and wiring that convert high-voltage electricity into a form you'd use to charge your iPhone or, in this case, run a data center. All around us were towering utility poles strung with high-voltage transmission lines that carry raw electricity from power plants to those substations; they hang over Loudoun like a canopy, or a cobweb. Follow any one cable far enough, and you're likely to reach a data center.

For years to come, the AI race is projected to be the main force driving roughly 2 percent annual growth in U.S. electricity demand, which has been stagnant for nearly two decades. Nationally, this is not a crisis; regionally, it may be. Dominion Energy, the major electrical utility in Virginia, predicts growth of 5.5 percent each year, with overall electricity demand



doubling by 2039. Aaron Ruby, a spokesperson for Dominion, told me that the company is preparing to meet that surge, though he was frank about the challenge: "We are experiencing the largest growth in power demand since the years following World War II." By the end of the decade, training the industry's most powerful AI model could require as much electricity as millions of American homes.

In China, hundreds of data centers have been announced since 2023, and additional facilities are planned for beneath the ocean and in the desert. China's biggest advantage in the AI race is not the talent of its software engineers or the quantity of its data centers, but its abundance of energy: In 2024, the nation produced nearly as much electricity as the U.S., Europe, and India combined.

President Trump has declared that the nation is in an "energy emergency," and been vocal about the need to build more power plants for the U.S. to win the AI race. A senior executive at OpenAI told me that the U.S. needs to activate every resource at its disposal—solar panels, natural-gas turbines, nuclear reactors. And Anthropic, OpenAI's top rival, published a report arguing that the U.S. should streamline permitting for data centers and power plants in order to keep pace with China.

But an internet-driven energy crisis has failed to materialize before: As fiber-optic cables were being laid in Loudoun in the 1990s, energy companies built more coal- and gas-fired plants. "Dig More Coal—The PCs Are Coming," read a 1999 *Forbes* headline. When the demand didn't arrive, the nation was left with a glut of gas plants and multiple bankrupt energy companies.



The generative-AI boom, too, could prove to be a bubble. The technology remains extraordinarily expensive, largely because of the cost of advanced computer chips, and no AI firm has presented a convincing business model. One path to profitability might be more efficient algorithms—which would preclude the need for the new natural-gas plants. And if AI doesn’t turn out to be as transformative a technology as experts predict, swaths of data centers could be left unused or unfinished—ruins from a future that never came to pass.

Either way, the rush to power data centers as fast as possible has already pushed the U.S. to expand its reliance on fossil fuels.

BEHIND HER ONE-STORY brick home in southwest Memphis, Sarah Gladney grows tomatoes, and when the vines wilted early last summer, she had a suspect in mind. “When the wind comes up early in the morning, I can smell it,” Gladney told me, nodding in the direction of Colossus. One of her neighbors, Marilyn Gooch, told me the data center’s turbines have made her uncertain about whether she should let her grandchildren visit.

Their neighborhood, Boxtown, is named for the railway boxcars that formerly enslaved people used to build homes, and is still almost entirely Black. Virtually every heavy industry has set up nearby—a wastewater facility, an oil refinery, a coal-fired power plant. Colossus itself, which is next to a steel mill and a trucking and rail yard, occupies the hull of an old oven factory. Life expectancy in and around Boxtown is more than five years below the national average, and the cancer risk in southwest Memphis is four times higher. What KeShaun Pearson and I smelled may not have been Colossus itself; xAI had chosen an area so besieged by heavy industry that any exhaust from the facility’s turbines would mix in with a pervasive smog.

Colossus was built so quickly that many Boxtown residents and elected officials didn’t know what was happening until the project was well under way. Construction began in May 2024, and the project was announced the following month. Gladney,

Pearson, and his younger brother Justin—who represents the district in the Tennessee General Assembly—found out about the project that day in June. By Labor Day weekend, less than three months after the press conference, Colossus was up and running.

The company installed its own gas turbines because that was faster than waiting on the local grid, and argued that it did not need a permit to do so because the turbines would operate for less than a year, a claim that the Southern Environmental Law Center, representing the NAACP, contested in a letter threatening to sue the company. (xAI has since received a permit for 15 turbines, and is reportedly operating 12.) Meanwhile, residents report that they have had respiratory issues flare up since xAI moved in.

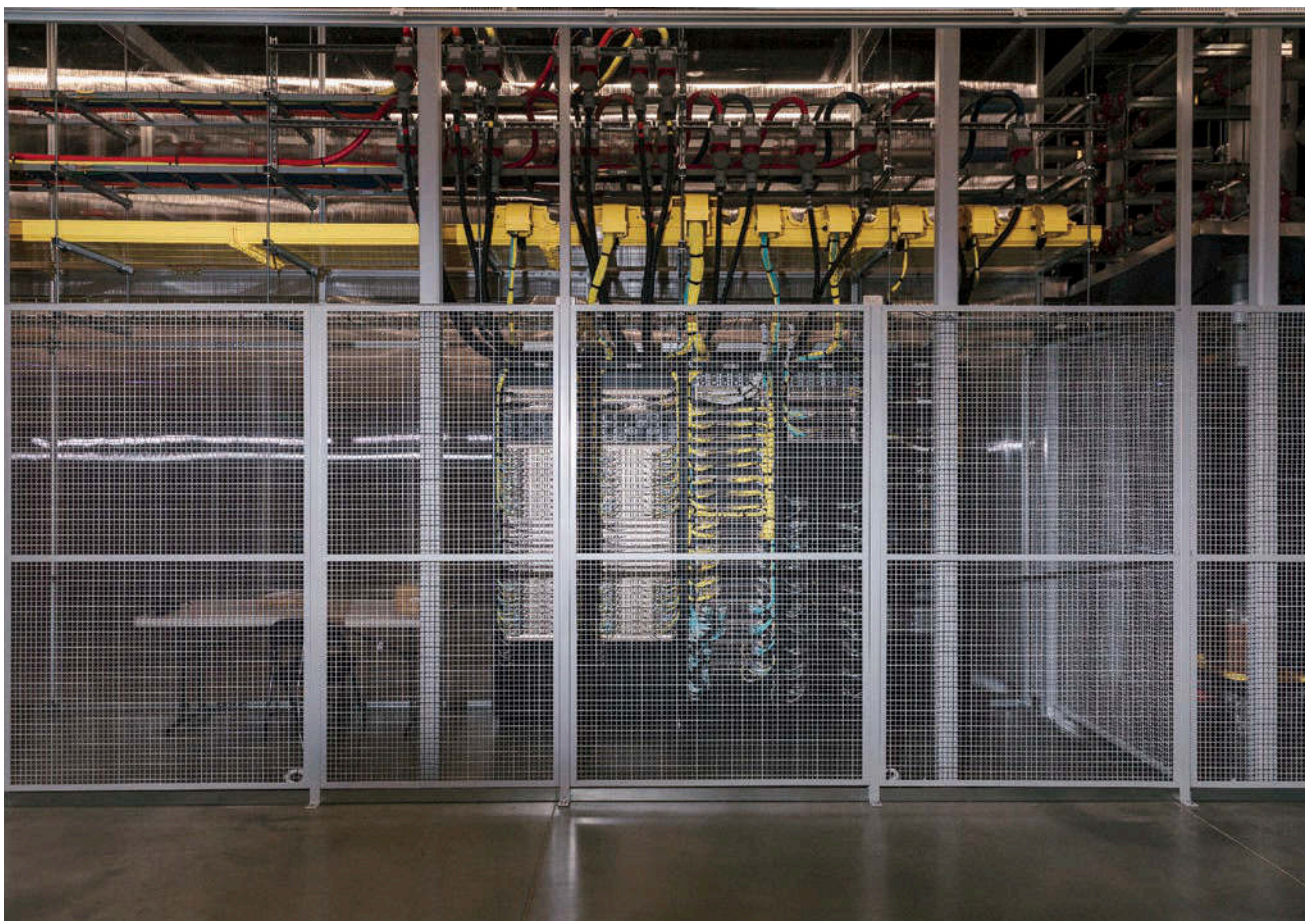
Last June, when an analysis commissioned by the city of Memphis found “no dangerous levels” of pollutants in Boxtown and at two other test locations, the SELC criticized the study’s methods. Using satellite data, researchers at the University of Tennessee at Knoxville found that levels of nitrogen dioxide—which causes smog and is associated with asthma and other respiratory

Opposite page: In Boxtown, a neighborhood in southwest Memphis, many residents and elected officials were unaware that Colossus was being built until the project was well under way. *This page:* Transmission lines, like these in Memphis, carry electricity throughout the grid—including to data centers.

problems—near Colossus have been substantially elevated since its public announcement. (xAI says on its website that it will install technology to reduce the pollution from its turbines. The company, the Shelby County Health Department, and the Memphis mayor’s office did not respond to a list of questions about Colossus’s environmental impacts and xAI’s presence in Memphis; the Greater Memphis Chamber of Commerce declined to comment.)

Fossil fuels have become the default for data centers around the country. OpenAI’s first Stargate data center, in Texas, also has its own gas-fired power plant. Chevron and Exxon are angling to hook natural-gas facilities directly into data centers, and the world’s three major manufacturers of natural-gas turbines all advertise their products as convenient energy sources for data centers. Michael Eugenis, the director of resource planning at Arizona Public Service, the state’s largest utility, told me that because of the demand from data centers, the company is adding more fossil-fuel capacity than it otherwise would have; natural gas will help power Microsoft, Amazon, and Oracle data centers, too.

In early 2025, a company affiliated with xAI purchased a former warehouse and nearly 200 acres south of Colossus to set up another data center, Colossus II. On a weekday afternoon, the road near the site was dense with traffic—not dump trucks and forklifts, but sedans lining up outside the adjacent public school for pickup. An xAI affiliate bought a retired Duke Energy plant about a mile away in Mississippi that is likely to power this facility, and filed an application to operate 41 natural-gas turbines on the site. Those turbines could emit more carbon dioxide annually than the city of San Jose.



ON AN ISLAND in the Susquehanna River, just south of Harrisburg, Pennsylvania, I saw another way to power the AI boom. Above me loomed four beige hourglass-shaped structures, each some 365 feet tall: the cooling towers for Three Mile Island, the site of the worst nuclear disaster in American history. On March 28, 1979, the facility was only a few years old, and nuclear-energy reactors were being built across the country. But a series of mechanical and human errors caused the core of one of the reactors, Unit Two, to rapidly overheat and leak radioactive material. The effects on human health and the environment were negligible, but together with the catastrophe at Chernobyl seven years later, the partial meltdown turned public sentiment strongly against nuclear power.

Three Mile Island's Unit One went undamaged and continued operating, after a brief pause, until 2019. By then natural gas was too cheap, the regulatory environment was too unfriendly, and the losses—hundreds of millions of dollars—were too great for Constellation Energy, which owns Unit One, to keep the plant running.

Nobody has ever resuscitated a fully shut-down U.S. nuclear-power plant, but in fall 2024, Constellation announced plans to do just that. Microsoft had agreed to purchase electricity from Unit One to power its data centers over the next two decades, a guarantee allowing Constellation to spend the \$1.6 billion needed to restart the plant. It was the ultimate bellwether of the AI age: Experts have long argued that we need clean nuclear power to reduce the grid's

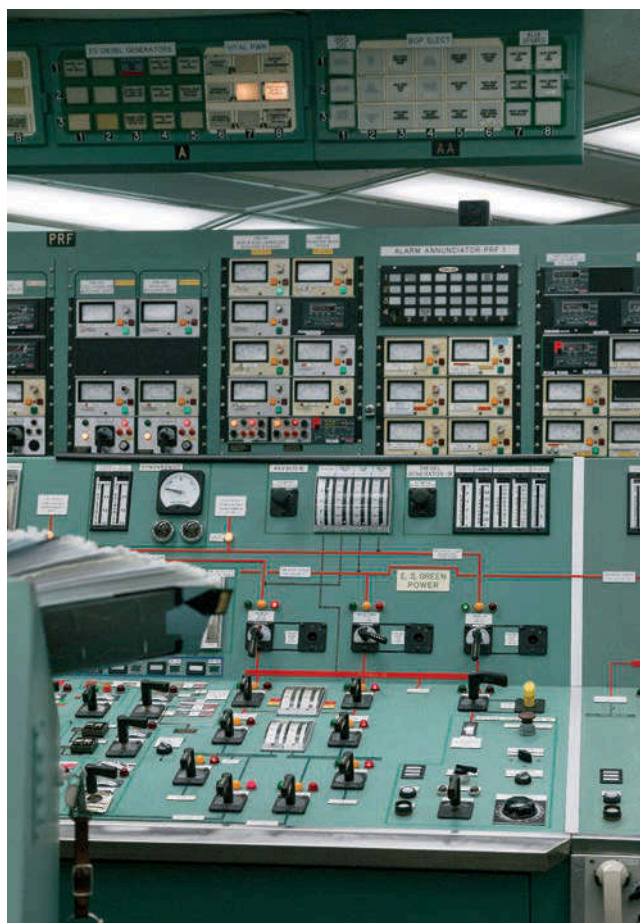
existing carbon footprint. Instead, Three Mile Island will help offset a new source of emissions from a single company.

Constellation is now reversing the steps it took to decommission the reactor: renewing its license, restoring equipment, retraining personnel. Dave Marcheskie, a community-relations manager, explained this to me in a conference room overlooking the nuclear core, which is housed in a building that resembles a large grain silo. Behind him, a clock counted down the time to launch: 650 days, zero hours, 42 minutes, and one second.

As the need for carbon-free electricity grows more urgent, Americans are having to reckon with nuclear energy again, and the AI boom has provided the industry with wealthy backers and an army of tech cheerleaders. Meta and Amazon are buying electricity from large nuclear-power plants, and nearly every major data-center company is investing in experimental nuclear technologies—especially small modular reactors, which in theory will make fission cheaper and easier to deploy.

Nuclear energy has its downsides, of course. The waste is radioactive and must be stored almost indefinitely, and the meltdown at Japan's Fukushima plant in 2011 was a reminder of how spectacularly dangerous nuclear reactors can be. But the dangers posed by the burning of fossil fuels are far more imminent.

At Three Mile Island, Marcheskie led me down a hall and into the actual power plant. Pipes, tubes, and hulking machines lined the floor and ceiling; a trefoil sign warned that a large tank



Opposite page: Cabinets of computer chips at a data center in Loudoun County, Virginia. *This page:* The original control room at Three Mile Island Unit One will become operational again when the reactor restarts.

potentially contained radioactive materials. The elevator was broken, so we walked a few stories up to the stadium-size room from which all of Three Mile Island's electricity will flow. Scaffolding and shipping containers were scattered around a row of pistachio-green semi-cylinders. Once the plant restarts, uranium atoms ripped apart in the adjacent core will generate immense amounts of heat, vaporizing water into steam that will spin blades inside those cylinders 1,800 times a minute, which will in turn produce hundreds of megawatts of electricity.

This will be orchestrated from a nearby control room, where hundreds of lights and switches line muted-green walls. The shift manager, Bill Price, explained that one half of the main panel controls the nuclear core, while the other half controls the turbines. In the middle is the most important control of all: a red button that shuts down the reactor, and above it an identical button that serves as a backup. In the event of an emergency, Price said, you'd press both. I put a finger on each button and pushed.

A small amount of the electricity generated here will support the plant itself. Microsoft is buying the remainder through a power-purchase agreement, a mechanism companies use to buy

carbon-free electricity to match whatever their facilities draw from the grid. Power generated at Three Mile Island will help offset the energy used by data centers in Virginia and Illinois; Microsoft says it purchases enough clean energy to match all of its electricity consumption, as do Google, Amazon, and Meta. These companies are also investing in hydropower, geothermal plants, and solar panels; Google is exploring building a data center in space, to enable cloud-free access to the sun.

Still, tech firms insist that nuclear and other clean technologies cannot be deployed quickly enough to meet their needs. President Trump has signed an executive order to accelerate permitting for natural-gas and coal-fired plants to support data centers. Yet China's energy advantage in the AI race comes from nuclear reactors and solar panels, not coal and oil; the country is building nearly two-thirds of the world's new solar and wind capacity.

The U.S. could still catch up, thanks to private investments by the likes of Google and Microsoft. A majority of planned electricity generation in the U.S. will be carbon-free, and running data centers on renewables can be done, Jenkins, the Princeton climate modeler, told me. Meanwhile, natural-gas turbines are so far back-ordered that acquiring one in the next few years will be virtually impossible.

For now, using existing power sources more wisely, rather than building new ones, may be all the AI industry needs. Electrical grids are designed for periods of peak demand—cooling on summer afternoons, heating on winter mornings—but mostly they run well below maximum capacity. Researchers at Duke University have shown that if data centers reduced their electricity consumption during some of those peaks, it would free up enough electricity to accommodate the country's planned data centers for years. Google and xAI have already entered agreements to do so.

That strategy would allow tech companies to continue building more data centers without waiting for utilities to expand the grid. And time, not dollars or electrons, is the AI industry's primary currency. Google, Microsoft, and their competitors can afford to spend historic sums without near-term financial returns, but they cannot afford to slip behind one another.

Time is also the biggest problem for Microsoft's deal with Three Mile Island, which is taking years to restart. As we left the facility, Marcheskie led me south, past the beige towers and through a fog that had settled over the river. At one point we passed a cluster of concrete barrels that had escaped my attention on the drive up. Marcheskie told me that they contained all of the nuclear waste from Unit One's 45 years of operation. Perhaps one day such casks will also line the perimeters of Colossus and Stargate.

AI may well overhaul how humans think and work, but it's also pushing us toward another inflection point. We can unlock the promises of this technology by doubling down on the energy systems of the past, or we can seize the opportunity to push the grid into a carbon-free future. To get there, an industry that likes to move at warp speed will have to develop a quality it severely lacks: patience. *A*

Matteo Wong is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

Culture & Critics



MARILYN ANDRE, COURTESY OF YOUNG RECORDINGS

Robyn Is Still Dancing On Her Own

The queen of poptimism takes up motherhood and midlife desire.

By Spencer Kornhaber

Once upon the '90s, a teenage girl named Robin Miriam Carlsson was crowned a pop princess. Her crystalline voice and secretive smile caught the attention of the Swedish record industry, whose producers and songwriters helped her create the swooning global hits "Show Me Love" and "Do You Know (What It Takes)." But Carlsson, first discovered at age 13, realized she didn't want to be a singing automaton, a mere vessel for the pop machine. She turned down a deal from the U.S. branch of Jive Records, which then set out to find an American version of her—and landed on Britney Spears.

By then, Robin Carlsson had become Robyn. A few years later, in 2005, she founded her own label to make her own kind of music. Her new sound combined firm dance beats, campy hip-hop flourishes, and synth riffs that spiraled and tessellated like the instruments in a Bach fugue. Her lyrics declared independence from clingy lovers and assorted social expectations, often through analogies inspired by technology. To simply quote her song titles from 2010's *Body Talk*, a now-classic album, she was an "Indestructible" "Fembot" warning, "Don't Fucking Tell Me What to Do." Beneath the metallic veneer, though, her songs had the tenderness and precision of a homily. The effect was to make solitude sound sexy, sad, and hopeful at once.

The timing had been right for her to liberate herself. The traditional music business was collapsing, as the internet cut into CD sales while letting listeners elevate their own niche idols. Mainstream pop was going maximalist by overloading its production with digital whizbangery; indie rock had risen as a rawer alternative. Robyn split the difference. She expressed a rebellious worldview in a sleek and organized way, like a manifesto in a well-formatted Word doc.

That manifesto was one that 21st-century pop culture wanted to hear. Spears had become a cautionary tale: The girl who gave her youth to the record industry ended up losing her legal sovereignty (via the establishment of a conservatorship in 2008 that remained

On her first album in eight years, Robyn is somehow singing the same song—even if the fable it spins seems more fantastical than ever.

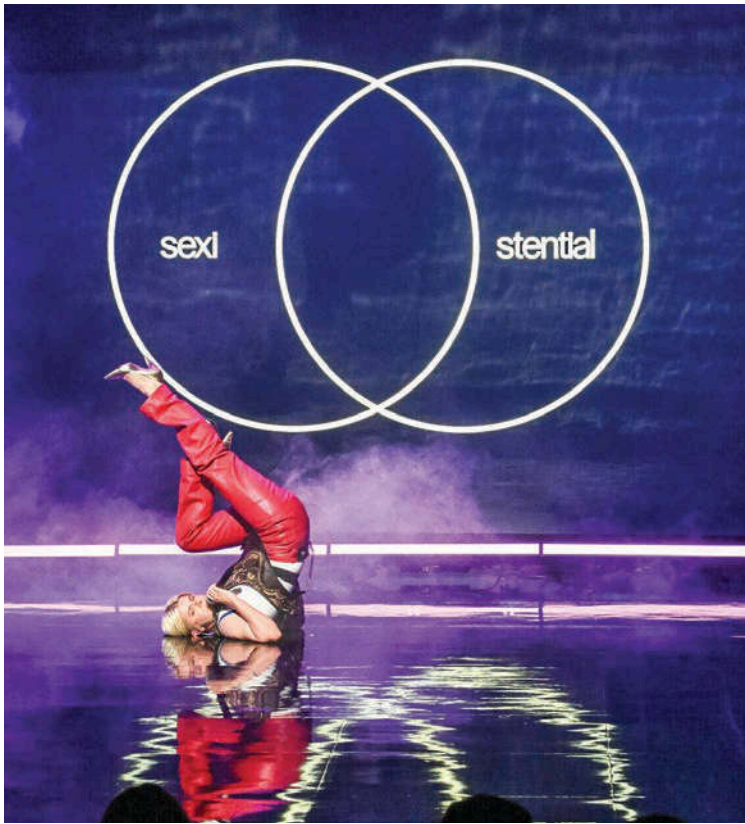
intact until 2021). Robyn did not become nearly as famous, but her emo bangers pointed the way for the likes of Lorde, Ariana Grande, and even Taylor Swift once she started playing with keyboards. Poptimism, the ascendant belief that a genre ruled by formulas and artifice can contain plenty of originality and humanity, made Robyn its mascot. And with time, her outlook on music came to seem like an insight into life itself.

Or at least, that's how many Millennials felt. Though Robyn is Gen X, she captivated my generation of idealists, who were out to upgrade the world that our parents had built and express ourselves in the process. Young adults in the early earbuds age used her songs as fuel for runs, laptop work, Tinder hookups, and the solitary, self-reflective mornings after. We also bopped along to her with our friends. HBO's *Girls* cemented her status in a legendary scene: Hannah Horvath carefully drafts a killer tweet in her bedroom, then starts jumping around to Robyn's defining single, "Dancing On My Own." Her roommate, back from her yuppie adventuring, walks in and joins the party.

The assurance of being yourself and being liked, fulfilling your purpose while climbing life's rungs, has obvious appeal in youth, before compromises and obligations start to pile too high. But Robyn is now 46 and back with her first album in eight years. She is somehow singing the same song—even if the fable it spins seems more fantastical than ever.

MANY POP STARS mellow into stately eminence in middle age, as Madonna (temporarily) did in her late 30s with 1998's *Ray of Light*. Robyn appeared to be trending that way with her last album, 2018's *Honey*—a dreamy beatscape that signaled appreciation for the mid-range of life after chasing many highs. Anthemic action was giving way to chill mantras, as if to regulate the ever noisier, ever more distracting world.

But *Sexistential*, released in March, pushes in the opposite direction, toward starry-eyed excess and abandon. The cover art shows Robyn screaming and topless. The title track features her rapping the word



boner. Echoes of earnest 2000s indie pop, including from Robyn's own catalog, abound. When she humped the air during a performance on *The Late Show With Stephen Colbert* in January, much of the internet snickered: Had the coolest girl in pop finally become cringe?

Perhaps so—cringe appears to be the fate of anyone older than 25 in the TikTok age. And pop culture has rarely allowed its female stars to grow older without mockery. But *Sexistential* may discomfit listeners for reasons other than ageism. After *Honey*, Robyn broke up with her on-and-off partner of more than a decade and then had a son through IVF. To judge by the disorienting sound of this album, middle-aged motherhood for her has been less an experience of setting down roots than of ripping them up. The title song sets her pregnancy saga—scrolling through dating apps amid doctor visits and hormonal spikes—to fast-paced club music while filtering her voice for cartoonish effect. “Blow My Mind” is a cover of her own song from 24 years ago, but this version rewrites lyrics about romantic infatuation into ones about finding your baby to be ridiculously cute. On the final track, “Into the Sun,” distorted bass roars like a rocket engine—evoking her many previous sci-fi references—as Robyn propels herself into the unknown: “Look what I’ve done / So brave and dumb.”

The music amplifies both her giddiness and her uncertainty. *Sexistential*'s production judders and

Robyn performs “Sexistential” on *The Late Show With Stephen Colbert* in January.

glitches in ways that call to mind '80s synth experimentalists such as Art of Noise and the rowdy sample collaging of the Beastie Boys in the '90s. Its messiness is also in step with 2020s hyperpop—scruffy, topsy-turvy electronic music that seeks to harness, not counteract, modern overstimulation. The wooziest moments sacrifice Robyn's easy-listening appeal for the sake of surprise. On the album opener, “Really Real,” a shattered-glass sound effect rings out before she sings, “We’re splitting up reality / And I slip out through the crack in between it.”

What makes this chaos delightful rather than annoying is Robyn's unshakable sense of control, grounded in pop principles and thoughtful craft. *Sexistential*'s many catchy melodies bounce atop bright, blocky synth lines. Its psychedelic interludes exist to snap back into satisfying rhythms. Its lyrics brim with depersonalized language (“This is where the shared experience ends”), self-help real talk (“Fuck a therapist, it’s not mental / I need philosophy, this shit is existential”), and biological determinism (as in the lead single, “Dopamine”). She’s mapping out the way that even life’s strangest chapters unfold logically.

The album, Robyn has said, was partly inspired by hearing André 3000, of the hip-hop duo Outkast, explain that he’d pivoted to instrumental music because no one wants to hear a 48-year-old man rap about his colonoscopy. In Robyn's view, the unglamorous milestones of middle age are plenty deserving of pop treatment. Two years ago, a 33-year-old Charli XCX dominated pop culture with a similarly unruly album called *Brat*. It dwelled on the question of whether Charli would ever give up her hard-partying ways and settle down with kids. Robyn is now arguing that the choice is a false one.

That argument is certainly upbeat in its implications—but the sound of *Sexistential* suggests the limits of maturing hedonistically. As I’ve been playing the album on repeat, savoring its intricate details and humming its candied choruses, I’ve felt a little self-conscious: *Sexistential*'s childlike glee raises the specter that Robyn and her listeners still have some growing up to do.

But I’ve also felt grateful for how playfully she’s engaging with midlife vertigo. The generation that grew up listening to Robyn is full of people whose blend of careerism and individualism has made them delay or skip marriage and children. Have we compromised too much, or not enough? Is there time for a reset? These sorts of questions are timeless rites of passage at the end of youth. Barreling ahead, Robyn is yet again modeling how to find meaning in the conventional—by doing it our own way. *A*

Spencer Kornhaber is a staff writer at The Atlantic.

HENNION & WALSH & COMMITTED TO YOU



We started Hennion & Walsh for people like you. People who make their own success. People who share our values. Integrity, honesty and loyalty.

The result? We're different, because we care about you and your success. So we'll speak the truth, even if it doesn't benefit us. We're dedicated to your financial goals. And because we've got your best interests at heart, we'll always give you our very best efforts. Why do we offer all this & more? You've earned it.

To learn more or to request a free, no obligation second opinion on your stock market or fixed income investments, get in touch.

Call us at **(800) 279-5279**
or visit **hennionandwalsh.com**

HENNION & WALSH
ASSET MANAGEMENT



BOOKS

The Last Days of Franco

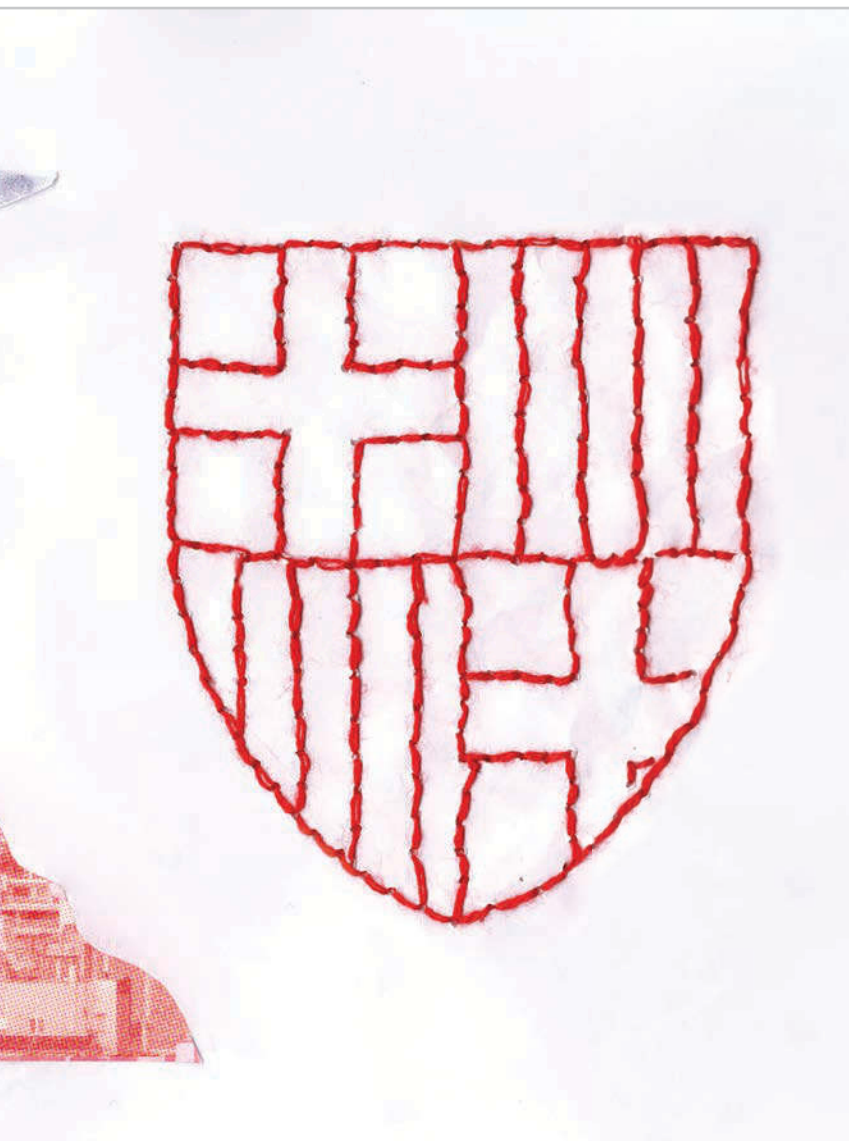
Montserrat Roig's classic novel captures Barcelona on the cusp of unimaginable change.

By Colm Tóibín

Montserrat Roig's classic novel, *The Time of Cherries*, captures a sort of still point in the history of Barcelona—a moment that came before great change. When the novel ends, no one has any idea that within 18 months, Francisco Franco, the old dictator, will be gone. *The Time of Cherries* was originally published in Catalan in 1976, the year after Franco died. Half a century later, Roig's excavation of family life in a period of historical flux is now available in English in the United States for the first time.

The Time of Cherries became an essential book in post-Franco Catalonia. It appeared at a time when there were few images of the culture whose youth had cast off Franco long before 1975. The novel is infused not only with an array of vivid characters but also with a sharply detailed vision of middle-class Barcelona before democracy was restored. The book revolves around Natàlia, once a student activist

ROGER VIOLETT / GETTY; ELOI OMELLA



and now nearly age 40, as she deals with unfinished business: her conservative brother and her fearful and neurotic sister-in-law, her father, her old friends, and, more than anything, the stifling political atmosphere that she had abruptly run away from 12 years earlier. Soon after its publication, the novel became available in a cheap paperback and was on sale in the newspaper kiosks that dotted downtown Barcelona.

When I first encountered Roig's novel, in the 1980s, I was struck by the freshness of her tone—and by the fact that Natàlia's generation was being depicted in a fearless and dramatic way. There was, for example, a sexual frankness in the book that came as a relief in a country where many films had been censored or banned for their sexual content. When Roig portrays characters from the older generation, many of them emotionally and spiritually maimed by the long years of the dictatorship, she is careful to make the gap between

The time of cherries, of youthful revolt, was not far away from a time of fear.

them and the new generation complex and ambiguous rather than simple or easy to predict.

The middle class in Barcelona had remained, for the most part, undisturbed by the First and Second World Wars, and even by the Spanish Civil War. Its members held on to their spacious apartments in the Eixample, the area of the city that was developed in the late 19th and early 20th centuries by Modernista architects, including Antoni Gaudí. Their innate conservatism persisted; they kept their heads down and looked after their affairs during the dictatorship. Things were ripe for a revolt by the generation that came of age in the 1960s.

Roig was born into a middle-class family in Barcelona in 1946, to parents who had already staged their own revolt. Her father was a lawyer and writer deeply embedded in the world of Catalan politics and culture. Her mother, also born into this middle-class milieu, was a feminist writer and suffragist. While Roig was growing up, her parents' apartment was a gathering place for writers and those involved in progressive politics.

In her late teens, Roig began writing about current affairs in the magazine *Triunfo*, which was becoming a pro-democracy force. Before going to university, she trained as an actor. During these years, she got to know the feminist writer and left-wing activist Maria Aurèlia Capmany, almost 30 years her senior, who introduced her to the writings of Simone de Beauvoir. Capmany, even when I met her in the last years of her life while I was writing my book *Homage to Barcelona*, was what might be called an indomitable spirit—witty and sharp, loud when she needed to be, radical. Like Roig herself, Capmany became one of Barcelona's prominent cultural figures in the 1980s. She was an energetic and visionary head of culture on the Barcelona city council when I knew her. Much of her is there in the figure of Harmonia, Natàlia's older friend in *The Time of Cherries*.

ROIG USES the trope of the returned daughter, in this case one who has bathed in the freedoms of England, as she herself had done in the early 1970s before coming home to Barcelona as both insider and outsider. The novel explores the strange way that time's passing makes some aspects of family dynamics subtly different and allows other aspects to stay the same.

Political life is disorienting too. The dates in *The Time of Cherries* are carefully chosen. Natàlia's exile to England and France begins with the arrest, in 1962, of the Communist Julián Grimau, who was executed by the Franco government a year later; it ends with the execution of the militant Catalan anarchist Salvador Puig Antich, in 1974. Natàlia was born in March 1938, the month the Coliseum theater in Barcelona was bombed by Italian fascist forces during the Spanish Civil War. Both her father and her brother,

Lluís, were born in important years in the history of Catalan nationalism.

According to her biographer, Betsabé García, Roig spent three years planning *The Time of Cherries* (the title is a reference to a famous French revolutionary song, a favorite of Natàlia's silly Communist boyfriend at university). She then wrote the book in 26 days, thus placing it among the masterpieces of 20th-century literature created at speed, including Kerouac's *On the Road* and Faulkner's *As I Lay Dying*.

Although Roig wrote about her own city and historical moment, she insisted that her novel was not drawn directly from her life: "I have learned to laugh when it is called autobiographical. If only they knew how it lied!" She noted that three obsessions dominated her imagination: death, sex, and growing old. All of these themes surface in *The Time of Cherries* as Roig explores shifting elements of the culture in which she grew up. She worried that if she gave her novels a working-class setting, "they would not be convincing." Rather, she would dramatize "the world that I know," bourgeois Barcelona, aware that Balzac and Proust had written about a similar class.

While her novel evoked Natàlia's interior life, it also portrayed a Barcelona, parts of which were about to disappear. In 1974, the airport bus did indeed go as far as Plaça d'Espanya. Rich people did indeed shop for domestic goods at Vinçon. Catalans did indeed look to Switzerland as their ideal state. "Switzerland was the dream," Roig writes. Men bought their hats at Can Prats, drank a brandy called Torres 10, and had dinner in a restaurant called 7 Portes. To own paintings by Ramón Casas and Isidre Nonell, two 19th-century Catalan painters, was a point of pride. People traveled to Perpignan, just over the border in France, to watch banned films. Intellectuals gathered amid the neoclassical elegance of the Catalan cultural hub, L'Ateneu.

Middle-class kids who had been brought up in the Eixample loved the seedy beauty of downtown Barcelona, as Natàlia does: "What she missed was a certain aroma, a street, the laughter of friends strolling down La Rambla in waves, the shadows around Santa Maria del Mar, the chilly mornings, the leaves of the plane trees when they fell in autumn." Anyone who knew Barcelona in those years will recognize the "bar on Carrer de Banys Nous where grizzled card sharks and students drank wine and ate olives around barrels that doubled as tables" as El Portalón, and "the old textile-warehouse lobby" near Santa Maria del Mar, now a "large, drafty hall" where "a pair of thick velvet curtains separated two open-plan rooms," as Zeleste, the nightclub for progressive young Catalans of that time.

The time of cherries, of youthful revolt, was not far away from a time of fear. When the novel came out, a great many citizens of Barcelona had experienced

baton charges and vicious police attacks—assaults that were ongoing even as the book was being written and when it was published. But no one had yet written about them. There was no free press. Roig's account of police violence against students who were protesting the Franco regime, among them Natàlia and her friends, has a sense of urgency that came from her own experience as a young activist.

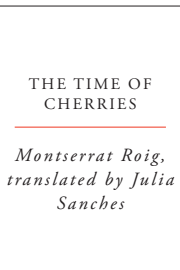
Roig had taken part in one of the most famous sit-ins in Catalonia during the years before the end of the dictatorship, La Caputxinada. In 1975, when she wrote *The Time of Cherries*, the memory of that event in 1966 still felt fresh. More than 400 intellectuals and students had demonstrated against the regime in a Capuchin monastery on the outskirts of Barcelona and were surrounded by police for two days.

Though other novelists later wrote about what it was like to navigate these repressive years in Barcelona, no one else described a protagonist having a backstreet abortion in the city. Once again, Roig's novel broke a silence.

A powerful ghost hovers over the book, that of Puig Antich, the anarchist, who was executed using the *garrote vil*, whereby the victim is slowly strangled. At the time, no one could tell whether this execution was the regime flexing its muscles or emitting one of its last gasps.

The execution causes one of the family arguments in *The Time of Cherries*. When Lluís, Natàlia's brother, refers to Puig Antich as a thief, he gets interrupted by his son: "He wasn't a thief, Dad." Lluís then calls Puig Antich a moron. And then, more weakly: "In any event, those zealots are going to make a mess of things and ruin our chances of joining the Common Market." Lluís is an embodiment of a kind of pragmatism that reigned in those years among the Catalan bourgeoisie.

For others, the execution was chilling. Natàlia's friend Harmonia blames the Communists for the stalled revolution. Another character sums up the bleak situation: "None of us wants to admit just how powerless we are," he says. "It's been years and we're getting old. Nothing has changed." The change came later. No one in this novel could have imagined that in the future, a Barcelona street would be named after Maria Aurèlia Capmany and a square on the city's outskirts would pay tribute to Salvador Puig Antich. A neighborhood park named after Montserrat Roig, who died in 1991, honors her contribution to the reimagining of Barcelona on the brink of change. *A*

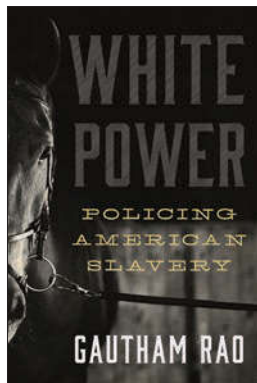


MODERN LIBRARY

Colm Tóibín is the author, most recently, of the novel Long Island. This article was adapted from Tóibín's introduction to the Modern Library edition of The Time of Cherries.

NEW

THE UNIVERSITY OF NORTH CAROLINA PRESS

A NEW IMPRINT
OF UNC PRESS

WHITE POWER

Policing American Slavery

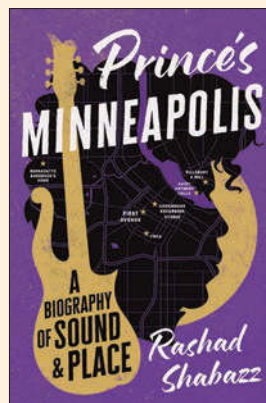
GAUTHAM RAO

"A sweeping and strikingly counterintuitive argument that the colonial and antebellum system of white power did not end with emancipation, but was reconfigured afterward with the same motivation and intent. Rao's longitudinal approach presents a significant contribution to scholarship on the origins of modern policing."

—Stephanie McCurry, author of *Confederate Reckoning*

A Hodding Carter III Book

320 pages \$30.00



PRINCE'S MINNEAPOLIS

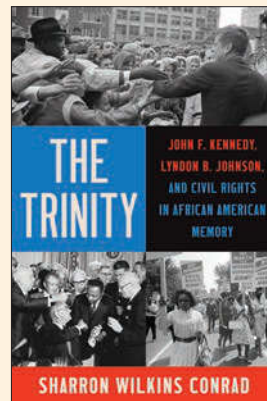
A Biography of Sound and Place

RASHAD SHABAZZ

"Prince is often rightly hailed as an individual virtuoso and genius, but he was also an artist whose tastes and abilities were shaped by long histories of racialized space and arts education, and legacies of cultural coalescence and conflict. Shabazz presents an engaging, compelling, and persuasive analysis of the poetics and politics of place in the music worlds of Minneapolis and their impact on Prince."

—George Lipsitz, author of *The Danger Zone Is Everywhere*

272 pages \$24.95 paper



THE TRINITY

John F. Kennedy, Lyndon B. Johnson, and Civil Rights in African American Memory

SHARRON WILKINS CONRAD

"A superb, original, and urgently needed history that reshapes our understanding of the civil rights era and presidential leadership. Drawing on largely untapped sources and elevating voices too often unheard, Conrad offers a nuanced, deeply engaging account that will captivate both scholars and general readers."

—Ellen Fitzpatrick, author of *The Highest Glass Ceiling*

256 pages \$27.95 paper



THE AMERICAN REVOLUTION

Essays on the Founding Era

EDITED BY
NICHOLAS POPPERINTRODUCTION BY
CYNTHIA A. KIERNER;
PREFACE BY
JOHANN N. NEEM

"The Omohundro Institute is justly renowned for its superb scholarly productions. This volume, published on the occasion of our country's 250th anniversary, continues that tradition of excellence. The essays brim with insights about the meaning and legacies of the American colonies' break with Great Britain. This book is destined to become indispensable to the study of the creation of the United States."

—Annette Gordon-Reed, Pulitzer Prize–

winning author of *The Hemingses of Monticello*

Published by the Omohundro Institute of

Early American History and Culture

304 pages \$29.95 paper



THY WILL BE DONE

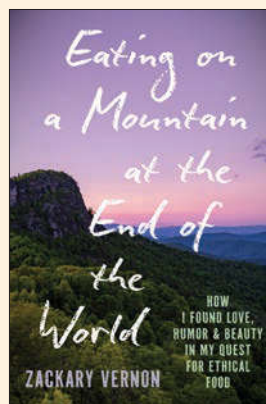
George Washington's Legacy of Slavery and the Fight for American Memory

JOHN GARRISON MARKS

"Marks paints a nuanced, three-dimensional picture of George Washington. He helps us understand him as both revolutionary and enslaver, as president and as captor, as a man who was troubled by the institution even as he continued to participate in it. *Thy Will Be Done* is an exceptional book. This is how George Washington should be taught. This is how history should be done."

—Clint Smith, *New York Times* bestselling author of *How the Word Is Passed*

304 pages \$35.00



EATING ON A MOUNTAIN AT THE END OF THE WORLD

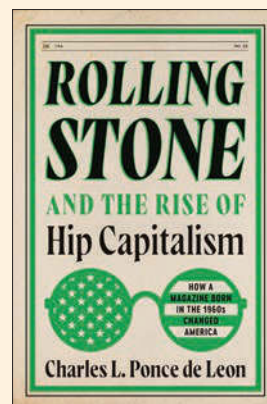
How I Found Love, Humor, and Beauty in My Quest for Ethical Food

ZACKARY VERNON

"Vernon tackles the ethics of growing and consuming food from a deeply personal and engaging perspective. From the outset, it's clear that here is an author who can both grow a tomato and butcher a chicken."

—Diane Flynt, author of *Wild, Tamed, Lost, Revived*

160 pages \$19.95 paper



ROLLING STONE AND THE RISE OF HIP CAPITALISM

How a Magazine Born in the 1960s Changed America

CHARLES L.
PONCE DE LEON

"Ponce de Leon brilliantly contextualizes the history of Rolling Stone while attending to the broader historical transformations that had swept up the magazine by the time of Reagan's ascent. A brilliant examination of the 1960s and its legacies."

—Andrew Hartman, author of *Karl Marx in America*

304 pages \$30.00



PURCHASE
IN BOOKSTORES
CALL 800.848.6224
VISIT UNCPRESS.ORG

FOLLOW
UNCPRESSBLOG.COM





BOOKS

Vigdis Hjorth's Family Secrets

The wildly popular Norwegian novelist returns again and again to a dark past.

By Honor Jones

Vigdis Hjorth, one of Norway's most famous novelists, is best known for writing about the sexual assault of a child by her father. She's published more than 20 books since the 1980s, a number of which take up the same material—a woman trying to remember something that's too dangerous to remember; a family with a secret. Her writing tends to be classified as *virkelighetslitteratur*, or “reality fiction,” and for good reason. Hjorth makes Norway sound like a small town—the sort of place where your neighbors know you're home if they can see your footsteps in the snow—and the overlap between her life and work has more than once been the literary version of tabloid news there.

In 2016, she published *Will and Testament*. The novel was a hit, won the Norwegian Critics Prize for Literature, and made her family furious. Her sister Helga accused Hjorth of using their family members' correspondence in the book; Hjorth said she had permission. Helga then wrote her own novel, about a woman whose sister lies about being raped by their father. Unlike her fellow Norwegian writer Karl Ove Knausgaard, Hjorth doesn't give her characters real people's names. But if anyone had doubts concerning how close the family in *Will and Testament* came to reality, Helga's response seemed perfectly crafted to dispel them. That people talk about the book the way they do, Hjorth has suggested, is partly Helga's fault: “I can't say that there's nothing from reality, because she has proven it.”

If you're thinking, *Not another autofictional trauma plot*—don't. Hjorth's books—especially her latest, *Repetition*, now out in English—are much stranger, and more interesting, than that. As readers, we're accustomed to being steered toward the revelation of a trauma. But what happened to the protagonist of *Repetition* is never made fully explicit. Again and again, the book returns to one long-ago November. There is knowledge here, but it is a knowledge no one wants, leaving the reader slipping around in the dark.

What the novel is working toward is not the exposure of a violation, let alone the processing of any real-life event, but a recognition of the self—a self who survives the scourges of childhood, and a storytelling-self who learns that fiction can reveal otherwise unsayable truths.

AS *REPETITION* OPENS, the first-person narrator, a novelist in her 60s, sits next to an unhappy teenager and her parents at the

symphony one night. She's reminded vividly of events in her own 16th year. The novel in store appears to be about an adolescent girl's first sexual experience. She meets a boy; alone in her room, she practices French kissing by pushing her tongue against the mirror; they dance at a party, and another party; she drinks a beer, and another beer; the boy leads her upstairs.

But the boyfriend quickly proves to be a marginal figure compared with the girl's parents, particularly her compulsively vigilant mother. She is always lurking, waiting for her daughter to come home so that she can inspect her for traces of rebellion—"fingering my clothes and sniffing me, my hair, my breath," asking her where she's been and with whom. The book, like many of Hjorth's, is full of questions, which add up to a deeper one: "Why then this feeling of dread?" Even if you don't know that Hjorth has written about a violated child before, you come to suspect that this is not the girl's first sexual experience.

At the center of the novel is a diary. Now that the girl has a boyfriend, the act that has obsessed her for years, the thing she fears she'll never be able to do right, that she can never manage to joke about the way her friends do, can happen: sex. She promises the diary that she "will write about it here, on these blank pages."

But the night is a failure. The boy is too nervous or inept to do his part. How can she disappoint "the expectant, hungry, hopeful diary"? She has to write something. So she makes it up: "I invented what I had imagined in explicit detail."

The entry starts like a bad romance novel, the boy "brazen and swollen like hardened steel." But soon the language becomes fast and frank: "On paper I did everything I would never have dared to do." She puts the words down "eagerly and with a liberating lack of inhibition and a comforting tenderness for myself." She goes on: "I wrote and I wrote, I filled my enormous void with words." Writing is so powerful that the words themselves become a sex act.

And then her parents find the diary. Their grief and rage are terrifying. But she has discovered something she'll never forget: that "fiction can have a greater impact than the truth, and be more truthful." What she means, in part, is that her made-up story elicited a reaction—her father's despair, her mother's rejection—that she will truly understand only later, when the girl knows the family's secret.

All of this is agonizing, but Hjorth also writes sublimely about the wonder and subjugation of life as a teenager—what it feels like to be a girl with friends, to live in a place that's lovely even in the cold and the dark. And she can be very funny. The girl "might be capable of doing *anything* should the opportunity present itself, except"—so relatable—"it didn't." Consider the sexless sex scene: The boy

Hjorth writes sublimely about the wonder and subjugation of life as a teenager.

climbs on top of her and thrusts and groans. But he's not inside her. She tries pointing out the problem: "You're not inside me." When he stands up, the condom falls right off his flaccid penis. Later, smug and swaggering, he whispers in her ear, "Now I've made a woman of you."

The story isn't funny in the end, because it's replaced by the diary version, which causes so much damage. But it's funny while you're reading it.

Repetition is a powerful sliver of a book—it really doesn't have enough pages to contain as much life as it does. It transcends the trauma plot by, counter-intuitively, immersing us completely in the past: not in one devastating event, but in the whole past, of moment after moment. Terrible things happen in families, in history, Hjorth seems to be saying, but that's not so remarkable. What's remarkable is that these people, who used to be us, existed—that, day after day, they actually lived like this:

I went to the kitchen and sat down in my usual seat, fishcakes in white sauce and potatoes with chopped parsley, I will never forget it. It really did happen, it is strange to remember it now and it seems unreal that this family would sit around a kitchen table and have dinner together almost every night all year round, it's mind-blowing, but that is how it was, and the strangest thing of all is that it was the most natural thing in the world.

"WILL YOU NEVER let it go?" the narrator of *Repetition* demands. "No. I repeat and recall and relive and retell." Of Hjorth's six novels that have been translated into English, all by Charlotte Barslund, four have at their core a broken childhood and buried secrets. Hjorth and her protagonists know that retreading this territory can feel claustrophobic. *Will and Testament*—made up of thoughts and second thoughts, attacks and counterattacks—is about the narrator's battle to make her family listen to what her father did. When nobody does ("Shame on you"; "What nonsense"; "Liar, Mum hissed"), she has no choice: She repeats herself. But don't think for a second that anyone is more fed up than she is. Put it in her epitaph, she thinks: "All because of my stupid childhood."

Release from remembering would be bliss, but even if that were possible, it's not Hjorth's goal. *Repetition* is needed to know oneself, and to make oneself known. Hjorth's protagonists also turn that obsessive attention outward—to try to understand others. In *Is Mother Dead*, which was longlisted for the 2023 International Booker Prize, the narrator struggles to approach her estranged mother by imagining over and over what could have made her the way she is. What must she

have suffered that left her incapable of caring for her child? The result is a colossal, and failed, feat of empathy: A mother can be forgiven many mistakes, but not for giving up on loving her daughter. It is the saddest story about a parent, and the saddest story about the limits of storytelling, I think I have ever read.

The narrator of *Repetition* is different from these earlier protagonists because she knows that her art grows out of her repetitions. She is no longer trying to explain herself to anyone, but fixing in memory that which threatens to slip away. The book emerges from the tension between what the narrator expects to be “unforgettable”—the night with the boy—and the originating event that everyone has tried so hard to forget. She writes to return to the past, to the bewildered girl she used to be—to save her from “the mute darkness.”

More than four decades ago, Hjorth published her first book: a children’s picture book about a boy in a yellow apartment building. She has written fiction and nonfiction about politics, philosophy, drinking. *Long Live the Post Horn!*, published in the United States in 2020, is very different from *Repetition* (it’s about a consultant tasked with writing PR materials opposing a European Union policy on postal rates that ... Actually, don’t worry about it). Yet it’s also concerned with the power of language, and children’s capacity to wield that power. It begins in despair—“the silence on the Metro and the chill, the sick and the fear of getting sick”—before brightening into hope.

Deep in the book comes a story: A postman recounts how he has spent months tracking down an old woman named Helga Brun so that he can deliver her a letter. Her tale, he warns, is “shocking” and “dreadful” yet (how very Hjorth) “enjoyable.” Helga arrives on an island in 1967. She has come to teach at the island’s school for the summer, so that working parents have somewhere to send their children while the ordinary instructors have a vacation. (Americans: This is not magical realism; it’s just Scandinavia.) She teaches the children geography and takes them outdoors to learn the names of birds. Parents smile “at the sight of this cheerful group, the island’s future.”

But then she assigns an essay. What is it about? The children won’t say, but something sinister is going on. They brood and can’t sleep until one night they start frantically writing, and when they’re done, instead of leaving the papers on their desks where the parents can read them, the children run outside, all the way to Helga’s house, to deliver the essays straight into her hands.

The next day, their eyes are “eerily dark,” and the parents shudder to look at them. Now we’re in a horror movie, and all the adults of the island, “led by the vicar and the doctor,” gather at the school—missing only pitchforks to complete the scene—and

storm inside to demand that Helga tell them “the title of the essay.” When Helga answers, the parents leap forward to seize the essays; the children scream. Everyone, young and old, grabs

at the delicate papers which were torn to shreds between fearful, frantic fingers, the children stuffed the scraps into their mouths and swallowed them, in less than a minute the pile was pulverised from the shared desire of everyone involved, a desire for annihilation.

Helga is sent away. The children will forget, the parents say, but the children don’t. Forty years later, one of them writes that letter the postman is determined to deliver, thanking Helga for asking the one thing their parents couldn’t stand to know, the thing the children had suffered over, alone and in silence: “Why am I unhappy?”

One reason I love this parable is that it’s such a long way from autofiction. But all of Hjorth’s themes are here. The children know that what they wrote is so powerful, it has to be destroyed. Would they have told the parents eventually, if only they’d been patient and gentle? I don’t know.

The narrator of *Repetition* tears up her diary and flushes the pages down the toilet. For many years, she doesn’t write. Then one day she publishes a children’s book. *That’s okay*, her parents must have felt. *That’s no threat*. She keeps going. She imagines her parents anxiously leafing through her books—their relief, at first, “when they didn’t find what they were looking for,” their worry growing as the books come closer to the truth. Pity them, those “poor, long-suffering parents always on tenterhooks.” Since she was a child, she has never understood why they were afraid of her. Now that she’s a writer, she knows why.

Even in *Repetition*, however, so much remains unsaid—not to protect the parents, but to protect the self. The girl “would not have survived remembering and reliving” all that has happened. “It could have killed her, I know this because I, her mature self, don’t have the strength” to relive it either. I wonder if Hjorth will ever write a character who does. But even if that were possible, I can’t imagine her project ever being finished. The memories of childhood return because they need “to tell you something,” the narrator says on the first page of *Repetition*. On the last page, she has a vision. She opens the door to find the girl she used to be: “I put my arms around her, she lets herself be held and our embrace suspends time.” *A*

Honor Jones is a senior editor at The Atlantic and the author of the novel Sleep.

REPETITION

Vigdis Hjorth,
translated by
Charlotte Barslund

VERSO

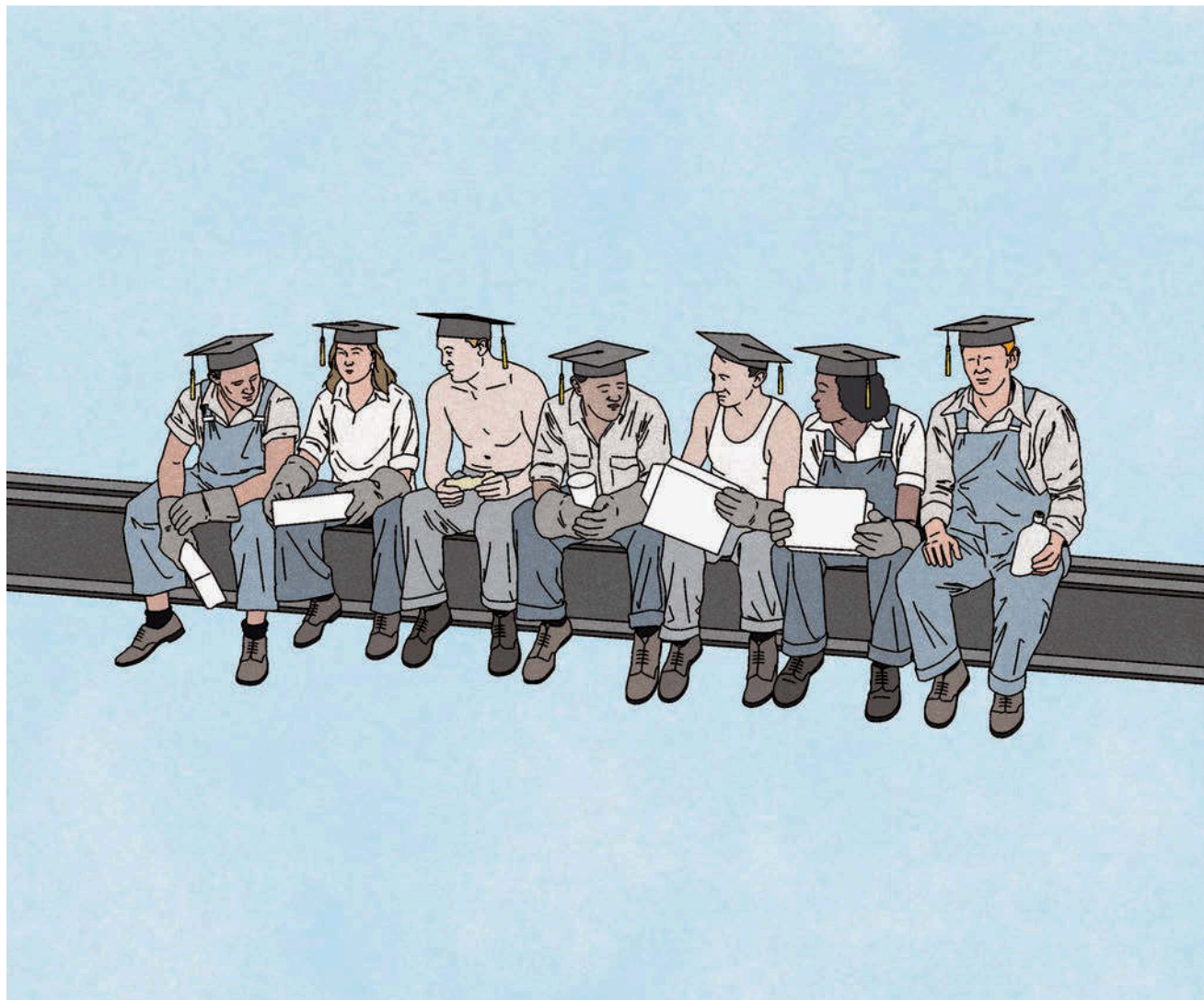
The College-Educated Working Class

Can a generation of graduates frustrated by their economic prospects change American labor politics?

By George Packer

This is an age of mutinies. For more than a decade in America, they've come so thick and fast that they trip over one another: the Tea Party, Occupy, Black Lives Matter, the Resistance, the anti-lockdown protests, the insurrection, the anti-ICE protests. The ur-mutiny, encompassing some of these, provoking and provoked by others, is MAGA. Even in full authoritarian control of the federal government, it still acts like a rioter laying dynamite at the foundation of a decayed establishment.

We understand these revolts in terms of the dominant political fact of our time, the forever war between red and blue. The mutinies are staged by one side or the other, and every high-profile trial, incendiary speech, and shooting caught on camera divides Americans instantly and predictably into two opposing camps, with



apparently irreconcilable visions of what is true and of what the country is and should be: multicultural America versus heritage America. The former is inclusive, outward- and forward-looking; the latter is exclusive, inward-looking, and nostalgic for a past that it tries to recapture by tearing up traditions, norms, and the Constitution itself.

The obvious precedent for an age of mutinies is the decade before the Civil War—the years of *Uncle Tom's Cabin*, Bleeding Kansas, *Dred Scott*, and John Brown—when pressure built up until it exploded in what future Secretary of State William H. Seward labeled “the irrepressible conflict.” The roll call of the present goes through the coronavirus pandemic, George Floyd, January 6, Project 2025, Charlie Kirk, Renee Good, and Alex Pretti. Now that President Trump's masked militias are battling residents in the streets of blue cities, our own conflict seems to be coming to a head.

But if we unfasten our gaze long enough from the riveting prospect of another civil war, a different historical period comes to mind. The fundamental sources of our troubles, going back half a century, are economic inequality, political paralysis, corruption, mass immigration, and cultural and technological upheavals. These were exactly the country's great problems at the start of the previous century. In 1914, Walter Lippmann wrote in his manifesto, *Drift and Mastery*: “No mariner ever enters upon a more uncharted sea than does the average human being born into the twentieth century.” Several decades of populism, progressivism, and reaction led to the emergence of a new order with the New Deal.

What is life like for someone born in the 21st century? Your everyday reality is disorienting change—but not the kind that freed Lippmann and his generation to shape their era. Instead, your overwhelming feeling is that the game is rigged against you. You see the old as at best indifferent, if not outright predatory, and lacking the ability or the desire to solve the problems they've inflicted on you. The electronic air you breathe crackles with vituperation. Political and media elites hoard status and wealth by keeping you in a perpetual fever of resentment and fury. Meanwhile, tech giants addict you from toddlerhood to devices that alienate you from other people and the natural world, trapping you in a hall of mirrors, until you give up on the idea that truth is even knowable and surrender to the wildest images of unreality. Your sense of your own existence grows fragile, and your job prospects are as precarious as your mental health. Whatever your race or gender, it feels like a liability. The system is a conspiracy against your chance at a decent life.

Anger and helplessness drive some young people to Nick Fuentes, others to Hasan Piker, and others still to fentanyl or 20-hour days of *Fortnite*. They might

revile one another, but they exist in the same frame, where they suffer many of the same afflictions. From this perspective, the culture wars momentarily recede. Perhaps the most important arena of struggle isn't the internet, where the wars are fought and nothing is achieved except division, but the physical world, where certain problems are common to all ordinary people. Perhaps the deepest conflict is not between red and blue, but between power and powerlessness.

Compared with a vicious online duel, this conflict is hard to dramatize. It seldom becomes the focus of politics, except in grand rhetorical gestures or small fixes for the deterioration of everyday life. A congresswoman denounces monopolistic oligarchy; a senator rails against Big Tech; another congresswoman drafts legislation against the nuisance of overly bright headlights and for the “right to repair” your own truck or washing machine. A movement of 20-somethings embraces dumb phones. And even now, amid the head-spinning events of Trump's second term, there's a sense that nothing fundamental changes. In Lippmann's time, the relations among citizens, corporations, and government underwent a historic transformation; in our time, new laws and civic reforms hardly ever arise. We spend our energy on the mostly online battles of the red-blue war, stumbling down the path of the 1850s, while the powerful entities that control our lives grow bigger and more corrupt.

The education divide is the most significant factor in American politics.

THE SUBTITLE of Noam Scheiber's *Mutiny: The Rise and Revolt of the College-Educated Working Class* points to an unexpected group of young people who are toiling against concentrated wealth and power. A college-educated working class sounds like an oxymoron because socioeconomic status is generally defined by education and believed to rise with each academic degree. In recent years, a college education has become one of the most reliable indicators of both economic well-being and voting behavior. Americans with a college degree tend to make 75 percent more money over their lifetime than those without, and in the past three presidential elections, these better-educated, wealthier voters have moved steadily to the Democratic Party. In 2024, they voted for Kamala Harris over Donald Trump by 16 percentage points. As if according to some law of political dynamics, non-college-educated Americans have gone for Trump and the Republican Party by similar margins. The political alignment of the 20th century, when workers tended to favor Democrats and professionals Republicans, has been reversed in the 21st. The education divide is the most significant factor in American politics—sharpest among white voters, and increasing among Latino voters as well.



These trends are so glaring that the term *working class* is now used to describe both those without a college degree and the MAGA base. So in reporting on the college-educated working class, Scheiber, who covers labor for *The New York Times*, is like a zoologist whose fieldwork has revealed the existence of an animal that contradicts some long-standing theory of speciation.

His subjects, in their 20s or early 30s, came out of college with heavy debts and unrealistic expectations. A Grinnell grad, recipient of a prestigious postcollege fellowship, takes a job at a Chicago Starbucks to support himself while he tries to break into theater, only to find years later that the theater dream has died and he's still making lattes, hectored by managers, hard up enough to apply for food stamps. After college, an "Apple fangirl" in Maryland is encouraged by a local Apple Store to think of her job in terms of passion and human potential. Hired to do one-on-one tech tutorials, she hopes to move up to designing the curriculum; instead, the company's relentless focus on profit traps her as a glorified saleswoman in a retail

mall, and she fails to keep up with her bills. Corporate America seduces these ambitious young people with exalted titles that bear scant relation to the reality of the work: Apple Store "creatives" and "geniuses" who have to wheedle customers into buying a \$3,500 Vision Pro headset, Starbucks "partners" who prepare venti iced caramel macchiatos all day, Amazon "associates" whose moves around the warehouse are tracked to the minute, adjunct "professors" who earn submedian pay with little hope of a career in their field.

It would be easy for an older, more comfortable reader, or a more truly impoverished one, to dismiss the grievances of Scheiber's subjects. How sorry can you feel for an underemployed Hollywood scriptwriter who makes ends meet through a "sugar dating" app, as a companion for wealthy older men? These young graduates start out naive about the heartlessness of the corporate world and harbor illusory hopes for success in unforgiving professions. Culturally, they have little in common with meat packers or home health aides who never expect to do more than get by—who are toiling for their children's futures, not their own. The college-educated are trained to expect that the world will make room for them, and when it doesn't—when they suffer the indignities of wage work, with its unpredictable schedules and disrespectful bosses, and can see no way up or out—the blow isn't just economic; it's psychological. "They were often bourgeois in their tastes," Scheiber writes. "They cradled sleek smartphones and expensive cups of coffee. They watched prestige TV on demand. But the previous decade and a half had bequeathed them the bank accounts—and the politics—of the proletariat."

The individual stories Scheiber tells sometimes feel like cases of bad luck or poor decision making, but he's writing more broadly about a generation of graduates whose prospects have unquestionably dimmed. The price of a college degree is soaring while its comparative benefit is shrinking. The pay gap between college and high-school grads has stopped growing over the past two decades, partly because of the Great Recession and the pandemic. The number of jobs in some of the most desirable careers has dropped, creating intense competition due to what the scholar Peter Turchin calls "elite overproduction." Or, as Scheiber puts it, "too many people with expensive credentials chased too few jobs requiring those credentials." When expectation and reality part ways for a cohort that's been raised on the assumption of upward mobility—when elites start to sink, and reform is blocked—the political waters get very rough, often leading to social disintegration and unrest. Turchin's historical examples include pre-revolutionary France, Russia, and Iran; another is the United States in this decade.

Scheiber's main interest is the development of a radical political consciousness in a generation of phone addicts and Netflix junkies. *Mutiny* follows a dozen or so employees at Starbucks, Apple, Amazon, Hollywood studios, and research universities who all come to the same epiphany: "They saw themselves as members of the rank and file. They grumbled about their supervisors and cursed their corporate overlords." This new awareness, whether or not it qualifies them as bona fide members of the working class, leads them to join union-organizing drives, publicize corporate abuses, go on strike, and gradually find more purpose in labor activism than in their thwarted professional ambitions.

WE REMEMBER the pandemic as a boiling point in the culture wars. The continuous battles over lockdowns, masking, police violence, expertise, conspiracy theories, and the outcome of the 2020 election have never really subsided. But the pandemic also exposed the grotesque unfairness of our economy and society in deeply personal ways, cutting across the red-blue divide. In the pandemic's early days, before the crisis became completely subsumed by the cultural civil war, a memorable phrase appeared: *essential workers*, people whose livelihood required them to show up at work and risk their health. The difference between the fates of essential and nonessential workers was a profound injustice, and a healthy country would have made it a focus of public attention and policy. Jeff Bezos's fortune increased by \$24 billion in the pandemic's first month. Meanwhile, his company's treatment of its essential workers, and the firing of Chris Smalls, an outspoken employee in a Staten Island warehouse, triggered the creation of the first Amazon union—a milestone in the recent surge of labor activism in America.

But Amazon turned out to be a more difficult case for labor organizing in the early 2020s than Starbucks, Apple, or Disney. Disagreements over tactics and strategy led to a power struggle that divided the union, damaging the cause of labor at Amazon. Smalls, the union's first president, framed the division along lines of race and class; his leadership faction claimed to speak for the warehouse's Black and brown workers who never went to college (though Scheiber points out that the opposition to Smalls also included nonwhite, non-college-educated workers). In his forthcoming memoir, *When the Revolution Comes*, Smalls accuses white college-educated organizers at the Staten Island warehouse of trying to take power away from the authentic working class. He insists that the Amazon union must be led by workers of color—only they have the experience of hardship to understand and speak for the rank and

The college-educated are trained to expect that the world will make room for them, and when it doesn't, the blow isn't just economic.

file. "If there is any mistake I made, any regret I have," Smalls writes, "it's the fact that early on we let people who didn't see the importance of race and culture the way we did get into positions of power within our movement."

In a way, Smalls is challenging the thesis of *Mutiny*. He's implying that there's something inauthentic, maybe flatly contradictory, about a college-educated working class, especially a white one. He's saying that "race and culture" matter more than an hourly wage. The fracturing of the Amazon union at the Staten Island warehouse plays a relatively small part in *Mutiny*. Though Scheiber occasionally questions the wisdom of his protagonists, he's plainly on their side. He considers their oppression real, their struggles just, and their activism the best way to achieve more stable, dignified lives. But he isn't sufficiently aware of the insularity and fragility of their project.

Mutiny includes no college grads in dead-end jobs whose grievances have turned them toward MAGA rather than union activism—young men and women recruited by Turning Point USA while still in college. Instead, most of the book's protagonists would feel at home at a Democratic Socialists of America convention. They're the kind of progressive Zoomers and Millennials who use gender-neutral pronouns and post online about Palestine. Within two days of October 7, a Starbucks organizer called on X for "solidarity with Palestine!" and even though the post was soon taken down, Gaza created such controversy for Starbucks that the company and union sued each other over social-media posts about the war. Joe Biden's efforts to be the most pro-labor president in history didn't spare him the wrath of young Starbucks employees who accused him of complicity in genocide. The war galvanized them in a way that haggling over wages and hours no longer did.

The point isn't that the Starbucks union should have taken a different position on Gaza, or that Smalls was wrong to insist on the centrality of "race and culture" at the Amazon warehouse. But these episodes show how easily the culture war can insert itself into a righteous cause. At the Apple Store in Maryland, Black and white workers in the union maintained cohesion and were able to negotiate a decent contract by focusing on corporate greed, which required a delicate balance between acknowledging the differences in their life experiences and resisting the centrifugal pull of identity.

This decade has seen more union activism than any other in almost half a century. The overweening power of corporations and plutocrats has turned much of the country in favor of labor, and Scheiber believes that it doesn't matter whether workers assemble automobiles, make upscale coffee drinks, or write

MUTINY:
THE RISE AND
REVOLT OF
THE COLLEGE-
EDUCATED
WORKING
CLASS

Noam Scheiber

FARRAR, STRAUS
AND GIROUX

television scripts. He seems sanguine that the college divide is fading as more and more Americans experience the whip hand of a heartless economic order. Scheiber cites polls that show college graduates drawing closer to the more conservative views of the working class on immigration and crime, and he takes this as evidence that “there may be a basis for an alliance between the two groups after all.”

But other polls suggest real disagreements between those with and without a college degree. For example, on whether to deport all immigrants in the country illegally, one poll found that the gap is almost 20 percentage points among non-Hispanic white people. In general, I’m more skeptical than Scheiber is that progressive baristas—let alone newly unionized doctors and architects—are going to be eagerly embraced by their working-class brothers and sisters. Plenty of Americans will dislike the attitudes and styles of *Mutiny’s* activists. There are important cultural differences between an internist struggling to treat patients in a private-equity conglomerate and a John Deere machinist on strike because of layoffs. That both belong to a union might matter less than that one voted for Harris, the other for Trump, and each has some reason to fear and loathe the other. The culture war is burning too hot for a class war to snuff it out anytime soon.

The radicalization of college-educated Americans who have begun to live the unpleasant realities of their less privileged compatriots—who can hardly afford rent, much less to buy a house and start a family—is an encouraging turn. They could form part of a broader social movement that finally addresses our deepest problems instead of dissolving them in electronic bile. A professional class that identifies with America’s multitudes of have-nots and votes on that basis would be a powerful force for greater equality and opportunity.

But to succeed, such a movement has to be aware of the fault lines that could make it fail, and take care not to widen them. Tread lightly around the identity traits no one chose and the beliefs no one will give up; instead, emphasize a common economic fate. The ground that unites the powerless against the powerful is always about to collapse. Our irrepressible red-blue conflict is always ready to set Americans against Americans in every conceivable way: education, race, religion, age, gender, region, even views of foreign wars. It’s better to be honest about these differences, and try not to rub them raw until they destroy the chance for a better country, than to assume that they don’t matter or wish them out of existence. *A*

George Packer is a staff writer at The Atlantic and the author, most recently, of The Emergency, a novel.

Misrule Music

By Robert Pinsky

When charismatic indecency carries the day
There’s not much comfort in the ancient cult
That says the dance of misrule always prances
At its one frantic ball—seems like forever
Until the music stops, the flags come down,
And ordinary corruption comes back, refreshed
In laughter. “Hitler has only got one ball.”
Misrule, ha ha. But tell it to the victims:
Millions at the time and millions more today
And everyone ever since, forever, a victim?

Long-ago bumper sticker, my naive, glib
Heart in the right place: Resist Authority.
The charismatic indecency that carries
The day this year this time is not the antic
Indecency of Harpo with scissors to snip
My necktie if I am Simon the Pharisee
Who invited Jesus to supper, when Jesus favored
The sinner who brought expensive perfume to wash
His feet—and Simon wondered, was it proper?
Excuse the prig, bless Harpo, bless the sinner.

God knows what’s in our nature, she used her hair.
He squeezed a horn and chased a squealing woman
Across the movie set. We laughed. The horse
At the feast of Saturn rode the master’s back.
Bless the anonymous indecent Carnival lyrics
To the “Colonel Bogey March,” and all the better
Knowing there never was a Colonel Bogey:
“Himmler had something similar.” Prisoners of war
Whistle the tune in *Bridge on the River Kwai*,
“And Goebbels had no balls at all,” but no—No,

This time, the very opposites themselves
Reverse the cult of misrule itself undone
Down to the altar. The European tribes
Crowned for one day a fool a goat a chicken,
To give the finger to a horned or strutting god.
Sometimes the blond brutes even ate the chicken.
Even the parody of order is all balled up.
And if it has happened before, all the less reason
Or more to wonder or shrug at whatever charisma
Of darker or dumber indecency carries the day.

Robert Pinsky is a former poet laureate of the United States. His most recent book of poems is Proverbs of Limbo.

ESSAY

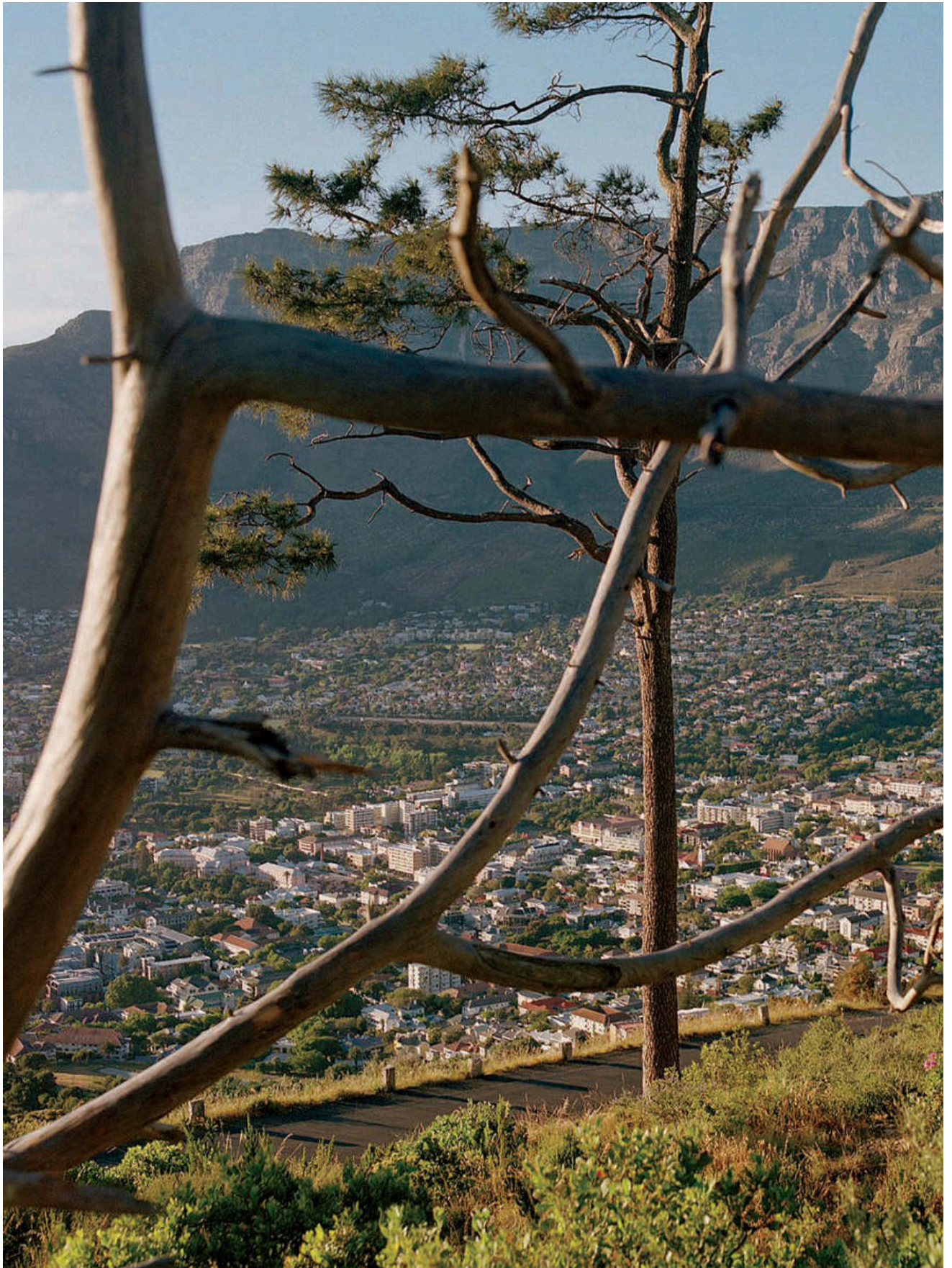
The City Where Coetzee Is God

*Searching for the
Nobel laureate in
Cape Town, the city
he left behind*

By Gary Shteyngart

*Photographs by
Kent Andreassen*

When I arrived in Cape Town, South Africa, in October, at the windy end of spring, setting foot on African soil for the first time in my life, it wasn't to indulge in the animal voyeurism that wealthy newlyweds tell me will change my life. The prospect of being stuck in a jeep watching wildebeest pour through the veld did not intrigue me. Instead, I was on a hunt for traces of one of the world's



strangest writers, J. M. Coetzee, in the city from which he had emerged, a city that he'd intermittently written about—without revealing much of it—and then left, in 2002. The 86-year-old author's legacy, I'd been told, stirred the kinds of passions that have gone extinct pretty much everywhere else on the planet. Here was my chance to witness not a band of rutting gnu but something I had not imagined could still exist: a communal literary obsession in a postliterary age, at the center of which is a man whom acolytes call, simply, "God."

I had first encountered Coetzee's books during my formative years as a writer, in the late '90s and early aughts. Every second that I wasn't drinking or abusing drugs or lamely trying to seduce someone or sleeping at a desk job or reworking my first novel, I was reading Toni Morrison, Salman Rushdie, Don DeLillo, a young woman out of London with the chipper name of Zadie—experimental, social-realist, modernist, travelogue, memoir. I probably read at least three books a week, a thought that both inspires and depresses me today.

Of course I read Coetzee. Nobody could make you feel as cultured and literary in the space of some 200-odd pages as the stoic and writerly looking man from Cape Town. I read the second of his two Booker Prize-winning novels, *Disgrace*, when it came out in 1999, at a time when I was experimenting heavily with ketamine, and then went to the back catalog, the novels of the apartheid era, including *Waiting for the Barbarians* and the other Booker winner, 1983's *Life & Times of Michael K*. In 2003, he won the Nobel Prize in Literature—the second South African writer to do so.

I mention the ketamine not to sound au courant, but because the dissociative properties of the drug tracked nicely with what I perceived to be the interior mood and tenor of the novels, or at least of their

protagonists. David Lurie, the disgraced literature professor at the center of *Disgrace*, and the titular Michael K, a simple gardener, are as different as can be in class, education, and race. But as I read their stories, they both felt cut in two: one part of their character acting, suffering, surviving; the other observing from above or below. They are inhabiting and yet also floating through their worlds, untethered to place and people. Many of Coetzee's characters feel landless; they've left home (*Disgrace*),

the past is freighted with guilt—a sense, implicit or explicit, that their "presence was grounded in a crime, namely colonial conquest, perpetuated by apartheid," as Coetzee writes in his 2009 semi-fictional memoir, *Summertime*, part of a trio he called *Scenes From Provincial Life*. As for the future: In Coetzee's pages, it generally promises catastrophe.

The ketamine sensibility wasn't all that drew me to him. I am no stranger to writing about dystopia, or to the subject of homelessness; emigration is a loss of home. Coetzee decamped for Australia the year before he won the Nobel Prize. I left my native St. Petersburg at the age of 7, and I dream of it perhaps once a week (given the political situation, a visit isn't likely anytime soon). I couldn't help wondering if Coetzee dreams of Cape Town after the sun sets over Adelaide. Somewhere in the novels I read was a moody African city of rainy skies that seemed so different from the cities in the works of Chinua Achebe and Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o, and even the Johannesburg of Nadine Gordimer, who won South Africa's first literature Nobel. Yet Coetzee's Cape Town was always blurry. A very large mountain, flat-topped like a table, sometimes made its presence known in his pages, but this writer seemed to want to keep the drama internal, or to reach past the particular for the universal parable.

I visited the city he left behind because I was curious to figure out what Cape Town may have meant to him, how it might have shaped him, perhaps why he'd moved away. Maybe I wanted to understand a little better the mind of the man floating above the work, more in control of his sentences and his plots, more godlike, in a way, than just about any other writer I had read. And I wanted to discover, too, how he could remain godlike in certain circles—to some a Kafka whose portrayals of alienation gave his once-pariah state a passport to a wider



J. M. Coetzee, 2003.

Previous page: A view of the City Bowl of Cape Town, looking toward Table Mountain.

or are homeless themselves (*Michael K*), or have relationships with the homeless that sometimes bleed into a kind of intimacy (*Waiting for the Barbarians*, *Age of Iron*). Many of them are swaddled in the privilege of their white skin, yet they yearn for a kind of absolution from the sins of their circumstances (an idea not unfamiliar to the liberal-minded white reader living in Donald Trump's America). For them,

world, to others a false prophet of doom who had abandoned the “Mother City” right when it was starting to prove his dire predictions wrong.

I came armed with an essay by my friend Imraan Coovadia, himself a novelist of some note and the head of the creative-writing program at the University of Cape Town. Titled “Coetzee in (and out of) Cape Town,” it appeared a decade and a half ago in a relatively obscure cultural journal in the Philippines, and its sweeping criticisms of Coetzee, painting him as a difficult colleague and his work as socially regressive, had set Cape Town’s literary community on fire. Various friends of Coetzee’s warned me not to trust Coovadia, because he was shunned by most Coetzee scholars, and one of them told me that the writer had been deeply hurt by the essay—the work of a former student, no less. Coetzee had been something like a mentor to Coovadia in the ’90s, when the future apostate was an undergraduate at Harvard and Coetzee was a visiting professor.

Coovadia’s essay is still shocking to read, and it hasn’t been forgotten in some Capetonian precincts. Coetzee, a writer I had regarded as a distant mystery, a subject of graduate papers and bland prize tributes, comes across as a contentious figure, a politically evasive writer who sought “to insert his own name onto the bookshelves beside Conrad and Dostoyevsky.” He also inspired wild rumors of varying credibility, including the tale that he’d once locked a rival in the trunk of his car. Coovadia doesn’t lend credence to such allegations, and I didn’t have the desire or journalistic wherewithal to investigate them. But I could examine Coetzee’s legacy up close, in the city that lays the greatest claim to him—a backdrop for his dark prophecies of social decay and civil strife that has instead become a cosmopolitan tourist destination, where farm-to-table delicacies, natural splendors, and seaside resorts beckon, but its greatest writer is nowhere to be found.

WHEN YOU SEE Table Mountain—its scale, its dominance of the sky—everything changes. The mountain’s backside, the one so many Capetonians prefer

to its city-facing side because it receives more rainfall and is hence more verdant, commanded the windshield of my taxi on the highway from the airport, just as the road left behind one of the impoverished townships of the surrounding Cape Flats, its corrugated roofs glinting atop informal piles of brick. This strange double vision mirrors so much of Coetzee’s work: poverty close enough to feel, the salvation of nature far in the distance, likely beyond the reach of his morally and often physically struggling characters.

There are cities like Los Angeles, ringed and cut by mountains, and cityscapes that are punctuated by outcroppings such as Rio de Janeiro’s Sugarloaf Mountain, but

*For all of the
region’s surface
attractions,
Coetzee’s continental
brand of
allegorical realism
was what put
Cape Town
on the global
literary and
intellectual map.*

I have never seen an urban place as thoroughly ensconced within stony promontories as Cape Town. The city lies in an urban bowl surrounded by Table Mountain, by the fearsome Lion’s Head, and by the lion’s posterior, known as Signal Hill; some of Cape Town’s prime beachside real estate crouches beneath the Twelve Apostles, a range of (actually 18) similar peaks. St. Petersburg was built by Peter the Great to make its inhabitants feel small in comparison with the ornate might of its imperial architecture; here, one is cut down to size the moment one looks up and sees a blank cliff face that refuses to stare back, or Table Mountain when it’s

covered by a run of wispy clouds that the locals call a “tablecloth.”

My companion for the next 10 days, the photographer Kent Andreassen, met me at the Taj Cape Town hotel in the city’s center, about a block away from Parliament, shortly after I’d checked in. We immediately charged up Lion’s Head in the trail-ready Toyota that everyone seemed to drive around there. “Mongoose! Mongoose!” he cried as we nearly ran over said animal. I recalled my childhood love of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, the mongoose hero of a Kipling story, which had become a popular animated film in the Soviet Union.

Throughout my visit, Capetonians kept intimating that although I had finally made it to Africa, I hadn’t really—that their city and most of its inhabitants existed apart from the rest of the continent. The sources of this exceptionalism were both physical and spiritual: first, its rare natural beauty, and second, a (more Coetzeean) sense that it was a remnant that had broken away from some other world entirely and drifted down to the edge of Africa.

In the cultural musings of Coetzee’s white characters, that world is Europe—Lurie, for example, spends much of *Disgrace* planning to write an opera about Lord Byron. And Coetzee took his literary cues from European modernists: Kafka composing his parables; Dostoyevsky shaking his fist at God (or perhaps vice versa); Conrad seeking truth at the edge of empire. For all of the region’s surface attractions, Coetzee’s continental brand of allegorical realism was what put Cape Town, a city closer to Antarctica than to London, on the global literary and intellectual map. Was the author, like the city itself, in Africa but not quite of it?

“Cape Town is showing off for you,” Andreassen said as the city below us shone prismatically, the way it never would in a Coetzee novel. The Cape’s notorious wind had decided to take a rest. In the distance, we could see the loading docks of the massive port stocked with colorful Lego—Chinese shipping containers. Closer was something approximating the skyline of a modest Canadian city, the downtown where I was staying. Closer still, the vividly painted buildings of

the Bo-Kaap, a neighborhood of mostly Muslim residents of the Cape Malay subgroup. And in the middle of the bay, Robben Island, where Nelson Mandela was imprisoned for nearly two decades, rebuked all of this beauty with history.

Next to a Muslim shrine where we'd paused at the top of the hill, a family of three lay sheltered in the shade of an anemic-looking bush. "You guys want some apples?" Andreasen asked the disheveled patriarch, who shook him off with an explanation for his refusal that could have come from *Michael K* or *Age of Iron*: "It's because I got no teeth." The rest of the family accepted the fruit.

We headed down the other side of the hill toward Camps Bay and instantly found ourselves, visually, at least, in Malibu or Sydney's Bondi Beach. We passed the street where the current South African president, Cyril Ramaphosa, has a home. White villas, fearsomely armored against intruders, were stacked up and down the hill. Despite the tense security situation—Cape Town's homicide rate is among the highest in the world—the city has become a magnet for foreigners. Andreasen (who had recently suffered a brutal attack) noted that crime, and the frigid waters (he is, like many residents, a surfer), are all that keep Cape Town from being completely overrun. *The Telegraph* rated it the best city on Earth in 2025. So did *Time Out*: "Locals and visitors alike can hang out with a colony of African penguins, taste world-class wines, stroll Blue Flag beaches, enjoy views from atop one of the New 7 Wonders of Nature"—Table Mountain—"and visit one of the world's coolest neighborhoods, East City, all in one day."

Driving past Camps Bay, we came to Sea Point, a traditionally Jewish neighborhood fronting the beach. Here was my first chance to contrast the scenes

of a Coetzee novel with what I could see on the ground. In *Michael K*, the eponymous character finds himself trying to survive in a civil war. The first part of the novel involves a journey he undertakes with his ill mother, who's been working as a domestic for a "retired hosiery manufacturer" in Sea Point, which is portrayed as an abandoned shell under martial law. He's trying to convey her by means of a jury-rigged wheelbarrow to her native Prince Albert, at the southern edge of the semiarid region known as the Karoo, so



Imraan Coovadia, the head of the creative-writing program at the University of Cape Town, roiled the city's literary community with his essay about Coetzee.

that she can die peacefully on the land where she was born.

Michael K repudiates the feverish world building that pervades a lot of dystopian fiction. The combatants in the civil war are never named, nor is the reason for the war; characters' races are (as in the rest of Coetzee's fiction) mostly unspecified. But city landmarks get slipped in, as do racial clues, at least for locals who can recognize them. *Michael K* wheels his mother "across Beach Road and on to the paved

promenade along the seafront," a quiet scene that later gives way to mob violence on the road. Because his mother is a servant, readers have assumed that they are "Coloured." (To preempt the American reader's justified ire: *Coloured*, in the South African context, refers to most people of mixed-race heritage.) Now I walked down the same paved promenade, past absurdly fit young men engaged in push-up competitions (squat and you're on Miami's Ocean Drive), past swimmers' bodies glinting in gorgeous beachside pools, past housewives speed-walking away the afternoon.

The incongruity between the grim dystopia that Coetzee conjured and the booming post-apartheid reality of Cape Town is terribly relevant to the way he is perceived, and puzzled over, by South Africans today. Forty years ago, the strangeness of his settings stirred debate too: How to read this lofty writer's views of his country's actual anti-apartheid struggles? "The unique and controversial aspect of this work," Nadine Gordimer wrote in her review of *Michael K*, "is that while it is implicitly and highly political, Coetzee's heroes are those who ignore history, not make it." Admiring his fierce vision of human oppression, she also detected "a revulsion against all political and revolutionary solutions": Rather than join a band of guerrillas, *Michael K*, a harelipped loner raised in a state home for the "unfortunate," sticks to his gardening.

Allegory can open many interpretive doors, as it has for Coovadia. In his essay, he cites *Michael K* as an example of a narrative that speaks to the white South Africans who fled the country in anticipation of a bleak future under Black rule. "You could ask," Coovadia writes, "whether Coetzee was offering a warning or something which has more the quality of a wish"—a justification for the decision to flee. Bolstering this critique was Coetzee's own post-apartheid departure.

Coovadia's insider reading, an uncommon one, hadn't occurred to me. I had imagined the many checkpoints through which Michael K had to pass on his journey as being manned by white soldiers from warring factions. Coetzee, for his part, bridled at hearing his novels "discussed as political statements dressed up as fiction," he once wrote in a letter; he was frustrated by the failure to read "them as they were written: as accounts of the possible lives of possible people."

In any case, I wondered if Coetzee would argue for his self-exile on moral grounds, as a colonizer whose "presence there was legal but illegitimate," as a character in *Summertime* says. "We had an abstract right to be there, a birthright, but the basis of that right was fraudulent." To

which the daughter of *Disgrace*'s white protagonist, who is gang-raped at her farm, adds: "Why should I be allowed to live here without paying?" Her father himself experiences a harrowing downfall. When the novel came out, half a decade after the euphoria of the 1994 democratic elections in South Africa, its portrayal of a cycle of brutality and resignation as white dominance ebbs fueled yet more debate over Coetzee's political stance, or the lack of one.

By this point, Coetzee was a towering figure at his alma mater, the University of Cape Town, and had been on its faculty since 1972—but he was also an intermittent presence. He was in demand as a visiting professor in the United States, where he'd earned his Ph.D. 30 years earlier, and

he traveled a lot. He seemed eager to put some distance between himself and his home. I will mention that the university has a beautifully situated and landscaped campus, its classical buildings draped in a Princeton's worth of ivy. I discovered this when I dropped in on Coovadia, a tall man with a luftmensch air about him, as if his mind is always processing the unseen and unsaid—not exactly an obvious provocateur type.

In *Disgrace*, critics like Coovadia have seen an attempt to vindicate the white South Africans who warned that chaos would fill the power vacuum they were leaving behind. The African National Congress, the ruling party at the time it was published, attacked the novel for promoting racial stereotypes of the



Cape Town's stony beauty is rebuked by history: Beyond Lion's Head and Signal Hill, the frigid waters of Table Bay surround Robben Island, where Nelson Mandela was imprisoned for nearly two decades.

country's Black population. For Coetzee's acolytes, it can be seen as a parable about how the wages of colonialism spare no group. François Verster, a South African filmmaker at work on a movie about the writer, made the case to me that Coetzee's avoidance of race and ethnicity is designed precisely to subvert stereotypes—"a refusal to replicate the linguistic terms of apartheid power structures," much as the absence of scenery defies Europeans' habit of "reveling in and poeticizing the beauty of the lands they were stealing."

In my first, rapt reading of *Disgrace* decades ago, perhaps influenced by my history as a child of a failed totalitarian regime, I had felt depleted by the constant, horrific conflict between personal

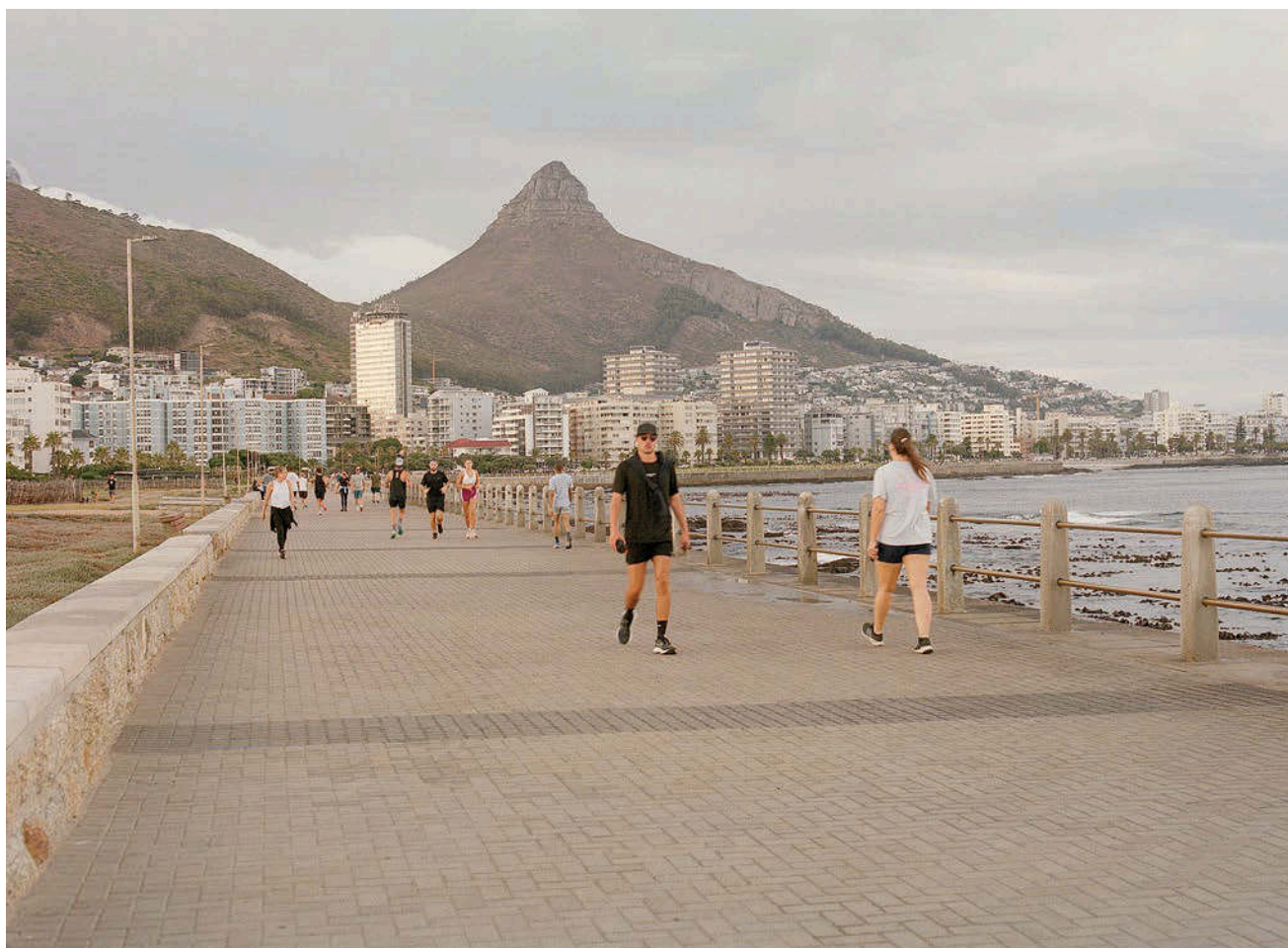
and political choices playing out in its pages. Now I couldn't help wondering what rereading the novel would be like—how would Coetzee's vision of a country's moral core under pressure and its institutions cracking strike an American these days? But I'd get to that later. For the moment, here I was in Cape Town, and I had traces of the writer himself to pursue in places I'd never been—places from which he'd always felt estranged.

I ARRANGED to take a trip with a true expert—"the dean of Coetzeeans," as Coovadia had called him. Hermann Wittenberg is an English professor at the University of the Western Cape, a longtime acquaintance of Coetzee's, and the editor of *J. M. Coetzee: Photographs From Boyhood*,

a collection of pictures taken by Coetzee as a teenager living in the Cape Town suburb of Plumstead. The chiaroscuro selfie on the book cover—the young Coetzee looking impishly ominous in the shadows—is jarring if you've seen Coetzee only on stately novel jackets. It hints at a more playful nature than the one to be found on the page decades later. (Some of Coetzee's acolytes tried to convince me that in addition to his many other talents, he is a funny writer; they are wrong.) Wittenberg has the grown-up version of the familiar Coetzee mien: slightly bearded, a bit awkward, hopelessly cultured.

South Africa's history, as I'd learned by now, has its share of intrawhite tensions, less warping than oppression along lines of color, but socially salient. According to the

The Sea Point Promenade runs alongside one of Cape Town's most affluent neighborhoods, an area portrayed as an abandoned shell under martial law in Coetzee's novel *Life & Times of Michael K*.



KENT ANDREASEN FOR THE ATLANTIC



Left: The classical buildings of the University of Cape Town.
Right: A statue of Nelson Mandela stands at the entrance to Robben Island.

rough archetypes that have evolved over the years, the Afrikaners, descendants of the original Dutch settlers, are considered more working-class and blood-and-soil in spirit than the British latecomers, who are portrayed as wealthier, more effete, and less tied in with the politics of apartheid.

Once asked what he would call himself, Coetzee answered, “A doubtful Afrikaner, perhaps.” His parents were both of Afrikaner descent, Wittenberg explained, and I knew that a farm in the Karoo, *Voëlfontein* (“Bird Fountain”), had been passed down by his grandfather to his paternal uncle. But Coetzee’s immediate family was somewhat distanced from that heritage, not least by speaking English at home—and he described himself as feeling particularly ambivalent, starting young. At school, he was more comfortable with the outsiders—Jewish and Catholic kids—than the Afrikaner students and teachers, who feature as bullies in his memoirs. In adulthood, he often seemed ill at ease in conventional social and cultural precincts—a man at the margins of the party.

“He can sometimes be difficult to engage with and doesn’t suffer fools lightly,” Wittenberg said. “He may

sometimes say abrupt things which don’t allow his interlocutor to save face. He has the strength of cutting right to the core, but for some people, this can sometimes feel antagonizing.”

I thought of Coetzee’s own gloss on his adolescent self in the interview included in the photo book. As a budding photographer, he’d been “interested in being present at the moment when truth revealed itself, a moment which one half discovered but also half created,” he told Wittenberg. At the same time, he recognized that he wasn’t attuned “to other people’s experience. I was too wrapped up in myself, which was not unusual at that age.” In *Boyhood*, another of Coetzee’s semi-fictional memoirs of provincial life, the young protagonist longs to be a “normal boy,” yet he also proudly stands apart from peers, whom he considers crude Afrikaners.

Nearly everyone I talked with, admirers of Coetzee or not, emphasized a kind of emotional remoteness. In *Summertime*, a former lover describes the Coetzee stand-in this way: “In his lovemaking I now think there was an autistic quality. I offer this not as a criticism but a diagnosis, if it interests you. The autistic type treats other people as automata, mysterious automata.”

In my conversations, a startling number of people quietly speculated about Coetzee perhaps being on the spectrum, and his fans sometimes spoke of him as a godly invalid or, if you want to go full Dostoyevsky, a holy fool.

By this point in our tour, you won’t be surprised to learn that Coetzee’s family story is an unsettled one—and that the places where he grew up have changed. His father held an assortment of jobs, and, despite having a law degree, he ran into legal trouble along the way (among other things, he embezzled trust funds). The Coetzee family “was marginally middle-class,” Wittenberg said as we headed for Plumstead, where the downwardly mobile arc of his boyhood landed him before he left home. “That’s why he had the ambition to succeed,” Wittenberg said, “and why he’s always been careful with money.”

We stopped by the Catholic school that Coetzee attended before university—a “last resort” for those shut out of the fancier private schools for the English elite. From there, Wittenberg drove us to where the Coetzees lived at the time, explaining that it had then been very close to a Coloured area, with halal

shops and a mosque; he pointed out the “cheap postwar housing.” What I could see of the Coetzee house, mostly obscured behind a sturdy-looking gate and fencing, reminded me of the kind of anonymous place my family lived in a few years after arriving in America; I suppose one could call it lower-middle-class but striving mightily. Coetzee had practiced cricket here, while his emotionally inaccessible father drank himself into oblivion.

In one of the photos that the young Coetzee took, his mother stands out front, a slight smile on her face, a dog in her arms—a snapshot of homey rootedness, in sharp focus: exactly what’s left out of his fiction. On our drive, I brought up

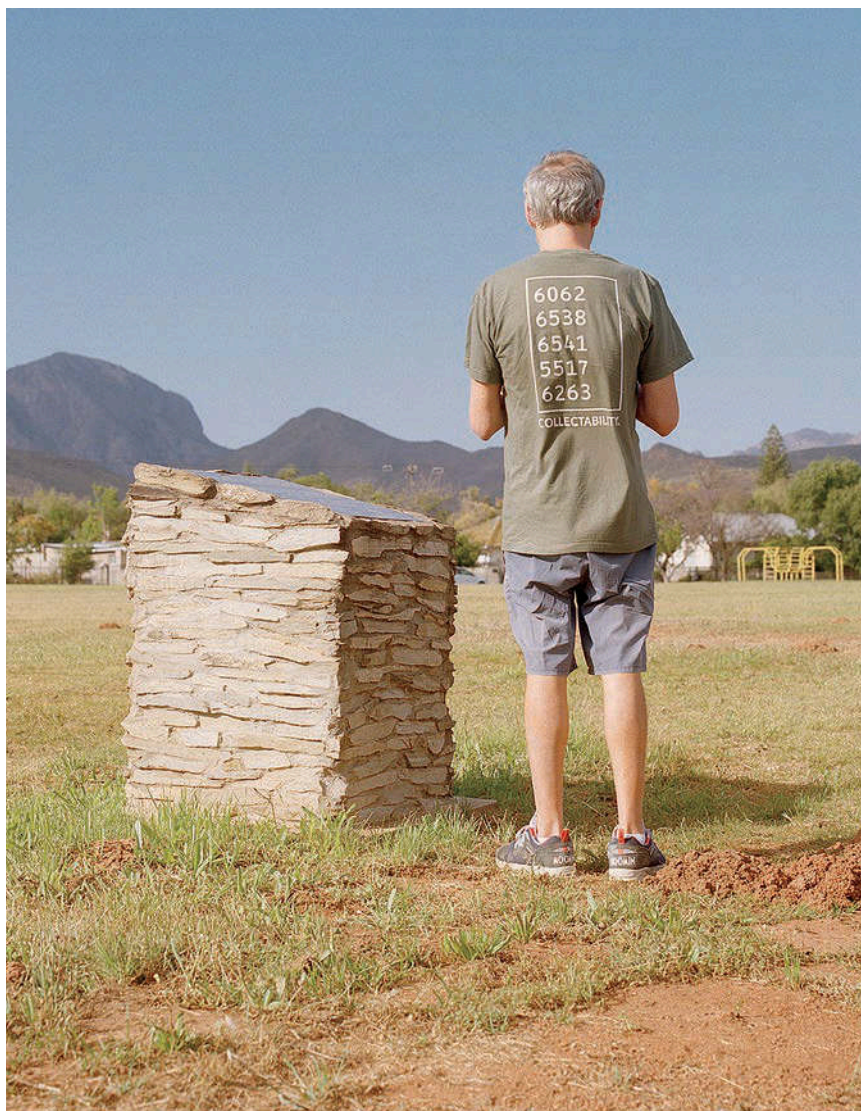
the way the entire region tends to hide in the deep background in Coetzee’s work. Wittenberg told me that Coetzee applies a kind of filter to the stunning landscapes provided by the city and its environs. He cited a character in Coetzee’s 1986 novel, *Foe*, an author who muses on “a ripple in the glass” as he gazes out of an attic window. This sense of a “distortion in the visual field” is key, Wittenberg said, to Coetzee’s “complicated realism.” Any strand of joy that a character happens to catch comes from deep within his mind, and is connected mostly to the intellect, sometimes to love, or, on rarer occasions—reaching across the divides drawn by colonialism and apartheid—to

an understanding of another human. For Coetzee the outsider, fiction dwelled in the interior.

FOUR YEARS before the Coetzees settled in Plumstead, the family interrupted their suburban existence and left the city behind. The preteen Coetzee was miserable when the family moved to Worcester, not far from where the Karoo starts. “After an hour outdoors there is a fine red dust in one’s hair, in one’s ears, on one’s tongue,” he wrote in *Boyhood*. “Worcester is only ninety miles from Cape Town, yet everything is worse here.” It was hard to say no to a ringing endorsement like that. So one early morning, I set off to visit this part of Coetzee’s past, joined by Andreasen and Coovadia. (Lest one think of Coovadia as a thoroughgoing Coetzee antagonist, he did tell me at one point that his former teacher “is still the greatest living South African writer.”)

The drive up to the Karoo was as beautiful as one could hope. Every few minutes, a new stage set presented itself: landscapes of increasing aridity backed by mountain ranges that fanned out into eternity, or poked up into ochre skylines, or presented as what the locals call a “witch’s hat.” If a small dinosaur instead of the customary baboon had dashed across the road, I would not have been surprised.

We stopped by a traditional *padstal*, a rural roadside farm stall crowded with kitschy examples of what Wittenberg had called “Boer chic”—wooden plows and the like. Dozens of farmers had gathered there for lunch, many in T-shirts that stretched over their monstrous torsos and celebrated various kinds of tactical weapons. I ate a springbok carpaccio that tasted silky with blood (this would not end well for me on a gastric level). Before hitting Worcester, we took a detour: Andreasen drove us to the so-called Gateway to the Karoo, the railroad town of Touws River, which he had been photographing for a project. We passed all forms of cinematic desolation: abandoned schools, sad-looking liquor stores (“Boredom in South Africa means drinking,” Andreasen said), salvaged train seats piled up on people’s porches. “This is the poorest town I’ve ever been in,” Coovadia said, although as a former Soviet I found the alcoholic vibe familiar: It felt like Russia with sun.



The author in Worcester, 90 miles from Cape Town, where Coetzee lived as a preteen and a memorial plaque now honors his literary contributions

We circled back to Worcester, which, after the poverty of Touws River, appeared to be a veritable Palm Springs, the main street bustling with coffee shops and wealth managers, though the dismal place that Coetzee described was not thoroughly transformed. The house he lived in is now a one-story ranch with a garage and a corrugated roof with a skylight. An old white man, aided by a walker, was ambling over to a woman next door as barefoot kids ran down the street and a dog barked and whined. (The boy in *Boyhood* stands out for always wearing shoes.) We rang the doorbell; no one answered.

But the view! Every time Coetzee left his *Boyhood* home, he'd be greeted by a mountain range—perhaps minor by Western Cape standards, but terribly impressive by anyone else's—that towered above the humble homes. A park in front of his house only heightened its grandeur. How did that not make it into Coetzee's work? Then again, postcard vistas are not selling points in novels about the core of existence—any more than a gift for mingling is to be expected from their author.

Later in the week, Coovadia threw a *braai*, or barbecue, at his grand but lovingly cluttered home in the suburbs, with an Afrikaner minding the lamb, which was charred to perfection and perhaps even tastier than its New Zealand counterpart. The expert griller presented me with a book in Afrikaans that traced 300 years of the Coetzee family's lineage in South Africa; he himself, he told me, was distantly related to the writer. A friend of Coovadia's, a woman of South Asian heritage, recalled her time at the University of Cape Town when Coetzee taught there. She mentioned, not without some pride, that her "ex-husband sold a bicycle to him"—and that "lots of people I fell in love with were Coetzeean fanatics." It was she who told me that whereas foreign students addressed him as John, "South African students referred to him as 'God.'"

I thought of how many parties and *braais* must have taken place in Cape

Town's southern suburbs over the years, in academic households such as this one, with the conversations focusing on Coetzee; some, perhaps, on his actual work, others on his aloofness, his love interests, his bicycles. In his essay, Coovadia writes that in the decades after apartheid, Coetzee became more than a writer to a contingent of Cape Town intellectuals. He became a religion, which made their African outpost a kind of mecca.

As my time in the city drew to a close, Andreasen and I rushed around town on

*The drive up to
the Karoo was
as beautiful as
one could hope.
If a small dino-
saur had dashed
across the road,
I would not have
been surprised.*

a scavenger hunt, list in hand of stray lines from Coetzee's novels that mentioned Cape Town's particulars. I began to realize that Coetzee hadn't been as unaware as I'd thought of the fact that he lived in one of the world's most beautiful places. "Cape Town," Lurie reflects in *Disgrace*, "a city prodigal of beauty, of beauties." Scenes crop up of sad seductions and near intimacies: His characters stare down from a height at one of the beaches below or struggle through a harborside meal in a picturesque suburb like Hout Bay. And, yes, as Lurie says during a class lecture

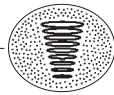
in *Disgrace*, climbing up Table Mountain can lead to "one of those revelatory, Wordsworthian moments we have all heard about."

Before I left the city, I met the author Justin Fox, a half Afrikaner who traveled along the route taken by Michael K for his book *Place: South African Literary Journeys*. "So many South African writers are bred of the Karoo, this ancient landscape where dinosaurs roamed," he told me at an L.A.-style casual restaurant by the waterfront, a kind of anti-Karoo. "My English roots are only 150 years old, but my Afrikaner roots are 300 years old, so the pull is deeper, and so I think it is for Coetzee."

In a public conversation last year in the Netherlands, Coetzee said that as he was "nearing the end," he felt more and more like an imposter when he spoke English: "I am a lighter—a more lighthearted—and a better person in Afrikaans." It might seem a strange thing to say, considering the leading role Afrikaners played during apartheid, and if *Boyhood* is to be believed, the young Coetzee had been panicked at the prospect of being consigned to classes taught in Afrikaans at school. I grew up speaking Russian and reading the classics in that language; now, given its political uses in the atrocities perpetrated in Ukraine, I shudder every time I have to speak in the tongue of Pushkin. Yet Coetzee's homecoming to his parents' language might well be a sign of his needing to reconcile with his origins, no matter how complicated they are.

"He has mentioned that he wants his ashes scattered on the grounds of his family farm," Fox told me. Does this mean that God in fact intends to return, if only in death? Fox couldn't say: "I've known him for 50 years, but I've never known him, because, in a way, he's unknowable." *A*

Gary Shteyngart is the author, most recently, of the novel Vera, or Faith.



CALEB'S INFERNO

By Caleb
Madison

Warning: This crossword puzzle starts easy, but gets devilishly hard as you descend into its depths. See which circle you can reach before you abandon all hope.

ACROSS

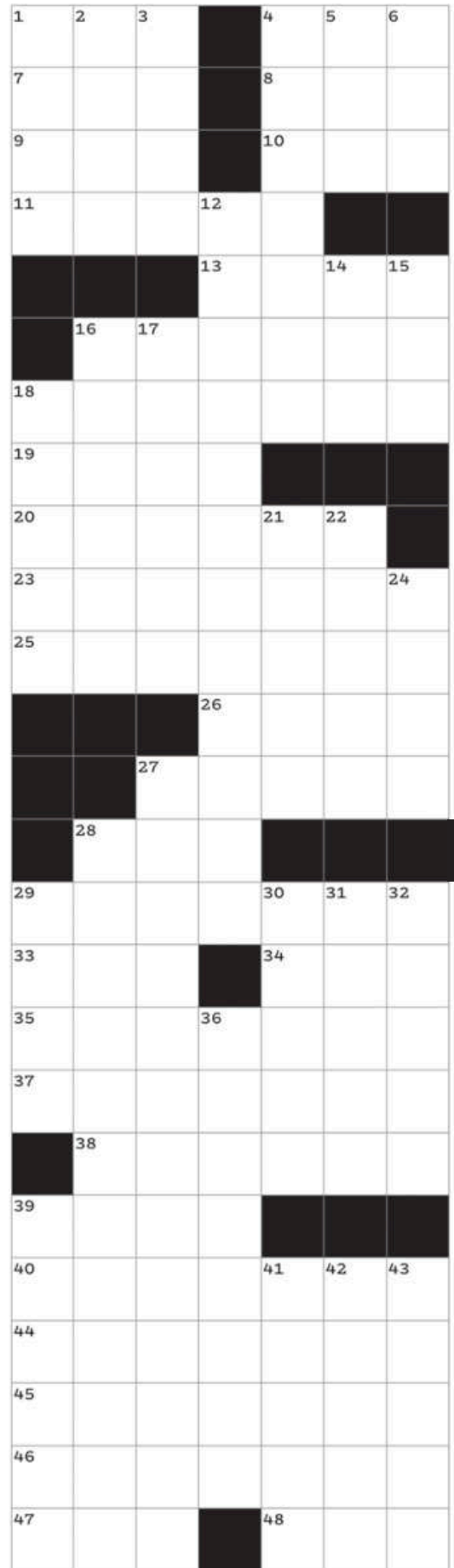
- 1 Futon alternative
- 4 Use the **+** button
- 7 Tool for splitting wood
- 8 School that's home to Manhattan's Tisch and Gallatin: abbr.
- 9 Hair goo
- 10 Matcha or pu'er
- 11 Genre for *Bugonia* and *Frankenstein*, familiarly
- 13 Name before Azalea or Pop
- 16 Made a smooth transition
- 18 Some Nevadan neighbors, unofficially
- 19 Humongous
- 20 Last syllable of a word, to a linguist
- 23 "Old Town Road" performer
- 25 *Prepare to repaper?*
- 26 "The thirst of youth," per Lord Byron
- 27 Socially mesh
- 28 ___ es Salaam (largest city by population in East Africa)
- 29 Handy tool for an artist
- 33 *Sculptura*, e.g.
- 34 Certain beat discipline
- 35 Sticks in the kitchen?
- 37 Connect with
- 38 Welles's *Citizen Kane* and *The Third Man* co-star
- 39 Dish whose name originates from the French verb meaning "to chop"
- 40 Illuminates
- 44 Like some security scans

FOR HINTS AND SOLUTIONS, VISIT:



TheAtlantic.com/inferno

- 45 "u feel me?"
 - 46 ___ up (vitalized)
 - 47 *KPop Demon Hunters* voice actor Daniel ___ Kim
 - 48 "Sound of da Police" rapper, to fans
- ## DOWN
- 1 Items in an overhead bin
 - 2 C-suite member, for short
 - 3 Place to order cold cuts
 - 4 Island whose name is Spanish for "ancient"
 - 5 Salon coloring
 - 6 ___ Lipa ("Don't Start Now" singer)
 - 12 With 36-Down, mirroring an enemy's tactics
 - 14 Demographic cohort, for short
 - 15 Stats for a QB
 - 16 *The Death of ___* (2017 black comedy about the Soviet Politburo)
 - 17 SoCal spot south of Pasadena
 - 18 Part of the palate
 - 21 Jacobin who was famously stabbed in a bathtub
 - 22 "Same!"
 - 24 Wolverine and Cyclops, for two
 - 27 Potentially frightening test result
 - 28 Internet aesthetic influenced by collegiate-Gothic architecture
 - 29 Onetime
 - 30 Frequent musical collaborator of Atticus
 - 31 *Pâtisserie* offering
 - 32 Electronics brand that has its origins in a miso storehouse
 - 36 See 12-Down
 - 39 True believer
 - 41 Like a wet signature
 - 42 Downer?
 - 43 Tireless travelers?



Protect what matters. **Secure all your guns.**

Don't live with the threat of family fire.
Learn how to make your home safer at
EndFamilyFire.org





HAUSER & WIRTH

LORNA SIMPSON

L.A., 2025

ON VIEW AT PUNTA DELLA DOGANA, PINAULT COLLECTION, VENICE, ITALY
29 MARCH – 22 NOVEMBER 2026